

Divine Guidance

Being a source book and guide to the Faiths and Religions within the Empire and a treatise
into the nature of Supernatural Power within and around Primus

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Introduction

The following Source book has been written with a strongly In Character point of view. Since I'm the person writing it its been written from the IC point of view of one of my own characters. The idea for the book is relatively old and dates back to the early days of *State of the Empire* when Watching-Owl achieved the post of Spiratus of the General Inquisition. The Department of Spiratus, at that time being one of the then nine departments that made up the Inquisition. Specifically the department responsible for monitoring the activities of the various Churches and Faiths within the Empire and supernatural threats to the Empire that were of a Spiritual nature. Not an easy task.

As part of those responsibilities Watching-Owl decided to create a Grand Register to document the faiths active within the Empire. Plans were put in motion and laws enacted to allow him to collate the information. This worked reasonably well, suffice it to say these original files were carefully gathered, collated and hoarded on a now extinct PC. Still with a copy of just about every Companion and Guild Directory since the start of the McManus Era I've been able to recover most of this information. Additionally I put out further requests for information. So all those faiths that sent in information have been listed.

There is of course the problem of secretive faiths. Those whose true beliefs and tenets are unknown outside their organisation. So as to fairly represent this there are sections added to these faiths that are made up of knowledge that only those initiated into the Church would have access to but they are listed here for a matter of out of character completeness.

I'd like to add my disclaimers now. Many of the faiths, especially the older ones, may be interpreted in many different ways. What is here is a write up of the generalised basis for the faith. Some such as St Michael and Elbereth for a long time had very little to obviously distinguish them. They even share the same miracle list.

Of course since their inception they have grown and changed. The effect of *State of the Empire* and *Heroes of the Empire* on helping to cement the idea of a pantheon with Deities responsible for specific aspects of the world has allowed further definition of these Churches but they are still quite extreme views within the Church and not all those views have been addressed but rather those that were presented to me when I asked for information regarding them. Or to put it another way I could only really write up what I was sent, so some Churches have long write ups but that's because large chunks of information were submitted, so if you feel that your Church is under represented take issue with your guild leaders ☺.

Newer faiths tend to revolve around a more precise and singular concept. The "Words From Above" rule book for Priests has also greatly helped in furthering this as newer churches have greater options for their basic miracle list allowing them to both be more varied from the older faiths and more structured in their choice of miracles from the start.

The concept of divinity was greatly expanded on in *Heroes* with the idea of different types of deities and levels of god-hood. Until the generation or uncovering, of the Primal Deities, depending on your viewpoint, gods were pretty much modelled on a very Monotheistic system. That is despite there being many deities they were unconnected and each existed as high up Omnipotent, Omniscient and Omnipresent beings in their own Heavens.

The events of the Namer War helped give the major gods, i.e. those who had a large number of PC priests and who were mainly goodly, a more coherent set of identities and form a pantheon. Naturally, as is usually the case with change, not everyone shared this view point but in the end it seemed to be generally well received and is now part of the ever expanding history of Primus and beyond.

Ian "BBB" Armstrong

Layout

The layout of the Church Guild information is quite simple and follows the general formula as below. **Name of Deity:** This is, unsurprisingly the name of the Deity, or in the case of churches that follow a pantheon, the most prominent of that pantheon. Not all faiths follow a specific deity and not all name or allow their deity to be named and in some cases the name of the Pantheon itself will be the choice of nomenclature

High Priest: This is the individual responsible for the religious rites. They are the mouthpiece of their deity and the highest temporal authority of the faith on Primus.

Avatar: The physical manifestation of the deity.

Guild Founder: This is the historical figure responsible for either bringing the faith to Primus or organising the faith into a Church. Sometimes the same as the High Priest other times the Founder has moved on, to another world, a Higher Plane or simply has not been heard of or seen in many a year.

Spherical Leaning: This is the nature of the Churches specialisation. Ranging from Healing, Benediction, Dismissal, Warding, Communication, Force, Dominion, Causing and Necromancy. A generalisation that can be

drawn is that older Churches tend to lack Spherical Orientation, whilst newly formed or resurgent Churches tend to specialise in one art, becoming a master of a specific form of miracle and fulfilling a niche.

Diametrical Opposition: Where a Church, Faith or Deity actively opposes another Church, Faith or Deity this is listed. Please note that this enmity is not always reciprocated. For instance the faith of the Raven opposes the teachings of Shaehan but the Church of Shaehan has no interest in "opposing" them.

Centres of Religion: Centres of religion are the places within the Empire where the church is relevant and prolific. Naturally such things are not static and change quite quickly but are correct at time of writing.

Symbol: Like any powerful organisation Churches have recognisable symbols. Whilst more commonly worn in heraldic fashion as a religious crest many fashion these symbols into three-dimensional representations, Holy Symbols, through which they may call the power of their deity.

Commentary: Some entries have an IC report on the perception of the Church / Faith or Deity. Bear in mind

An Ex-Lord Inquisitor

I am Watching-Owl, my name may be familiar to you. I have borne many titles, held many posts and been a man of influence and power within the Empire but as I write now the last comments on this tome I bear no titles, and wield no great influence, I am but a wanderer in the Lands of the Far North. Once again a simple Shaman, an explorer of mysteries and a servant of the tribes.

Be warned, for as you read there is much here that is only truth in as far as we can prove, truth only so far as we can perceive and truth only so far as we have faith. What is here is but a guide to the faiths of the Empire. For those who graduate from the Spiritual Schools and seek true enlightenment you would be advised to meditate upon your faith, call to your deity or speak with your High Priest and church's hierarchy.

My observations are just that, my observations, for all my perceived wisdoms and insights I am but a mortal man, and though many mysteries are opened to me by my arts

of divination there will always be the shadows at the edge of even my perceptions.

All references to The Final Dawn, unless specifically stated otherwise, refer to the specific period at the end of the second age, the last few days of IM999, now referred to as The High Final Dawn or Grand Final Dawn. A time of great upheaval. A period of time where the Senior Mennihaf declared Inquisitional Law and placed governance of the Empire in the hands of the Inquisition.

The entries contained within are all correct at the final creation of this tome, it is quite likely of course that over time the information will be superseded and out of date. For more up to date details one is recommended to consult the Imperial Journals. The Volksraad updates its information on a regular basis and changes to the laws and hierarchies of the faiths will be noted

Watching-Owl

Churches

Ancestral Summoning

Name of Deity: None
High Priest: None
Guild Founder: Kei-Ry
Centres of Religion: Thimon & Bildteve
Spherical Leaning: Necromancy

Prerequisites: Be a Lawful Evil priest.

Miracle List ~ Lawful Evil

1st: *Halt*
2nd: *Animate Zombie*
3rd: *Animate Skeleton, Protection From Spirits, Talk To Spirits*
4th: *Create Ghoul, Control Ghoul, Cause Disease, Cause Fear, Spiritbolt*
5th: *Create Mummy, Cause Grievous Wounds*
6th: *Summon Wraith / Wight, Control Wraith / Wight, Spiritual Mastery*
8th: *Animate Life (10sp)*

Ethos

The Church believes in formalised Ancestor Worship. In particular attention is paid to venerating the Dark Kami and Ancestors as through the varying arts of Necromancy the Church is able to communicate with the spirits of the dead and gain insight and understanding into many mysteries of the spirit planes.

The Church also believes that many powers possessed by the Undead can eventually be learnt and used by the living. The ability to paralyse one's foes in combat, to protect oneself by turning gaseous or to transport oneself from one plane to another are examples of such powers exhibited by the undead that could be learnt by skilled practitioners of the arts of Necromancy. The Church exists to study and teach such skills to those who would

learn them. The first step to understanding Undead and their powers is through their Animation, Creation and Summonation that they may be bound in useful servitude to the living.

The fear that many show for Undead is caused by a lack of understanding. Once they are understood then there is no need for fear, that is not to say that Undead should not be treated with caution, undead can be extremely dangerous, merely that once understood hostile undead become easier to destroy safely and the summoning and binding of Undead for useful tasks becomes possible.

Restrictions

No priest may leave the guild once joined, except by Rebirth or express permission of the guild Founder.

Commentary

Little history is known of this Church in the Empire, founded as it was in the Oriental lands. It was brought to the Empire by the Unholy Champion, Kei-Ry. Its existence as a Church in the Orient seems to be quite weak and there appears to be some confusion as to the age of the Church itself. However at this time the Church has broken no laws of the Empire and its small membership has caused its existence to be one of low priority by the Inquisition.

The Master of the Church is credited with pioneering the technique that allows a Necromancer to wear a Zombie as a protective covering against attacks that would destroy any other undead that are bound to them.

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Azrai

Name of Deity: Azrai
High Priest: Baron Ma'ar Saldana
Guild Founder: Baron Ma'ar Saldana
Centres of Religion: Thimon
Spherical Leaning: Causing

Miracle list ~ Neutral Evil

1st: *Cause Minor Wound, Power meld.*
2nd: *Cause wound, Damn.*
3rd: *Cause Serious Wounds, Protection from Spirits, Talk to Spirits.*
4th: *Cause Disease, Control Ghoul, Spirit shift, Communication*
5th: *Cause Grievous, Spiritual Invisibility.*
6th: *Walk Through Walls, Control Wraith.*
7th: *Suspend life.*
8th: *Touch of Death.*

Inquisitional Report

To: Spiratus Watching Owl
From: Inquisitorial agent Maxian Greensby

My Lord Spiratus,

Here follows my report into the emergent dark faith you asked me to investigate.

The faith follows a God of Blood and Darkness named Azrai. The results of my communications indicate this entity is the sole survivor of a Godwar on the plane of Cerilia that culminated early in the second age. The plane itself was apparently destroyed or fragmented at the end of the conflict and no longer exists per se. Indeed the precise location of the God Azrai at this time is a mystery I was unable to unravel. My investigations reveal that this growing faith is scattered across the empire, and at this time the only priest of any note is a visionary prophet by the name of Laton Voschilde, who has not been seen for the past year and more. The faith seems to consist of small groups widely scattered who are guided by priests trained by this prophet. I got the chance to quiz some of the faithful in Thimon, and even speak to a trained priest by posing as a potential convert. This is what I learnt

Date: 3rd Aipirus IM998

Their God is the father of Darkness, he rules the shadowrealm and night and winter are his times. He guards and protects his people from deep within the shadows, allowing them to walk without fear in the night.

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The second aspect of Blood was of greater concern and I devoted most of my efforts to that, as it seems to be the worst side of this faith. This aspect is Complex and lies at the core of their doctrine. My investigations have highlighted these major points:

They see blood as the representation of the power of an individual, this is oddly not a symbolic belief and they actually believe that blood is the source and repository of an individual's will. There is a strong aspect of family in the faith and ties of blood brotherhood. All true believers are seen as blood brothers once they have experienced full communion with their deity. This is, I believe, what appeals to some of the nobility, as for them rank and status flows from the sallow blood. There is a strong belief in inherited power, always diluted but reinforced by the actions of the sire, which has startling echoes to the sallow blood. Of greatest import is that this is a faith that spills blood for ritual and worship. This comes from three sources.

Primarily from voluntary acts, always by worshippers, for acts of faith, from any willing for ritual.

From those they call the forsaken, who have committed a crime that merits corporeal punishment or death by the wider communities law, the law of The Empire.

Finally the Baneblood, the blood of the enemies of the faith, those who have attacked them or against whom they enact vendetta.

My assessment is that whilst their use of and affinity for blood magic is concerning this power will not be turned against the empire unless we persecute them, and as they do not break our laws to practice such acts they are not the threat that other blood cults represent. Indeed if included in the 'family' of tolerated faiths they could act

as a formidable agent against such cults bent on destruction, and would in my view serve the empire as ardently as any if given freedom to worship, due to the fact that their doctrine automatically legitimizes the preeminence of the sallow blood.

The only point of concern I can see is that the priests and servants of the more militant goodly faiths may object strongly to their practices, and strife between them and a faith that venerates the empires nobility as divinely endowed, and with all the attendant attractions for such a group, could have severe consequences.

By my hand and seal,
Maxian Greensby
Spiratus Department
General Inquisition

Report Addendum Deebar IM 999: Baron Ma'ar Saldana has ascended to the position of high priest of Azrai.

Jonas Silasian
on behalf of the Imperial seers.

Holy Days

25th of Januar ~ Day of Cerilian Winter

13th Aipirus ~ Night of Deismaar

7th Jurple ~ Day of Cerilian Summer [Shadow Day]

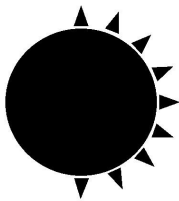
17th Septus ~ Fulcrum of Shadows

5th Novaus ~ Raseens Birthday

Major Exponents of the Faith

Laton Voschilde,
Baron Ma'ar Saldana (High priest).

Black Sun



Name of Deity: None
High Priest: The Minister
Guild Founder: The Minister
Symbol: Stylised black sun with half circumference covered with projected spikes.

Miracle List ~ Autarch ~ Lawful Neutral

For details of this list one would need to consult with the High Priest

Miracle List ~ Conciliator ~ Neutral Neutral

For details of this list one would need to consult with the High Priest.

Miracle List ~ Carnifex ~ Chaotic Neutral

For details of this list one would need to consult with the High Priest.

Ethos

Essentially an Apocalypse faith, it is the belief of the Order of the Black Sun that one day, sometime in our future, a Black Sun will rise, heralding the end of existence, and marking the beginning of the final battle between Good, Evil, Law, Chaos and Balance. On this day the spirits of the dead will be re-united with their bodies, which will rise and join the final battle. To this end the Order of the Black Sun believes that it is their duty to collect the bodies of those powerful enough to

deserve a place in the final battle, and care for them in their place of burial.

The Order of the Black Sun preaches religious tolerance very strongly and as such has no diametric opposition. Many gods have been interred within the halls of the Necropolis when their worshippers have dwindled, so respect for other faiths is paramount. The only practice that is frowned upon is the raising and summoning of Undead

Background

The Order of the Black Sun are the care taking priests responsible for the care of the Necropolis, the fabled City of the Dead, located on its own demi-plane. The Necropolis is an incredibly potent structure designed by the Ancients to house the dead shells of The Exostance's most powerful beings. Several pantheons of dead gods are believed to be interred within the city's gothic halls, having expired after their follower's died out or abandoned them. Alongside the gods rest the bodies of some of the most powerful Heroes, Villains, Tribal Totems and unique entities who have passed away following turbulent lives. Their bodies freely given by their friends and families to the care of the Order of the Black Sun, as they are renowned for taking the utmost care for the dead. The Order specialises in funeral practices and has vast libraries devoted to the treatment and care of the dead from all cultures.

Members of the Order are usually orphans taken in at

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early childhood, who more often than not have parents interred in the Necropolis. Usually the Order only numbers about 100 but recently the Order has taken in a greater number of initiates.

It was recently noticed by the hierarchy of the Order that fewer and fewer bodies were being brought in from Labyrinthia and its surrounding regions on Primus. It was decided therefore that one priest be allowed to leave the Necropolis, in order to act as the Order's Herald, spreading the message that the Necropolis welcomes all applications to intern bodies of the great and powerful.

Major Exponents

At the time of writing the Minister of the Black Sun is the only follower of this faith on Primus, acting as the Order's Herald. Only in truly exceptional circumstances would any others of the faith leave the Necropolis for any prolonged period of time, but this does not deter individuals from practising lay belief of this faith. Lay Believers are often referred to as Collectors, due to their habit of collecting dead bodies for

burial.

Commentary

The greatest point of interest about this faith is this: Where precisely do Priests of the Black Sun derive their power from? They do not worship a single deity or even a pantheon, nor do they claim to draw power from Spirits as a Shaman might, Angels as do some Hermits or even Demons as do others. So what remains? Within the halls of the Necropolis are kept the bodies of many dead, powerful beings, is it from these dead beings that they derive their power? If this is the case then how may power be derived from the dead? Which of course raises the question as to whether a god can truly die. Or perhaps the death of a god is a slow thing and whilst it no longer sends power to its devoted those of the Necropolis are able to weave their miracles from the fragments of myriads of dying deities. Whatever the answer may be it is another great mystery of faith and will no doubt keep great scholars arguing for as long as Priests wield power.

Watching-Owl

Border

Name of Deity: Border

High Priest: Robin

Guild Founder:

Centres of Religion: Mordred's Rest (due to former Lord Knights Moonglum, Robin and Feargal)

Symbol: A Crescent Moon

Spherical Leaning: Healing and Holy Warding

Diametrical Opposition: Thanatar

Prerequisites: Goodly aligned priests

Miracle List ~ Neutral Good

1st: Cure Wound, Detect Spirit's Nature, Power Meld

2nd: Cure Serious, Temporary Bless

3rd: Cure Disease, Detect Lie, Protection from Spirits, Spiritshield,

4th: Heal, Control Ghoul, Communication I

5th: Spiritual Invisibility

6th: Total Heal, Regeneration, Dismiss Vampire, Control Wraith

8th: Restore Life

Ethos

Border is a small church, mainly due to the very personal and family like relationship between its members and their Goddess. Each priest or Paladin, as Paladin's may freely belong to this church, has his, or her, own personal relationship with the goddess Border. You would need to speak to each individual member to find out their own personal views. There is not a view dictated by the church it is a choice of free will of the member themselves. The two most important things that the Church does believe in are "Doing what is right" and "freedom of will".

There are no dictates laid down by the Church, but rather each member has his own outlook on life. The Church principally advocates "*Doing what is right*" and "*freedom of will*" and there is no command from The Goddess that "*evil must be killed*" or similar, rather each individual will act towards another being or situation with regards for the greater good and what is most loving at the time.

Each member will view individuals or each instance as they would see fit and do what "was right" at that time. There is only one thing that Border hates, and that is Thanatar. Thanatari steal souls and memories, take away the concept of what makes a person, they destroy free

will. They are the enemy of the church of Border.

The Stealer of Souls: Thanatar is the enemy, and even though his priesthood is nearly extinct, those of the Church are still vigilant. Thanatar is the one thing Border hates, Thanatari steal souls and memories thus destroying the concept of what makes a person, freewill.

The priesthood of Border is very close knit, more like a family than a Church and because of this its membership has always been relatively small. Each priest has a very special and personal link with the Goddess Border and is within the church for those reasons, and everyone else is part of that family.

The Church of Border has always been martial, the majority of the Church being spirit warriors, paladins, battle priests and warrior priests, although with his recent Epiphany Ulric has chosen to tread a path of healing and tranquillity (though not a philosophical pacifist).

Owing to the fact that each priest has his own belief in Border it was decided recently that it would be inappropriate to have a High Priest to lead us in worship, but rather the Church elected a nominal head -Sir Robin of Border, to lead us in times of trouble.

Tenets of the faith

The promotion of "Good" through whatever active means the individual priest deems fit. The church of Border, this has never been a large faith. The founding members never desired political power and were always content simply to exist and Border herself prefers friends and disciples to worshippers. As a result, the small number of priests have become close, often referring to each other as brothers. The church also has strong ties to the Knights of the Land, as several of its most renowned priests are founding members of the Knights. The church today: still a small church, its members are virtually all retired from active life. Feargal can still be found fighting alongside the Knights of the Land, Robin is active in the empire on a political level and Moonglum recently returned to Border's side, perhaps forever.

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The tenets explained

Being a small yet diverse group, the priests differ wildly in the manner in which they 'promote good'. Border herself is content so long as her priests are doing what they consider to be their best.

Holy Days

Because Border is part of each priest and each priest is part of Her, Her power is spread evenly and so no day grants more or less power to our goddess.

Major Exponents

The Church of Border has always been martial, the majority of the Church being either Spirit Warriors, Battle Priests, Warrior priests or Paladins.

Sir Robin -Border's champion and current leader of the Church. Ex Lord Knight. Sir Robin of Border has recently ascended to sit beside the patron whom he loved so much. The Church is not sad for this however, as Robin has sent a construct created by the power of Imrazil and Border to fight in his place. This looks and behaves exactly like Robin though without Robin's priestly powers.

Moonglum -Border's Blessed Assassin recently faded helping to defend Primus. Although he has appeared to us in a new incarnation, little is known about him at the time. Ex Lord Knight

Feargal- Lord Templar, ex Lord Knight

Jarek Mace- an unliving Paladin, infused with Border's righteous wrath

Modius- A Spriaqwe Paladin, extremely gentle and the most selfless individual you could hope to meet.

Anna & Kat- Sisters and very competent spiritual warriors, sharing a bond so deep that it binds their souls. (known to many as the Border Babes),

Sir John Fitzsimand- A cavalier, recently sworn his first oaths as a Paladin.

Armand- A Defender of the Faith.

Ulric- Ex War Angel, turned healer and only priest not a Knight of the Land. Ulric was murdered by one of the Ratfolk and Border called him to Her side, thus preventing his return. Whilst there She worked changes upon him before sending him back to Primus, partly angelic, stronger of form and power. Ulric's form would have developed in time to become fully angelic but believing this route to be one that would strengthen his relationship with Border he forced the change before he was ready. This had the effect of granting him the powers inherent in a war angel whilst at the same time driving him insane. Convinced of his infallibility and the rightness of triumphing over evil with war and mace he spread the false word of Border. Luckily his friends Zak,

Robin and Sir John were there to cause him to question his path, and thus his infallibility. Realising that he could be wrong he prayed to Border and she lifted the "curse" of angelhood from him. Now Ulric works as an unarmed healer trying to mend the pain he has caused.

A Prayer To Border

"...Great Mother, from the depths I cry unto thee - a voice raised in supplication. Most holy Border, Goddess of Justice, Lady of the Moon, She of the Many Faces, the Dancer Alone, the Light in the Darkness, the Wanderer's friend I beseech thee to grant me grace such that I may further the cause of Justice and freedom..."

-Ulric, Border's Priest IM1002

Avenging Priests of the Crescent Moon

For some time the Church of Border had a Martial arm known as the Avenging Priests of the Crescent Moon.

Nowadays, due to the greatly militant nature of the Church's Priests, this martial arm seems to be indistinguishable from the faith as a whole.

Commentary

The Church of Border, as a Church, on initial inspection seems to have made little impact on the politics of Primus. However the names of its luminaries are well known amongst the Knights of the Land. Three Lord Knights have been of the faith of Border. The Knights and that which it has done for the Empire, Primus and countless worlds beyond has indeed been affected by its leadership and such leadership can only be considered to be down in at least part to Border.

Whilst ready to fight the fight the Church of Border does not appear to throw itself in the fore but brings support where needed and has the appearance of a more thoughtful and tolerant approach to the problem of *Choice and Evil*.

It was the Church of Border that had the quickest resolution to the Namer War. Sir Robin understood the nature of the War far quicker than any other of the High Priests and chose the same course of action that I chose as Lord Inquisitor: To do nothing. The refusal to act instantly ended the Namer Paradox for his faith. Such shrewdness should never be overlooked and whilst Robin himself has left Primus to return to his mistresses side it is expected that the Golem known as the Heart of Robin, will continue act with all the knowledge and foresight of his demon slaying creator.

Watching-Owl

Cabal



Name of Deity: Bhaal (known *only* to initiates)

High Priest: Count Fade Raban Di'ablo

Guild Founder: Bane Diablo

Symbol: A Pair of Daggers

Centres of Religion: Deci & Bildteve

Miracle List ~ Evil

1st: Cause Minor Wound, Taint Spirit, Spirit of Seeing, Remove Rune of Power,

2nd: Spirit of Seeing and Hearing, Stasis

3rd: Cause Serious Wounds, Talk to Spirits, Protection from Spirits

4th: Cause Disease, Create Ghoul, Paralyzing Touch, Communication I, Spiritshift

5th: Cause Grievous Wounds, Spiritual Invisibility, Voice of

Power

7th: Suspend Life

8th: Communication II

Tenets of the faith

Power through Stealth, Intrigue and Murder. It is the duty of the priesthood is to send as many souls to their lord, be it by consecrating dead bodies or through ritual sacrifice or simple Murder in his name! This cult, **note not** the open faith, aims to gain power and influence in the mortal realm, be it in business, government, nobility to infiltrate all levels and gain power and wealth within the infrastructure. It is the duty of the faithful to gather wealth as wealth is power and to tithe the church while still accumulating personal wealth.

Divine Guidance

History

The cult started on Primus via an Assassin, Bane Diablo, also a priest of Condesecration a servant of the Lord Waste. During his career he discovered a Demon Lord, one Bhaal, who's power rivalled that of many gods and who's sphere of power dealt in stealth and murder, Bane made a pact with the demon that in exchange for souls he would be granted power. In this manner Bhaal became the patron of Bane, not his god but a patron who exchanged souls for power. Over the years Bane's power grew as an Imperial Officer and Bounty Hunter until he became the head of the assassins guild of Primus, The Grandfather of Assassins, who's power of life and death over those with the ritual conditioning was total. With the passage of the years his body was changed until he became a Cambion demon. His body warped by Bhaal's power, during this time the knowledge of Bhaal spread and it attracted a few others in the mercenary community, those of a like mind who looked to a patron "not a god" and followed in Bane's Footsteps.

The Cult actually required the death of its founder to come to fruition. Bane met final death at the hands of Orientals and his soul was claimed by Bhaal. He spent time at Bhaal's feet as one of his favoured servants, and because of the way Bhaal had changed his form to that of demonkind he was not truly dead, just banished from Primus for 101 years. But Bane chaffed that his time had been cut short so Bhaal made a pact with him that he would allow him to possess those of his blood line and interact on Primus via his offspring, with the one stipulation that he form a religion, a cult who actually worshipped Bhaal rather than just trading with him in souls but this church must remain hidden with the masses believing it just a simple cult of death dedicated to funeral services and sending the dead on their way and not the true cult of murder. Thus was the Cabal born and so the word spread first in Deci. It spread slowly

outwards and so the word entered the world of the drow who now saw a power as other than just their Demon Queen.

The Modern Church

The church today has gained much in power and has had influences of world shaking proportions with links to other demon lords it is the strongest it has ever been. Many are the Drow who now serve Bhaal over Loth, many are those, who have taken the guise of demonkind in the search for power in Bhaal's service those who are not even of the priesthood but scouts, assassins and those who deal in death and wish strength in their endeavours. The Church controls, to all intents and purposes, two of the empire's settlements to differing degree's Deci and Bildteve and has had a hand in some of the most prominent mystery deaths of the decade!

Holy days

As not a open faith unable to have a official holy day , but a festival is held each year on the final day of Octuar, called the *Day of the Dead*. This festival is huge in Deci and most of the city's inhabitants are involved, whether they wish it or not...

The Tenets Explained

To follow the high priest words as though they where from god himself for he sits at his right hand and see's all! Blood and souls, wealth through stealth, power, power for Bhaal and self but in the shadows or the servants of light will find us and light up the shadows ...always stay to the shadows!

Important Note

In Character there is no connection between the cult of the Cabal and Bhaal only those who are members of the cult are aware of this and only those with Vitae are initiated into the inner circle who know the true secrets.

Condesecration

Name of Deity: None
High Priest: Treare
Spherical Leaning: None
Diametrical Opposition: None
Centres of Religion: None
Symbol: None
Pre-Requisites: Evil Priest

Miracle List ~ Neutral Evil

1st: Halt, Spirit of Seeing
2nd: Cause Wound
3rd: Cause Serious Wounds, Talk To Spirit, Protection from Spirits, Spirit Shield, Curse
4th: Cause Disease, Spirit bolt, Control Ghoul
5th: Cause Grievous Wounds, Voice of Power, Spiritual Invisibility
6th: Control Wraith
7th: Suspend Life
8th: Touch of Death

Ethos

Martial priest are the majority, as even though the war was many years ago those without a spirit are still seen as *The Enemy*, therefore it is advised that if you are a weaponless priest you gain access to ways of dealing with creatures without a soul.

The church's power is now gained from the evil within men's hearts. In the eyes of the church spiritless creatures have no heart therefore no power is gained from them. Killing peons is frowned open as this reduces the church's

power, of course sometimes there is no other option and sometimes we do it because we are evil...

History

First he was nothing but a lowly Unholy Champion by the name of *The Grinning* but as his power grow from rites and rituals. What was once The Grinning choose the name that we all grow to love or Fear... Lord Waste...

In a different place Lord Waste ruled with an iron fist, the dark lord and his nine generals laid waste to the world and were at constant war with the Elven lords.

The priest's of Lord Waste where bought up to be skilled in the martial way as well as the spiritual way, as spirits are no good against an elf but a cold iron mace did the trick therefore it is rare to see a weaponless priest in the worship of Condesecration although not impossible.

The war raged for many years and Condesecration had several high priests in that time but there was always one that followed his master's word, never swaying, never turning from his masters path...and when the gates to his world started to crumble it is he that left and ventured into a brave new world.

After many attempts at finding a replacement to gain his power from, the servant realised that he did not need a god, there was enough evil within the hearts of man to gain powers from.

Divine Guidance

So moulded into the church that once was, With a new found fire within what was left of his heart Treare the Ghoul Priest rose from the ashes to form the new Church of Condesecration, no God would ever tell him what to do again and as his old and truest lord once had maybe Treare would rise to be the voice that all others heard...

Holy Days

20th Januar Shadow Day ~ Shaedwaith

The lowest part of the year for priests of Condesecration, so far from the True Holy Day of Virnaroth, powers have faded and will not renew for some time.

10th Maii High Holy Day ~ Gelnaroth

The celebration of the day on which Troy, thereafter called Turncoat, formed The Love of God, which would eventually become the Church of Condesecration.

10th Octuar Shadowday ~ The Sorrow of Loss

The day where priests of Condesecration remember the closing of the gates and being cut from their master, Lord Waste.

20th Jurrle High Holy Day ~ Virnaroth

The celebration of the Ascension of Lord Waste, original patron of Condesecration.

17th Orgus Holy Day ~ Kelnaroth

The celebration of the day Lord Waste ordered Jon Shannow to call the Love of God Condesecration.

Commentary

Once a great and feared faith it seems now all but forgotten amongst the mercenaries of the Empire along with its dead god but beware as there are some things that should not be forgotten.

Watching-Owl

Cult of the Eternal Vampire

Name of Deity: None

High Priest: Unknown

Guild Founder: Unrecorded

Spherical Leaning: Necromancy

Diametrical Opposition: Mortai

Miracle List ~ Lawful Evil

1st: Detect Spirits Nature, Power Meld

2nd: Animate Zombie, Temp Curse

3rd: Animate Skeleton, Protection From Spirits, Spirit Shield,

4th: Create Ghoul, Spirit Bolt,

5th: Create Mummy, Voice of Power, Cause Grievous Wounds

6th: Summon Wraith, Spiritual Mastery

7th: Suspend Life

8th: Summon Vampire

Commentary

This Church has never been strong in the Empire. It is little more than a cult. Followed by those driven by the Simple belief that Vampires are the highest form of Unlife and unlife the highest form of existence. They serve the Vampiric spirits of undeath and hold them sacred. They will never harm such except in self defence and would often, it is said, rather die as a willing victim of a Vampire than bring harm to one. Naturally the dark Vampiric spirits have little care for those who venerate them and such attitudes have resulted in a Church that has small well known membership.

Watching-Owl

Cult of the Smith

Name of Deity: None

High Priest: Grand Master Smith Leto

Guild Founder: Leto

Spherical Leaning: Communication

Centres of Religion: Halgar

Symbol: Hammer and Anvil

Miracle List ~ Neutral Evil

1st:

2nd: Cause wound

3rd: Cause serious, talk to spirit

4th: Cause disease, Create Ghoul, Paralyzing Touch, Spirit Bolt, Communication

5th: Cause Grievous, Spiritual Invisibility

6th: Control wraith / Wight, Walk Through Walls

7th: Suspend Life (free)

8th: Communication II

Prerequisites: Must be a priest that is able to wear armour bar the Guild Leader who must be a Pure Priest. The Church is known to have a hierarchy from apprentice up to Grand Master. Your tier must be signed onto your card by the guild leader.

Ethos

The church is built around the knowledge and skill of the forge. This is a highly secretive organisation with a strict hierarchy.

The guild is first thought to have been founded a few years ago in Halgar and it is there that they still have

their main place of worship. Unsurprisingly enough this is a large forge in the merchant quarter.

The Church is not believed to follow a specific deity and rather gains it power through knowledge and spirits it has at its control.

The membership of the Church is solely from those from the Smithing profession a skill they carry on in the Church in the forging of spiritual artefacts.

History

The church was formed from the application of knowledge. This knowledge was gained through the study of an art that lies all around Primus and is part of almost all people's lives, but is understood truly by only a few. That art is the art of smith craft.

From the dawning of civilization people clawed wisdom and knowledge out of the very rocks. They learnt how they could blend the force of fire and the strength of rock to give them more, a new thing, metals. The wise men that lead the way forward were the smiths. It was the smiths who learnt to turn the very world itself to their wills to grant wondrous new things to the people of Primus. Using *Fire*, ore from the *Earth*, *Air* to char away impure metals and to feed the fire and *Water* to cool quickly and quench their creations. Smiths brought things into the world, objects of power and durability, things that were strong.

Divine Guidance

People held smiths in great regard and their goods were always in high demand. Even now with many of our tools widespread and crafted in massive numbers, smiths are still essential to the way this world lives its life. Whilst produced metal is found far and wide, the knowledge of true smithing is still secret, even after all this time. The odd peasant may be able to make a shoe for a horse, but who can make a sword fit for a warrior? Who could make intricate locks to keep treasures safe and bars of iron to keep enemies from breaching a city's gates? The answer is few, a precious few, yes the knowledge is still hidden.

We are smiths. We are users of secret and hidden knowledge that has not been lost, no, many over the centuries have built upon it, but it has remained in our hands, in the hands of wielders of smith craft. There are true smiths in the land who know the ways to bend the physical world to their will, using the powers of metal.

We, however, are more. We have transcended the level of smith craft held in Primus. We are not content to learn how to build a mill, to re-channel rivers, to make mighty creations of beauty and weapons that cut through leather as quickly as they cut through cloth. We have learnt to craft not just the physical world to our will, but have acquired the knowledge to turn the spirits around us and of others to our designs.

We have brought together the ancient wisdom of the shaman together with the skill of the smith to form a new craft, one that will supercede both. We have learnt to bend spirits to do what we demand, be that to infest the body of a dead man, or to serve in a weapon, so that other spirits may be slain.

This is just the beginning of what we shall teach you. You shall begin your training as apprentices, sometimes it will be hard, there will be much labour and learning, but it will be worth it. Some of you will become Journeymen, some, perhaps, even more...."

Part of a speech delivered at a meeting of the Church, sometimes Cult, of the Smith, overheard by agent [Name removed for Imperial security] IM1002.

Report reads as follows: The Church appears to conform to a rigid hierarchy. On emergence some members of the Inquisition suggested that this may even be a Black Guild, however after close inspection of their rites and the miracles they utilise, it was decided that this is not the case. The church is very secretive, but it has been discerned that the rank structure is as follows: Apprentice, leading to Journeyman, leading to Master. There is, at present, only one known Grand Master, a man called Leto, living in Halgar. It is unknown whether there are others, or even if there are allowed to be more.

The church uses its powers mainly for the purpose of creating spiritual objects. It also uses evil miracles, many of which are undead related. The church's has an open headquarters in the Imperial capital.
Report ends.

Commentary

To the eyes of the mercenary community, which in the majority of cases is pragmatic, a dark cult simply dedicated to making spiritual artefacts is of less concern than one engaged in dark acts of Necromancy, Terror or domination over the innocent. As such one would expect such a cult to feel less threatened and less inclined to secrecy but like many Churches and individuals that have the power of Divination there is a tendency to secrecy. Secrets gained are valuable and often hoarded and it may well be for this simple reason that the church is so closed mouth about its membership. Not to mention that secrecy in itself lends an air of power.

Of course such secrecy could simply mean that the Church does indeed have many dark secrets of its own...

Watching-Owl

Dark Deliverers

Name of Deity: Unknown
High Priest: Zardos the Unliving
Guild Founder: Unrecorded
Spherical Leaning: Warding

Miracle List ~ Neutral Evil

1st: Spirit of Seeing, Halt
2nd: Control Zombie
3rd: Spirit Shield, Protection From Spirits, Talk To Spirits
4th: Spirit Bolt, Communication I, Create Ghoul, Cause Disease, Rune of Power, Paralysing Touch
5th: Minor Ward of Power

6th: Summon Wraith, Spiritual Mastery, Level Drain
8th: Major Ward of Power

Notes From Zardos The Unliving

We are the hunters of the night, we seek our pray within the realms of darkness, seldom seen but often heard. We are hunters, loyal to our own and aid those who have pledged allegiance to us at all costs. We are what nightmares are made of, we are the hunters of the night, our motto: **Death is just the beginning.** Join today. We can open a world of opportunities to you...

Dead Heroes

Name of Deity: Milora
High Priest: Arius De'ville
Guild Founder: Amora De'Ville & Gustav Thorenstein
Centres of Religion: Halgar

Pre-Requisites: Priests of Dead Heroes may be of any alignment as this represents the fact that the church has many, many heroes it follows and they are of different alignments. Outlaws may not join without the council's permission and outlaws may not remain without the council permission. No member of the church may act against the Empire as it is the current belief of the church

that the Empire is essential and central to existence. All members must be from Primus and people from outside the Empire may only join with permission of the council.

Ethos

In our past hundreds and thousands have died defending both the Empire and Primus from threats and conflict. Some have died willingly, many of the vitae infused heroes, and others less willingly, the soldiers of the armies of the Empire. As such these people responsible for our existence today should be remembered and their names and stories passed from

generation to generation. Further more, when times are troubled who better to call upon for aid or advice than those that have been there and done it before?

The memories, powers, knowledge and strength of the dead heroes can all be called on by the faithful who cause the dead to be remembered. Finally in the darker recesses of the church when other solutions fail there are those priests willing to call back the spirits of the dead to once more fight for Primus and the Empire.

It should be noted that the general ethos of the church is pro existence, pro primus, pro empire and vaguely on the whole heroic and doing the right thing for people. Various priests within the church have more specific roles - keepers of knowledge, tellers of stories, raisers of the angry dead, channeler of the spirits of aid, communicators with the knowledgeable dead etc.

Anyone, with the Guild Master's permission, may join as a lay believer if they are both from the **Empire** and **Primus**. Again due to the nature of the church alignment is not relevant. People belonging to other churches or who worship other deities may not join. Outlaws may not be lay believers in this church without permission of the council.

History

For many many decades the church was quiet, one monastery in the mountains near the southern border where monks kept records and stories of the dead, various noble houses sent their youngest sons to join the monastery as a sign of respect for its work and once in a while legions would take up the religion as their own. This changed when the battle of Rothril killed the two oldest sons of House De-Ville and this tragedy caused the madness and then death of the their father the then head of House De-Ville Anton. With no other male of inheriting age available Amora De-Ville was called back from the Monastery where he had spent the last decade as a priest and the religion was once again introduced to Noble, Military and Mercenary circles.

With the work of the then Warlord, Gustav Thorenstein, promoting the religion, the then Magistrate of Halgar, Jonquil Masters, work, the Death of Amora De-Ville and the appearance of the god Milora the aged council of the monastery of the Church of Dead Heroes have decided it is time for its priests to go out in to the world, spread the word of the dead and find new Heroes to immortalise.

The Tale of Orgay and Omgay

This is not the first time that the demons that plague the men of the south have sought to come north of the mountains, for their lust for our land knows no bounds.

Now, in the Dark Baronies, there are those men amongst the rulers there who would treat with the demons and allow them land and treat them like men. They are not men, they are demons, who would destroy us if they were strong enough. We of the Empire have never bowed to them, nor granted them land and it is our land, and our homes that they truly crave for they are much more bountiful and much more beautiful than the dismal swamps and dark woods of the Baronies. Why, there are even lands in the south where the sun never shines!

Now, Omgay and Orgay were brother and sister. They lived before there was an Empire, but they lived in the lands that would become the Empire, at the foot of the Brandins. Their village has long since turned to dust and its name is forgotten, but I know that it lay at the end of a narrow pass, which ran through the mountains. That pass is still there and the demons do know of it still.

Now, Omgay was a woodcutter and his sister Orgay also. Omgay stood tall and proud, his limbs strong from long and hard toil. His sister was ruddy cheeked and strong of back. Still, she was beautiful, but her beauty was the strong and honest beauty of the girl who toils in the fields. Many men courted her, but none found her favour and brother and sister lived together in the sturdy cabin that had been built by their father when he courted their mother.

Now, times were hard and too little firewood and cut planks were sold by Omgay and Orgay for both of them to work in the forests. So, Orgay went alone into the pass whilst her brother cut wood to hunt and trap the wild goats that lived there so that they would have meat to eat and perhaps, if she was lucky and skilled, to sell.

For many months Orgay hunted in the hills, a few days at a time, between each trip returning to the sturdy cabin and bringing with her each time the carcasses of goats. She did well in her hunting, for few had the courage to walk the high crags of the Brandins, which are treacherous and cold.

One day she spied a terrible thing. In the pass, she saw demons. Dudoins, arrogant creatures who believe their demonic tricks make up for skill at arms and a stout heart and strong sword arm, huge Grutuuck and, behind them and leading them the cowardly Blauz.

Orgay knew the mountains and she remained out of their sight and travelled quickly, leaping from high rock to high crag like the goats she hunted, back to the village. Here she met Omgay and told him what she had seen.

Omgay knew what to do immediately: "We must gather the people and go into the pass and there, where it is narrow, we must fight the demons. The old folk and children, they can stand on the high crags and hurl rocks down upon them and thus we will drive them back and be safe."

Now, you might be thinking, 'Where is the army?' Now, I have to tell you that in those days there was no Empire, but there were many of what were called 'magiocracies' who fought, not with men, but with rituals of great destruction. Certainly, they had some soldiers, but these defended only those places of import to the corrupt rulers. Now, with the Empire, we have an army that stands to fight for all the people, but in those days little villages like that of Omgay and Orgay had to fend for themselves.

So brother and sister went into the village and told them of the coming of the demons and what must be done. Both were astounded at what they heard and what they saw. Some of the people there gathered up their chattels and fled, others cowered in their homes and bolted the doors and hoped the demons would not come. The hope was futile, of course, for no bolted door will stop a Grutuuck and they love to destroy the houses of men so they can erect their own foul cities upon the ruins.

The names of these villagers do not matter, for they are dust, whilst Omgay and Orgay are remembered."

Omgay and Orgay despaired and talked between them of fleeing and perhaps hiding in the mountains. But they did not, for they were and are heroes and, though they were as afraid as the others of their village they would not give up the cabin their father built for their mother.

So, Omgay took his axe, and Orgay took hers also and they headed up into the pass. Orgay picked a narrow

Divine Guidance

spot, wide enough for his great blade to swing, but only just, such that when he swung it sparks flew from the rocks on either side of him. And there he stood, and waited.

Orgay went up into the crags that overlooked the pass and made her way along them, leaping from one to t'other until she spied the demons making their way along the pass.

Now, the demons had not come far from where she had first seen them, for demons are quarrelsome and while she and Omgay failed to rally their village, one Blauz had murdered another and two Dudoin had fought a duel in the manner of their people. The fighting of the Dudoin involves much talking and then, when a fight does begin, a great deal of hissing and pulling of hair, in the manner of young girls.

But with this foolishness over with, the demons advanced and, though there is much foolish about them, the demons are no weak foe. The Dudoin are fast and live to fight, the Grutuuck mighty thewed and the Blauz cunning and malicious.

The army of demons filled the pass, which stretched through the Brandins as far as a man could walk in tow long days of hard march. And still, where the pass entered the south, there was a great camp of the creatures, waiting to enter.

Now at the front of the demon army, arrogant and dressed in stolen finery, was a Dudoin. He was what they call a rovuqr, who think themselves the best in battle and more skilled than any other. He wore a great hat with feather in it and his face was striped in black and orange. For all his foolish appearance, he was a victor of countless battles, both against his own kind and against the murderous men of Schtoy.

He saw Omgay, a simple woodsman, standing in the pass and laughing, drew his sword and moved forward, the legion of demons at his back. The Dudoin lunged, but Omgay knocked his blade aside with a sweep of his axe and the Dudoin had to jump back. Again and again the creature attacked, each time he was repulsed, but each time he leapt back away from the axe of Omgay.

Then the Dudoin said to those behind him 'I cannot strike this man, come forward and we will slay him together.'

But Omgay had been clever, for he stood where only one could fight him, in a narrow part of the pass. So the demon lunged forward to attack Omgay again and was once more parried but, as he jumped back to avoid the swing of the axe the demon was undone, for his call for help had made the others crowd in behind him and he had no space to retreat. The axe of Omgay bit deep into the Dudoin's side and he stumbled and fell, half cleaved in twain.

But the demon reached out as he lay there and touched Omgay as, as he did so, the strength fled Omgay's body and he felt weak and his strength flowed into that of the creature and healed his wounds. But Omgay was not to be daunted and stamped down on the head of the demon and then crashed his axe into it such that the demon, for all its vile tricks, was slain.

The name of the Dudoin does not matter, for it is dust, while Omgay and Orgay are remembered.

But Omgay was weakened by the touch of the creature such that he could barely hold his axe and the demons

before him were pushed forward by the demons behind *them* and, sensing his weakness, they fell upon them.

Omgay, hands numb, parried the blows of those who sought to slay him, but had no strength to strike back. He fought on, but he would soon die.

High above him, though, was Orgay and she put her back, strong from the woodcutting, to a great boulder and pushed it, such that it fell into the pass and crushed the demons that assaulted him.

Given respite by the acts of his sister, Omgay was able to gather his strength once more. The demons were cast into confusion and delayed, until a great Grutuuck thrust forward, crushing those demons who could not find a crevice to lurk in to avoid its passage. Huge it was, such that it filled the pass, its shoulders brushing the cliff on either side.

Now, Grutuuck are wise in the way of stone and this one more than most. It took its great hammer and struck the rock such that the rock flew into pieces. The air was thick with stones from the exploding rock and these scoured Omgay, such that he bled from a thousand wounds and his flesh was cut and sliced from his body.

Omgay fell to the ground, dead. The great Grutuuck strode to him and spat upon his body and then went to step over him.

But we know already that there is more to Omgay than there is to other men and Omgay refused to let death stop him. He was no mercenary, always with an ally ready with candles to bring him back to life and make his heroism meaningless. Candles and chants to far off gods are no use to men like Omgay, like us.

Omgay rose, his flesh gone, nothing but bones and his axe. That axe he took and, from his place on the floor, he struck the Grutuuck between the legs, such that he cleft his balls one from the other.

The name of the Grutuuck does not matter, for it is dust, while Omgay and Orgay are remembered.

Then Omgay rose and, though he had no spit to spit with, he stood over the bleeding bollockless corpse and cried 'I am Omgay and you shall not pass this place!'

Now the demons, seeing their strongest slain and a dead man crying defiance at them, took tail and fled.

And Omgay stood resolutely in the pass, where he stands still, and no demon shall ever pass him."

And what of Orgay? Well, she was consumed with a great rage for the loss of her noble brother. I say 'noble' for, while he was not noble by birth, he most certainly was of spirit. Orgay followed the fleeing demons, leaping from crag to crag and raining rocks and pushing boulders down upon them. Some tried to come up into the rocks after her, but none could match her skill in the high places and one and all they fell screaming to their deaths.

For two days she did this, until the demons were back in their camp and thought themselves safe. Little did they understand the power of the wrath and hatred of a sister for her dead brother!

That night Orgay stole into their camp. The demons travelled with their families...for the demons have children and wives in order to better mock the customs of normal folk...but she left these well alone.

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She took her axe and as they slept she slew first one demon, then two more, then five and then ten until fifty demons lay dead in their beds.

The names of these demons do not matter, for they are as dust, whilst Orgay and Omgay are remembered.

Now, the demons stirred and one caught her as she was about her work, her skirts thick with the blood of demon kind.

This demon was a Blauz and these creatures are strange in that they are very fearful. So fearful are they, that they can put all their fear in a great scream and, because no man has ever been as afraid as a Blauz can be, a man or woman who hears it may feel compelled to run.

Thus the demon screamed and Orgay fled, consumed *by the fears of the demon rather than fear of the demon itself*. As she fled, she was struck a cowardly blow in the back and, though she had overcome the fear of the scream, which she did quickly, unlike the Blauz who screamed which could never overcome its fears, she left the camp and headed for the hills, to nurse her wounds and come back when healed to wreak havoc in her brother's name once more.

But the Brandins are cold and harsh and Orgay sore wounded. There, high in the hills, she died alone, frozen, her skirts still blooded, a smile frozen to her lips in pleasure at the vengeance she had wrought. No demon killed Orgay though, only the hills took her life.

But this was not the end of Orgay for she, like her brother, was filled with purpose. No priest who twitters of the spirits of light heralded her return, no far off god of unseen face brought her back: Orgay returned because she willed it thus.

The next night, Orgay, still filled with the cold of mountains, fell upon the demon camp. This time, no blade could touch her and if she fled at the mewlings of the Blauz, she soon realised it was their fear, not hers, which drove her away.

Wherever she went, her axe spread cold and death such that, by the time she had finished, winter had come early the camp of the demons and not one remained alive, be they man or woman or child, each frozen in death as Orgay had been.

There names do not matter, for they are dust, whilst Orgay and Omgay are remembered.

Time is a fickle thing and Orgay and Omgay were forgotten. There are those whose duty it is to remember these things when others have forgotten them and such a duty fell to a small monastery of the Church of Dead Heroes. There, my high priest Arius told me the names of these two heroes and, through arts taught to me by my brother, Milo, I was able to speak to these two forgotten heroes.

Omgay and Orgay are not gods. They were, and are, a brother and sister. They were not mages, or priests or great warriors, but common people of uncommon courage.

All of us will one day die. Some of our names will be dust and some of our names, like those of Orgay and Omgay, will be remembered.

Commentary

The "Schism" of the Church of Dead Heroes is one that is quite of interesting. Almost universally amongst the Priesthood the very existence of the Primal Deity Milora is ignored yet the common soldier and the common Peon seem to look up to him. In retrospect this is hardly surprising. The appearance of Milora as a deity is very recent yet the Church, in its monastery, has been around for quite some time. The memories of the peons hardly matching that of the Church's scribes and Lore Keepers.

True to the apparent nature of Primal Deities Milora can take on many forms but he seem to appear to his followers in the guise of fallen comrades. Even his name appears to be a concatenation of "Milo" and "Amora", two dead heroes. It is said that two Deities of the Church arose in existence at the same time but there was insufficient belief to keep them as separate entities and they melded to give rise to Milora. These two entities were from completely different ends of the social strata:

The first was Milo. Milo was a peon pikeman who died at the Battle of Amora's Doom. Along with many of his fellow slain he was raised as a Ghoul by the combined ritual power of the Baron of Feldrachen Isle, the Liche Ashgaroth and the knowledge of the Rosarian Dark Scholars, to further fight against the Baroinal invasion. After time the control wore off and he wandered the lands for several years before his ascendance.

The second was the Lord of House De'Ville, Amora De'Ville, Noble of the Blood and one time Custodian of Primus. Lord De'Ville heroically fell in battle with the Middlesmith Vexathaccor during the events of the Throne of Wood Crisis.

The Church is one that seems to enjoy strong support amongst the Nobility of the Empire and the higher echelons of Imperial Society as a whole. In fact fearing the strength of the faith of St Michael amongst the ranks of the Legions, the then natural choice for the common soldier, Warlord Thorenstein strongly supported the growth of the church amongst soldiers. This eventually reduced the hold of the Church of St Michael on the Empire's military.

This strong support by the Warlord for the Church in turn lead to the misconception, by Mercenaries, that the Church of Dead Heroes was about Soldiers who died heroically. Not so, for the death of any in dire circumstances for a cause is the essence of a Hero.

Watching-Owl

Disciples of the Bright Lady



Name of Deity: "The Bright Lady"
High Priest: Frater Placido
Guild Founder: Frater Placido
Spherical Leaning: Healing
Centres of Religion: Bildteve & Halgar
Symbol: An Ankh

Prerequisites: Goodly aligned, non-weapon using Priest.

Miracle List ~ Lawful Good

1st: Cure Wound, Summon Candles

2nd: Cure Serious Wounds

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3rd: *Cure Disease, Protection from evil spirits, Talk to Spirits (with the same restrictions that a goodly aligned Pathed character has.) Healing Hand, Bless*

4th: *Wound staunch, Heal*

5th: *Angelic Shift*

6th: *Total heal, Spiritual freedom Armour of Purity **

7th: *Instant Regeneration*

8th: *Restore life*

NOTE: All miracles on this list are goodly aligned.

**Armour of Purity: 6 spirit miracle as Spiritual Invisibility, verbal: "Blessed spirits I pray thee, shield thy servant from the realm of spirits!"*

Ethos

The disciples follow the "Bright Lady", the nameless aspect of all that is love and healing, they preach love and succour, and believe that all sentient creatures have an equal right to life, Undead and Supernatural evil beings are people too! On the other hand we should respect the free will of free beings to fight each other, if it is truly wished by both sides, intervening in such cases should be handled very carefully, attempting to persuade rather than to force.

Notes From Frater Placido

Headquarters: A large converted townhouse near the docks area of Bildteve, in what was once a rich area but now exists in poverty and disrepair. The house, which dates back to the times of the magiocracies, was purchased with the limited funds of the guild several years ago and has been rebuilt and redecorated from it's run down state to support living quarters for the priests of the order, various small shrines and medical facilities. The living quarters are obviously of limited capacity, and most of the Disciples live in private residences scattered around the city. They live a simple, communal life, and the townhouse carries with it a strange air of being separate from the hustle and bustle of the city, an aura of peace, perhaps a holdover from the early monastic practices of the group.

Day-to-Day Activities: Though the core activity of the group is mystical exploration and spiritual practice, the day-to-day activities for the average Disciple could be seen as being disappointingly mundane. Typically the craft skills of each Disciple are used to their best to produce materials that will be of use both to their community and to the poor and needy of the Empire. So a carpenter might make furniture, a baker make bread and a weaver make clothes. Those that have no craft skills, or those who are done with their work might work with the less fortunate in society, distributing the Disciples' surplus and lending what aid they can.

Spiritual lessons are held in an open daily format, with those who are wise in a discipline teaching others who will listen. The practices are a mixture of shamanism and mystical spiritualism, focussing on channelling the powers of Harmony and the ancestors of mortal man.

Supernatural Patrons: The Bright Lady / The Spirit of Harmony plus countless ancestral, shamanic and house

spirits. The guildmaster also propitiates the Golden Drake, and those few Disciples who have interests in the magical path also predominately use golden magic.

Membership: Several hundred priests and lay members, plus their families, mostly in Bildteve but also with a small presence in Port Miere and travelling across the Empire. The nature of the Disciples is too extreme for most mercenaries and the powers granted to mercenaries not strong, so the mercenary membership is extremely low, at this time low enough to name individually. In practice, most mercenaries who feel the call of the healer's path join less restrictive churches that are more focussed upon the mercenary way.

Purpose: To make life as enjoyable as possible for as many people as possible, by teaching them to remember the world as it was before it was devastated with the power of Separation.

Why was the guild formed? The founder of the guild found that his personal beliefs had evolved away from the mainstream of his previous faith, and felt the need to find his own path. Having done this, he spread his beliefs to all who would listen and follow him, forming the church upon tenets and teachings that were fundamental to his personal beliefs, though trying to adapt them for more general understanding.

Holy Days

20th Februar Holy Day ~ Day of Awakening

The day on which Frater Placido was "born", a day of contemplation, illumination and rebirth

Commentary

This Church was formed by Frater Placido, once of the Church that is now Shaeahan. A man of special conscience Placido felt that the ways of Shaeahan, whilst pacifistic, to be too accepting of the violence. Few would claim to understand the difference between a Priest of Shaeahan and a Disciple of the Bright lady and often the Bright Lady is simply confused with Shaeahan.

It is apparent that the followers of this Church are tied more to the concepts of Mercy, Healing and Light rather than into following a specific deity. Placido himself will point out that *The Bright Lady* is really a term given to name that which has no need of a name.

I admit that I too have some difficulty in understanding the nature of the Church and am less qualified than some to comment on it. To my mind perhaps the simplest way of understanding the Church when comparing it to Shaeahan is to say that it does not believe in destruction but rather construction. As a faith it focuses on addressing the problems rather than just patching it up. This of course is a somewhat unfair on the Church of Shaeahan but the wielding of weapons of some description by those of Shaeahan is not unknown, where as I have never known a follower of the Bright Lady to do such a thing.

Watching-Owl

Dunatis

Name of Deity: Dunatis

High Priest: Bane

Guild Founder: Dara

Diametrical Opposition: In Dispute...

Miracle List ~ Neutral Evil

1st: *Cause Minor, Summon Candles, Halt, Spirit Of Seeing*

2nd: *Cause Wound*

3rd: *Cause Serious Wounds, Curse, Talk To Spirits, Spirit Shield, Protection From Spirits, Repel Life,*

4th: *Cause Fear, Cause Disease, Spirit Bolt, Rune Of Power, Communication*

5th: *Cause Grievous Wounds, Spiritual Invisibility*

6th: *Walk Though Walls*

History

The church was started approx nine years ago and Dunatis is the god of pain and suffering. Therefore death is an anathema to those in this guild as it prevents pain and suffering. This does not mean that those who worship Dunatis have to like suffering themselves, though this is not frowned on. It means that they must live to inflict suffering on others. Elves and the like are disliked as their ability to feel pain is often less than that of humans. The first high priestess was Dara though very early on in the church life there was dissent within. There was an attempt to take over the church at which over half the members were slain by Dara. She then took refuge in a Shaeahan temple, as they prevent death and, in her eyes, prolong suffering. The Church of Dunatis was taken over by Bane who remains the head of it to this day. Dara is no longer in the church, though will preach her version of Dunatis's will.

Ethos

Dunatis is the God of Pain. He both creates and feeds on the pain of the world, physical, spiritual and mental (psychological). He is an evil deity due to the fact that people across the world experience suffering and anguish due to his existence and actions, and the deeds of his worshippers. He and his followers would argue that the pleasures of life would lack their lustre if there wasn't any pain to compare them to... the comparison between highs and the lows of mortal experience being the joy/interest in life. Therefore some people believe their worship of Dunatis to be a neutral faith, and feel they get misunderstood by their fellows. However, he *is* a dark malevolent God who has grown to derive pleasure from the pain of others and thus all his worshippers bear the taint of evil on their souls. For all the arguments that you need pain to truly enjoy pleasure, a world without pain would be one step closer to nirvana/heaven, and thus the faith is bringing the world closer to the experiences of Hell.

As this is quite a vague and esoteric faith with few rules and formalised modes of worship, there exists great variety within the Church about beliefs, which has led to schisms in the past. Some believe that undead and elementals are abhorrent abominations in the eyes of their Lord due to their inability to experience pain, and thus seek to remove them from existence, at least on Primus. Others see that the end justifies the means and tolerate the summoning of undead to use in the cause of worldwide suffering. Some view the healing miracles of the goodly Gods and thus the existence of their churches to be essential to the world and thus the Dunatic faith, as they allow for more and fresher pain to be inflicted once the old wounds heal, again its about the comparison.

Others view the cause of Dunatic worship to be the bringing of the world into a Hell-like state of suffering where no wounds are ever healed, pain is stacked upon pain, where psychological torment is heaped on top of the mental anguish of the last experience. The 'Dara/Bane Schism' occurred at least in part due to a proposed alliance with the Church of Shaeahan. Some consider that faith to be an ally, after all they have been known to summon spirit swords to attack the undead! Others see them and the Disciples of the Bright Lady as their diametrically opposed faiths.

Core Doctrine

Whether they disagree on many of the other aspects of their faith or not, all Dunatis worshippers are united in their belief that Death is the enemy of them and their divine patron. A slain victim suffers no more, as not all return on the wheel of life, rebirth. The killing of

people should not be undertaken lightly. If it is an excruciating demise and allows for more pain to exist within the world, for Dunatis to feast upon, *e.g. the survival of the priest himself*, then a priest's sin of slaying somebody could be forgiven. Many priests of Dunatis say prayers of confession, accompanied by flagellation, at each day's end for those they have released from the suffering of the world that day. Quick and random slaughter is a excommunicable offence.

However, as their devotion is rewarded with power, priests of Dunatis can learn to beat death by gaining access to the spirits of their slain enemies. Archbishop Bane for example can send those he has killed to the Pit of Pain, a terrible pocket plane within Dunatis' realm, to suffer an eternity of torment, or until rescued, for his master's pleasure and amusement, or he can twist their spirits dooming them to wander this mortal realm as a pain wraith (not undead) bound to do his will.

So if they have any directly opposed faith it is the worship of Death, the black void of nothingness at the end of life. Like the Church of Dunatis though, Death's worshippers are few and scattered - preventing any Dunatic crusade against them.

The Faithful

Some worshippers of Dunatis can barely call themselves priests, as following in the ways of their Lord can simply mean living a life that brings pain and suffering to all those around them. Dunatis cares not if they are devout, if they observe what ceremonies and rites still exist. He simply asks that they continue to cause and create pain in the world.

Some fanatical priests turn themselves into living altars to their Lord, preferring their own self-mutilated anguish to be their offering to their God, in return for power. Others are simply bullies who grew up to realise that if you are the one doing the inflicting of pain then you have the advantage over someone. They then found out about a God who would grant them powers, help them to hurt others, a God who wanted them to be who they naturally are, as opposed to being told to mend their ways by the goodly faiths. Others are twisted individuals who simply need to serve and find Dunatis an easy master to please.

All manner of backgrounds can lead someone to a worship of this deity, and all manner of viewpoints exist about what worshipping him actually means or requires. This vagueness is perhaps what has stopped a unified Church from forming in the past. The mystery surrounding the Cult's belief, to outsiders, is perhaps also what has saved the Cult from a war with one or more of the goodly faiths.

The Church Hierarchy:

The Celestial: The Lord of Pain, our God, Dunatis. The Cause of Suffering.

His Avatar of Anguish:: Tu'kar. Master of Torment

Archbishop Bane: Archangel of Agony, General of the Unholy Host

Many Angels / Demons / Spirits of Pain / Torment / Suffering / Excruciation / Hurt etc.

The Mortal: Supreme Leader of the Church of Dunatis (formerly Cult) Kalraith

Many scattered priests, believers, bullies, etc.

The Words of Dara

Dunatis came to be when the first thing came to awareness and will only cease to be when the last mind dies. He is often misunderstood, even by those who claim to follow his guidance. I tell you this as the first, the one who was called first to represent his ideas on

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this plane. Those that follow, indeed those who now claim to speak with his voice, do not understand his true desire. Do not listen to their works. Dunatis is there to show people the glory of life, for without pain life has no meaning. In death you can no longer feel the warmth of his touch, and so should be avoided at all costs.

As such when I guided the church it was allied with Shaehan, as they promote life, and prevent death, without which Dunatis would not receive so much worship. For

every time someone cries then Dunatis is praised.

Therefore worship Dunatis with all your heart, but do not follow those who lead at present, for it is my belief as the first that they are not true followers of Dunatis, and will mislead you. Go with knowledge of this, and you will do well.

Dara
The first to be called.

Elbereth



Name of Deity: Elbereth, Lady of the Stars
Guild Head: Boukephela Starkadder
High Priest: Basil Jack of Stars
Guild Founder:
Centres of Religion: Gothiel
Symbol: Eight Pointed Star

Prerequisites: Goodly aligned priests

Miracle List ~ Neutral Good

- 1st:** Halt, Cure Wound, Detect Spirit's Nature, Power Meld, Spirit of Seeing
- 2nd:** Cure Serious
- 3rd:** Cure Disease, Talk to Spirits, Spiritshield, Protection from Spirits, Bless, Dismiss Ghoul
- 4th:** Heal, Spiritbolt
- 5th:** Dismiss Wraith, Voice of Power, Spiritual Invisibility
- 6th:** Total Heal, Dismiss Vampire
- 8th:** Restore Life

Ethos

Elbereth, Lady of the Stars, is the Goddess of Light, Beauty and Joy. In the words of the current guild leader: *"Those things that make life worth enjoying, not merely enduring"*. Until recently, the church in Labyrinthia directed much of its energy towards destruction of the Void God, but now that that end has been achieved, they have had a chance to step back and return the faith to its earlier roots.

Because followers of the Lady of the Stars must offer their whole-hearted love and devotion to the Lady, no individual who draws spiritual power from any other source or patron may claim membership of the Church of Elbereth. Any priest of the church who in some way acquires another spiritual patron must either reject that patron and their power **utterly**, or else leave the church. The only exception to this rule is followers of the other Valar, since the Lady is the representative of that pantheon upon this plane.

Tenets

The basic tenets of the faith following this period of recuperation and reassessment are now laid down as follows:

First: To respect life, and the right of people of good heart to enjoy that life. Most people, the Church would say, respect this and live peacefully with their neighbours. Those who do not, but rather take a delight in cruelty or the subjugation of others should be dealt with by whatever means necessary, as by denying the rights of others to live in peace they have forfeited their own.

It is the duty of those of the faith to actively defend the rights of the defenceless and as such must be prepared to risk their own lives in the service of those less able to do so. Mercenaries, after all, have vitae and the church contains many priests capable of restoring the fallen.

Second: Malicious creatures of undeath are the antithesis of life, and as such should be disposed of swiftly. Those who summon them are torturers of souls and should likewise be stopped with as much force as is required.

Third: Regarding other evil beings, the present leadership of the guild would urge members to consider using diplomacy and reason before violence, and attempt to dissuade them from following that path and turn to a better one. If this fails, then the anger of the Church, and its military wing the Templars of Gilthoniel must be swift and thorough. Theological disagreements between members of the church tend to involve the question of how much of a chance those of evil soul should be given before the sword is drawn, but agree it is wrong to let the forces of evil do their works unhindered.

Fourth: Beauty as a concept both metaphysical and literal is important to the forms of Elberethian worship, whether the beauty of an ideal or the literal beauty of art and nature. Members of the church are expected to appreciate art and learning; and whilst not expected to become artists themselves, though some do, to respect those that are, and not be wantonly destructive in their actions.

The faith is particularly strong amongst Elves, as the goddess was first worshipped by these folk. However, membership is open to those of all races who embrace their ideals and has included dwarves and even orcs. The will to follow the Lady can be found in all races that can see and rejoice in her light.

The heart of the church is in the fortress temple of Gothiel, a former castle on a high crag in the Heartlands around which the holy city has grown up, with smaller shrines in most other settlements of the Empire. Members of the clergy are requested to try to visit Gothiel at least once a year in order to maintain their links with the church hierarchy and ensure that they are not confused by lack of guidance in matters of scripture.

New PC priests are always recommended to contact the mercenary guild head for more information and assistance.

Notes from the High Priest

The centre of Elbereth's faith in these times is the city of Gothiel in the Heartlands of the Empire, a shining temple city shielded by the Lady's power from the presence of Evil. However, there are proponents of the faith throughout the Empire, and priests and worshippers are encouraged to travel widely, so that the Church may become aware of any matter that might concern the Lady Elbereth.

Modern Church

Elberethian Edict 19/2/3: The official leadership of the Church of Elbereth does not consider the church part of the Circle of Light, as the Circle's ethos dilutes the

religious certainty that should be the focus of a priest's life. Church members who are currently part of the Circle of Light are not obliged to leave at once but are asked to reconsider their membership of this guild and withdraw if possible.



Holy Days

15th Januar Shadow Day ~ Winter Barrows Opening

A day when traditionally the wights and undead who lie still for the rest of the year become restless and strain at their bindings

10th Februar Holy Day ~ Sharing the Bounty

Elbereth encourages her followers on this day to share their bounty with those in need - the preceding four weeks lead up to a day of sharing and feasting.

26th Maii High Holy Day ~ The Birth of Elven Worship

The day, as believed by contemporary Priests of Elbereth, that the first elves who turned to Laby Elbereth found her love. It is a day to re-affirm the strength of Elbereth's care for elvenkind and the support she shows for elves.

15th Juon Shadow Day ~ Summer Barrows Opening

A day when traditionally the wights and undead who lie still for the rest of the year become restless and strain at their bindings.

24th Orgus Holy Day ~ Celebration of the Constellations

A day to prepare for the nights celebrations of prayers and joy to the stars.

19th Novaus Holy Day ~ Turning of the Stars

A time when the most stars can be seen in the heavens at night; it is a day of worship and dedication of service to the Lady Elbereth.

History

Many years ago, Aardran Van Helsing brought the religion of the Lady of the Stars, and the concept of an elven pantheon to Primus. Amongst the first Labyrinthians to heed his words (as far as we know) were Random, Tarquin Starchild, Quentin Tremayne (also known as QT), Flash the Paladin, Abdul Nadir, and Doc Holiday, though many more flocked to the Lady's name.

He brought back this religion from a far off world, and unfortunately they also brought with them, as well as the attention of the Lady of the Stars, the attention of

Morgoth and his dark servants. Morgoth was trapped in the Void during the naming war by a force of the goodly gods, but he continued to try and thwart the Church of Elbereth's growth and worship in Labyrinthia.

For many years the church of Elbereth fought the minions of Morgoth, many times beating back the forces of He-who-Dwelt-in-the-Void. During this time the church grew in numbers and strength, the word of the lady spreading throughout Primus, people taking up worship of the Lady of the Stars, the graceful and beautiful, the shield of light against the darkness.

The Church also fought off threats from the Namer pantheon, which resulted in Grace, the Namer aspect of Elbereth, being trapped in the void. Finally she combined with Elbereth to form 'the lady of the stars', who destroyed Morgoth in the Void, while the Church destroyed Morgoth's primal aspect with their allies.

The church's numbers have diminished in recent years, at least within the mercenary community, though the founding of the City of the Stars, Gothiel, has strengthened the Lady of the Stars, and many people in Primus respect and look to her for support.

Gothiel ~ The City of Stars

The heart of the church is in Gothiel, a former castle in the Heartlands around which the holy city has grown up, with smaller shrines in most other settlements of the Empire. Members of the clergy are requested to try to visit Gothiel at least once a year in order to maintain their links with the church hierarchy and ensure that they are not confused by lack of guidance in matters of scripture.

Gothiel, as a settlement, is relatively new - the temple was a baronial keep, later a bandit fortress and for a few years a stronghold of the Church's martial wing before the city was built up around it.

At the heart of Gothiel is the Temple-Fortress of Elbereth on top of a crag, surrounded on three sides by the river Windrush. This crag connects via a neck of high land to a range of hills, and settlement has grown out across this neck of land and down into the river valley over the past few years. There is a local saying that there's no such thing as a level street in west Gothiel - just that some have less of a slope than others.

Other Notables of the Church

Aelsowen, Alexandre du Mas, Almeric, Calel, Calondiriel, Esseran, Forlorn, Garren Blackhand, George, Gozmo, Guy, Harley, Icondor, Ignatious Loyala, Jerran, Levicticus, Lorthandel, Nexus, Paraquat, Regal, Scooter Smith, She Who Has No Name, Sir Hersce, Sirac Drakeson, Sun-Child.

Elbereth - A Personal View

There are three major deities associated with 'good'... Shaeahan the Merciful, the Healer; Michael the Warrior and the offensive; and Elbereth...

As I see it Elbereth is the Light in the Darkness, the shelter in the storm... The Elven peoples have always stood by and watched, and defended those that needed it. Elbereth wishes to see light and beauty flourish, but on Primus it is not her role to do this by going out and murdering everything 'ugly' or evil. Instead, her role, and the role of her church is to offer shelter to those good souls who wish it. Hence Gothiel, a city dedicated to protecting the good from the evil around them...

It is not the place of the servants of the Lady of the Stars to hunt down and exterminate all evil. Rather we are the

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guardians of light and beauty in a world beset on all sides by darkness. It is the role of the Lady and her followers to offer aid where we can, to offer a shield against evil, a light in the darkness.



Some may choose to do this by hunting down and killing those that directly oppose the church and who seek harm to those of a light soul. Others see themselves as healers and protectors of the innocent. And there are many other roles that people see themselves in, while still serving the Lady of the Stars.

However, all these people are unified by the Church and by their desire to defend those who cannot defend themselves from evil, and their desire to see beauty and light blossom where only darkness and evil once was....

In other words, Michael is the offensive who goes out to eradicate all evil, Shaehan is the healer and the merciful, and Elbereth takes up the third role of the defender... at least on Primus and in Labyrinthia.

Eldias
Field Commander
Templars of Gilthoniel

Lost Salvation

Name of Deity: This Church follows an ancient pantheon referred to simply as *The Old Ones*

High Priest: Visionary Guild Father Crysalis

Guild Founder: Crysalis

Spherical Leaning: Communication

Diametrical Opposition: None

Centres of Religion: Gileenim

Acting Guild Head: Khardan whilst Crysalis is on his dream quests

Miracle List ~ Lawful Evil

1st: Detect Spirit's Nature, Spirit of Seeing, Halt, Cause Minor

2nd: Spirit of Seeing and Hearing

3rd: Talk to Spirits, Protection From Spirits

4th: Spirit Bolt, Communication I, Create Ghoul, Cause Disease, Spiritshift, Paralyzing Touch

5th: Cause Grievous, Spiritual Invisibility

7th: Spiritual Mastery, Suspend Life

8th: Communication II

History

The church comprises a number of people who have seen the truth, and know that the dark powers of old will soon return and reclaim the plane of Primus for themselves. When this happens, the races that scurry on it's surface like ignorant insects will be erased and the surface wiped clean, the better to serve the unknowable purposes of the Great Old Ones on their return. However, in the preparation for this time, the Great Old Ones are sometimes willing to lend a little of their great powers to mortals present on Primus, in exchange for prayer or other services...

Members of the Church of Lost Salvation accept that for all intents and purposes the end of the world is coming, and in many cases such a bleak and despairing viewpoint has left them a little unhinged. They do not seek to prevent this, and none but the most deranged think that there is any chance that they will be spared as favoured, this is not the way our Masters' work.

As such, they may as well spend their remaining days laughing at the unenlightened and drawing power from the Old Ones, to use it as directed or simply as they choose. Most times the masters have no more concern for our acts than we would for a flea in another country but very occasionally they will notice some act or deed which interests them for cryptic and esoteric reasons, and then they may require us their servants to act.

It should be remembered that there are many Great Old Ones and beings of power, and only a few at this time show interest in the prayers of our priests; many others bear us no interest, or even enmity for serving those we do. Our pantheon of seven currently bear each other no ill-will, but the behaviour of these creatures is beyond our prediction, and at any time this may change.

The Church's words must be carried far to reach those Great Old Ones who choose to return our prayers. These beings do not rest close to our world as do the new gods of the sheep of the Empire. Very early on the Church found that the best way to achieve this was to bind our spirits together and let the strength of each worshipper work with every other, increasing our strength beyond the sum of our parts.

Foolishly, the Empire's bureaucratic system saw fit to declare this form of worship outlawed before ever we had taken any action. The guild have never acted against the Empire, and indeed acted to divert a terrible other-worldly threat to it at the High Final Dawn. Nonetheless, although the high priest and the other members of the Church who could be called adventurers have been 'pardoned' by the Empire, though for what crime was never clear, the Church itself remains an outlawed faith. Another example of the spinning, toothless cogs of the Empire's government, but it matters little, for the church have no interest in the machinations of the Empire, and act as they see fit regardless.

NB: It should be noted that although the Church is loosely based on the works of HP Lovecraft and other Cthulhu mythos

Divine Guidance

writings, there are bound to be differences between written texts and the way the concepts are interpreted in LRP.

Commentary

What do the Church of Lost Salvation seek? A most interesting question as they seem to be unique in their desires. Most followers of a faith are dedicated to a few simple predictable aims: The spread of The Word, drawing power for their deity or simply enacting The Will of their deity. This does not seem so with the Church. They do not seem to engage in any grand acts of preaching to the unconverted. They even seem to think that their deities have no need of their worship or aid.

The majority of the Church are unhinged and lack the benefit of what we would term a sound mind. Is it their worship that drives them insane? Or are they driven to by their insanity to seek out the deities that they do?

Advocates of the Church seem to accept that the pantheon that they venerate is so alien to them and their needs that their deities pay no heed to those who would follow them. Perhaps it is this rejection or rather complete indifference by the forces that they worship that

cause this insanity. Perhaps their insight and communication into ancient dark mysteries overwhelms and destabilises their minds.

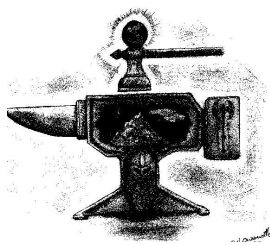
Yet the church has consistently sought acceptance into Imperial Society. Many of its members have performed a number of tasks with the sole hope of being pardoned from the blanket outlawing that exists for all Black Guilds and many of their members have been pardoned.

In its time the Church has performed acts of remarkable helpfulness towards the Empire. During the time of The Final Dawn it was they and they alone who averted the threat of the Elder Gods as they descended to Primus. The resultant desecration of the ruins of Gileenim being the price for their actions but their failing to do what they did would have been far greater.

If it were not for its obvious insanity the Church could almost be considered a productive force for the Empire. Still it undoubtedly remains one of the strangest cults within the Empire.

Watching-Owl

Moradin



Name of Deity: Moradin

High Priest: Ashalan

Avatar: Queen Gerehax

of Almacscar, Mortal

Hand of Moradin

Guild Founder: Ashalan

Spherical Leaning:

None

Diametrical Opposition:

Centres of Religion: Al
Macscar

Pre-Requisites: Goodly Humans and Dwarven Priests. Other races may be accepted at the discretion of the High Priest on an individual basis. We respect the elves as they have aided the Dwarven nation in the past but their ways are too different from ours and they cannot join the hearth.

Miracle List ~ Lawful Good

1st: Cure Wound, Detect Spirit's Nature

2nd: Cure Serious, Spirit of Seeing and Hearing

3rd: Cure Disease, Healing Hand, Bless, Dismiss Ghoul, Protection From Spirits, Talk To Spirits, Spirit Shield

4th: Heal, Passive Heal, Communication, Spiritbolt

5th: Spiritual Invisibility

6th: Total Heal, Dismiss Vampire

8th: Restore Life

Ethos

Moradin forges the dwarven race from iron and mithril, and then breathes life into them as they cool upon his forge. As the prime creator, he is revered by many good and neutral dwarves regardless of clan. Priests of Moradin are charged with upholding the dwarven virtues of law and light, and with guiding their people in the arts the dwarves hold dear.

The dwarves have always revered the Master of the Forge, attempting to emulate his masterful work with metals and stone. Honesty and hard work pay off just as often in the mines and the forges, as they do on the battlefield, or so the dwarves claim. As such all priests of Moradin are encouraged to spend at least some of their time at a forge learning and honing their skills. Any forged items of obvious quality if not able to be used by the bearer or finder should be given to the Church to

either redistribute to other church members or to be kept within Moradin's Hearth in Al'Mascar as an example to those who wish to enter his priesthood. Moradin Soulforged is our spiritual father. As such we are his children, often we will be praised and supported by him but when we go against his wishes he will not stop loving us but will punish us as we deserve.

Restrictions

- Will not suffer the Dueregar. They are an abomination and will not be suffered to live.
- Werewolves and their kindred are our allies and if possible they should be treated with due respect.

Tennets

- Our oath is our bond.
- Stone and the working of stone and metal into items of beauty should be admired and treated as objects of art.
- From Fire and the Earth are we born. Fear nothing for when we die we return to the earth for Moradin to reforge us once more.
- If the dwarven nation or people under their protection are threatened, we will respond with force if necessary. We will back down from no threat as our god is at our backs and the fire of the hearth drives us with a wild fury when required.

Creation of the Dwarves

After Moradin the creator had forged the world and made the dwarves from the very stone, he became weary and slept. Some lesser Gods jealous of his skill bound him as he slept. They heated the forge and made their own races of men and Elves. These they placed upon the home world of the dwarves, but they fell to arguing amongst themselves over which part of the world should be given to their people.

The dispute woke the creator who saw what they had done and became angry. But the others laughed at him for they had bound him fast, and he could cause them no harm. They continued to fuel the fire of the forge and work. However they did not know how to control the great forge and it became too hot. Great globules of molten rock stone flew into the air and fell to the earth. As they fell the creator breathed on them to cool them so

Divine Guidance

that they did not harm his people. The force of his breath gave life to the molten fragments and these became Dragons.

The Moradin warned the lesser Gods that they could not rule a world if they could not work the forge. The lesser Gods ignored Moradin and he warned once More: "One day the forge will burn beyond your control and the world will be seared by the heat of the flames. Then you shall free me or all will perish, even we. Then I will bring Justice to the World you have abused and my people shall be saved from your waging of war."

Years passed by with things as they were, then finally the forge burned so bright they could not even look upon it, great fires rained down upon the people of the world, leaving only blackness in their wake. In the panic that ensued the lesser Gods, freed Moradin, who lifted his people from the realm and placed them in a New World, that of Primus.

In these Mountains the Creator's people would thrive for thousands of years, and so they have. The creator then turned to the lesser Gods, seeking injustice, they were stripped of their divinity and cast down upon the blackened World, with only the powers to mend that which they had undone. Over thousands of years their protective nature grew and they became known as the Seven Tears of the World. Walking the Land as Mortals until the waging of war becomes peace and so still they are on the Blackened Realm Healing the wounds.

The Dwarves of Al-Macsar

The Dwarves of Al-Macsar all Follow Moradin, and tend to be neutral or Goodly in nature. They are Famous for their Forging

- The arm Elsolaris of the Elves
- The Shriken Blade, The Axe Wielded by General Rimirill Icewarden
- The Traitor, Dalron, being of Truestone

The dwarves give sanctuary to wolves and wolver-kind including Werewolves (western forest of Al-Macsar). The Punishment for killing a Wolf in Al-Macsar Lands is death.

Commentary

The religion of the Dwarves has never been strong in the Empire, hardly surprising given the relative rarity of the Dwarves. Concentrated and concealed as they are in Al'Macsar so has their faith been. It is only recently that the Priest Ashalan has brought the faith of Moradin to the other races.

The Dwarves of Al-Macsar are known in the Empire primarily due to their Queen Gerehax, and her bodyguard Gere. The alliances extended by the Queen to her

Not being of Dwarven blood himself Ashalan perhaps has been well placed to bring the Forge Faith to the non dwarven races and perhaps in time this faith will spread across the Empire.

Watching-Owl

Mortai

Name of Deity: Mortai

High Priest: Halvor Gowan

Avatar: Halvor Gowan

Guild Founder: Squire

Spherical Leaning: Dismissal

Diametrical Opposition: Despite not having a true antithesis to the faith, the teachings of the Church of Mortai clash with more than one evil Church who desire to bring suffering into the world through causing pain directly or using the tools of undeath.

Centres of Religion: Roxbridge

Symbol: White dove carrying olive branch motif on shield background.

Prerequisites: Be a weapons-wielding priest (not pure, armoured or hospitaller), or be a paladin

Miracle List ~ Lawful Good

1st: Dismiss Zombie, Cure Wound, Power Meld, Spirit of Seeing, Detect Spirit's Nature

2nd: Dismiss Skeleton, Repel Undead

3rd: Dismiss Ghoul, Protection from Spirits, Talk to Spirits, Spirit Shield, Cure Disease, Bless

4th: Spirit Bolt, Heal, Reveal Undead Name, Dismiss Mummy

5th: Spiritual Invisibility, Dismiss Wraith

6th: Total Heal, Dismiss Vampire

Ethos

Mortai is the brother god of Shaehan, and her defender. He too strongly believes in the sanctity of life, and is the overseer of undead across the planes. His role is to ensure that they do not stray outside the restrictions to which they are bound, by invading the dead bodies of mortals or otherwise seeking to take revenge on living spirits, as is so often their way. His priests are expected to harm no living thing except where

it is essential to defend a life, although those who raise undead are an exception to this rule and may be acted against as the priest sees fit. Undead must be returned to their own plane, by force if necessary, and trapped mortal bodies freed from their corruption. Antagonistic daemonkind should also be destroyed or banished, as their spirits are also perversions of lost souls and they are drawn to harm the living. Mercy is a paramount virtue for the church, and any who ask it should be granted it – in the case of undead for example, the priest should work to find some way to free their spirit painlessly. The church's symbol is a dove on a shield.

Tenets

- Do everything within your power to put an undead back on its original plane of existence and to cease any suffering caused by these creatures
- Always grant mercy to those who ask it
- Do not harm a living thing unless to defend another
- Do not take a life without first doing anything else in your power to prevent such happening

Background

Mortai is the brother God and defender of the Goddess now known as Shaehan, Lady of Mercy. Due to this and the history that they have gone through, it is not surprising that strong ties bind these two churches together and a priest of one will almost certainly pay homage to the other. Mortai shares her belief in the sanctity of life; all life is sacred and everyone has the right to enjoy it without unnecessary suffering. Whereas Shaehan preserves this sanctity through healing all ills, Mortai has the role of Overseer of Undeath across the planes, ensuring creatures of undeath do not stray outside the restrictions to which they are bound to interfere with this sanctity. It is too often undeads' way

to break through the boundaries of their home plane, whether through invitation or their own power, and invade the dead bodies of mortal people.

Undead cause suffering wherever they roam among the living, corrupting mortal bodies or feasting upon their life essence whether through hatred or simple hunger. As such Mortai priests will always seek to return these creatures to their plane of origin or, if suffering is being caused on the plane of origin due to clashes with the living, remove them from existence. It is due to this fact that Mortai priests are always martial in nature, and why paladins are often accepted as full members of the Church. The priests limited spiritual powers will be most commonly used alongside their weapons in their battle against undead. Daemonkind from other planes are not exterminated on sight, but antagonistic specimens will generally also be destroyed or banished, as their spirits are perversions of lost souls who are drawn to harm the living as well.

Mercy is a paramount virtue for the church, and they strive to end suffering where they find it. Mortai priests are therefore expected to harm no living thing except where it is essential to defend a life, and even then will do whatever they can to avoid causing death. There is one exception to this rule however; undead summoners. Those who raise undead willingly invite these foul creatures to taint mortal souls and spread suffering, and so Mortai's followers will act against them as they see fit. However *any* who ask for mercy will be granted it; for example, in the case of an intelligent undead requesting it, the priest will work to find some way of freeing their spirit painlessly.

The Church is currently maintained in Revelstone, formerly known as the Barony of Roxbridge, where due to the joint efforts of the Mortai and Raven priests in the area no creature of undeath is welcome. The current High Priest of the Church of Mortai is his Avatar, Halvor Gowan, who will normally always be found in this town.

History

The Church of Mortai has always had its fate tightly entwined with that of the Church of Shallya, now known as the Church of Shaehan. Initially it was an order of the Church of Shallya itself, a martial order following Shallya's demi-God brother, defending his sister's priests and battling mortal suffering in a different way. As such, in ages past when the Church of Shallya faded, so did the Order of Mortai. However when the hermit priest Lady Torwin Mortis Black soul stumbled across the ancient temple to Shallya in the Remus Hills, and consequently returned the Church to its former glory, the order was revived again as a part of this Church. With the new burst of faith filling the once forgotten deities, however, Mortai soon gained enough followers dedicated to his cause to become a full God in his own right. It was at this point that it was deemed best for the Order of Mortai to separate and become an independent Church, forever making the Church of Shallya a solely pacifistic Church, and the Church of Mortai one for militant priests only.

Under the lead of Squire, the Church of Mortai prospered and established a name and respect for itself. After many years of loyal and active service in his Lord's name, Squire retired from mercenary work and without his great leadership the name of Mortai started to fade away from the public eye. There were still a few active

members who did brave deeds and spread their faith to the populace, curiously the most notable being a Friar, Brother Bartholomew, who could often be seen among gatherings of the then Church of Shallya. However, as the years went by, new worshippers became few and far between; but this all changed on the outbreak of the Namer War.

In the Namer War, after a lot of grief and confusion, the priests of light worked together to try and keep the Gods from the future from destroying the Gods of that present. In the end there were differing results for differing churches, some fought their future selves and won, some lost, whilst others found other solutions, such as amalgamating both Beings. Mortai survived the War, his nature unchanging except for one thing. The ancient God Humakt, the Runelord who had warred against undeath for countless ages, had grown tired and weary and wished to pass on and transfer all responsibility to Mortai to keep undeath in check. Mortai accepted this role and so was alone in his attempts to maintain the boundaries that kept undead where they belonged. However, after the Namer when priests no longer prayed for all of the Gods of Light as well as their own deities but rather solely their own, Mortai started to feel the pressure of having so little strength given to him due to too few worshippers. The sole responsibility of overseeing creatures of undeath was too great for the little following he received.

Halvor Gowan, one of Shallya's Cherubim, who had followed Her into the Namer and through the other side to follow the new Lady of Mercy, Shaehan, felt a strange tugging at his being. Like many other Shaehan priests, he had always paid homage to his Lady's defender and brother God, but he had never felt such a strong calling to Mortai's power before. On a quest with his friends among the Restless, Halvor was yet again in a situation where he felt healing powers were just not enough to help those who suffered at the hands of creatures whose very nature brought suffering. It was at this juncture where Mortai and Halvor helped each other to change their future existences; with Shaehan's blessing, Halvor became the new spiritual leader of the Church of Mortai.

Re-establishing the Church as an open faith and spreading the word of Mortai, Halvor easily quadrupled the active members of the Church and welcomed Felix and all his Rune priests into it to fight in the name of Mortai. The Church is still not one of the large faiths in the Empire, its followers too scattered and few to maintain a Guild in the Volksraad, but the vigour and effort they put into practising their faith and warring with undeath will mean the name Mortai will be a long time in the forgetting.

Commentary

Mortai, successor to the Rune Lord. There is much strangeness attached to the origins of Mortai compared to the origins of the worship of Mortai and in some ways illustrates how deities may transcend the flow of time as we perceive it. It is said that Mortai was brother to Shallya and hence brother to Shaehan, Shallya's successor. The worship of Mortai happened for quite some years before the Namer war yet Mortai was named as one of the Namer Gods, destined to have succeeded The Rune Lord.

Watching-Owl

Divine Guidance

Name of Deity: None, the spirits of healing and mercy are venerated generally
High Priest Thomas de Racine
Guild Founder: Unknown
Spherical Leaning: Healing
Diametrical Opposition:
Symbol: None

Miracle List ~ Lawful Good

1st: *Cure Wound, Detect Spirit's Nature, Dismiss Zombie, Power Meld, Spirit of Seeing, Halt*
2nd: *Cure Serious Wounds, Spirit of Seeing And Hearing, Temporary Bless*
3rd: *Befriend, Bless, Cure Disease, Protection From Spirits,*
4th: *Heal*
5th: *Voice of Power, Remove Voice of Power, Remove Fear & Paralysis*
6th: *Total Heal, Regeneration, Spiritual Freedom*
8th: *Restore Life*

Ethos

The Sacred Heart is the Hospitaller's Guild. As such it is totally against violence and wishes all that live to be of good alignment. However it also desires that the unfortunate undead would walk this plane no more and this is in favour of freeing their spirits from the evil spiritual ties that bind them to this plane. Of course this must be achieved in a non-violent manner.

Tenets of the Faith

- All life is sacred.
- To take life is the most heinous crime imaginable.
- All life is joined on a spiritual level and to kill another is to kill a part of yourself.
- Compassion, the opposite of violence is the greatest act a man is capable of and should be shown to all that lives.

History

The Sacred Heart is an old church, predating most of those now popular in the Empire. It has never been large as the self control required to follow its tenets is great and most people are unable to turn the other cheek and accept the evils of the world. The church today: the current High Priest has many friends and counts many priests of Shaehan, Mortai, Unity, Border and St Michael among them. However, not suited to an adventuring life, he and his priests try to help in small ways, feeding the hungry, curing the sick and leaving the fighting of evil to those mentioned above...

Holy days

None are recorded for the Church.

The Tenets Explained

The Sacred Heart strives for a universal brotherhood in which peace can truly reign. This brotherhood is nominally termed 'the Sacred Heart', although for a few years the high priest has been heard speaking of a Holy Chalice which is the source of all things good. They speak of this brotherhood and hope that others will listen, yet they understand that there may be no one listening and therefore try to mitigate as much of the world's violence as possible.

Commentary

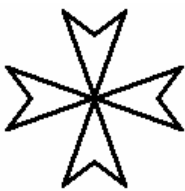
One of the oldest Churches of the Empire it has often been referred to as the *Hospitaller's Guild*. It appears that the lack of deific interference has made the following of the church by Hospitallers a popular one. Without a deity seeking to channel Faith the vows of the Hospitaller are not compromised by the demands of a deity. Even goodly deities have their own agendas and such agendas whilst often benevolent may still go against the strict vows taken by a Hospitaller. Without such a figurehead the drawing and use of power seems to be a thing of conscience to those who follow the Sacred Heart and they are truly free to follow a path of non-violence.

The head of the faith is a man of extraordinary conviction. To be an active member of the Mercenary Caste when holding views such as his is undoubtedly an extremely difficult thing.

It has often been noted that the presence of a powerful healer in any Mercenary band leads to an excessive increase in violence and bloodshed. I have seen this on many an occasion and my own presence, on occasion, has caused such a magnification of violence. The caution and mercy that a Mercenary might otherwise show often thrown to the winds knowing that their Priest can patch them up, or even restore them to life if the worst were to happen tends to lead to a less reasoned approach. The healing spirits of Thomas de Racine shy away from such violence and those involved in violence and it seems that this very fact helps in his pilgrimage of peace.

Watching-Owl

Saint Michael



Name of Deity: Michael
High Priest: Anarchus
Cardinal: Martaine Ettien Navar
Bishop: Dalin
War Abbots: Vayle D'Lyte & Kamac Macloud
Guild Founders: Anarchus & Duke Defender Saladin Bin Noordin

Diametrical Opposition: The Destroyer
Centres of Religion: Halgar & Sellaville
Symbol: As above or sometimes a Staff or Flaming Sword
Prerequisites: Be a goodly aligned priest

Miracle List ~ Neutral Good

1st: *Halt, Cure Wound, Detect Spirit's Nature, Power Meld, Spirit of Seeing*
2nd: *Cure Serious*
3rd: *Cure Disease, Talk to Spirits, Spiritshield, Protection from Spirits, Bless, Dismiss Ghoul*

4th: *Heal, Spiritbolt*
5th: *Dismiss Wraith, Voice of Power, Spiritual Invisibility*
6th: *Total Heal, Dismiss Vampire*
8th: *Restore Life*

Ethos

Priests of Saint Michael follow the Creator of all things and on the whole try to reason with most problems before beating it to death, a guild for reasonable characters. *E.g. will try to persuade those of a dark disposition to repent rather than kill them, as opposed to other religion's fanatics (though fanatics can be fun!).* However, many of the longer-standing members of the Church tend to interpret St Michael's teachings in more 'extreme' ways, and this has led to some discussion about the possible division of the guild. The High Priest is at pains to point out, however, that the scriptures can be read in more than one way.

Major Exponents of the Faith Past and Present

Duke Defender Saladin Bin Noordin*, Fadd* Vidar*, Anarchus*, Ungrim, Kamac MacCloud, Vayle D'Lyte, Sir Amorphus of Eldith, Wolvesbane, Noordin, Dalin, Martaine Ettien Navar, Gwydion, Mordred, Aurelius, Justin the Left Handed, (Those marked * have all held the post of High Priest)

Holy Days

1st Martius ~ Faith's Day [Holy Day]

The day on which the church of St Michael was founded within Labyrinthia by Anarchus, High Priest of St Michael, and Saladin Bin Noordin, Duke Defender of Labyrinthia

1st Aiprus ~ Day of Tears [Shadow Day]

The battle between St Michael and the Old Man of the Sands took place on this day so long ago, much to the tearful reflection of the priests of St Michael.

23rd Aprisu ~ Ascension of St Micahel [True Holy Day]

The day that St Michael was released from the staff of life and became a god.

13th Maii ~ Saladin's Day [Holy Day]

Celebration of the day the noble Saladin Bin Noordin acquired the holy weapon of St Michael for the benefit of the Church of St Michael. The Star Sword Nebulous holds great religious significance for the priests of St Michael.

3rd Septus ~ Justice Day [Holy Day]

A celebration of the day the Church of St Michael fought, defeated and slew Fzoul, Hihg Priest of the Destroyer.

5th Novaus ~ Day of Shadows [Shadow Day]

The pillar of light collapsed on this day, and leads priests of St Michael to quiet contemplation of the loss of light within the land that resulted from this dark event.

Tales of the Faithful

Martaine woke; the bed had been hard but better than the floor. The rain still fell outside, he was never going to be able to walk to Halgar by tomorrow and if the weather didn't clear soon transporting there would be difficult. He'd hoped to stop off in a couple of the villages on the way and see how the chapels there were doing, no chance of that now.

As he pushed back his bowl James, the son of the Inn owner came over to clean up. When he had finished he pulled over a chair and sat opposite Martaine.

"Tell me another story about Michael"

Martaine smiled, if only the members of his church were as eager to listen, a good sermon for Vayle and Kamac was in order when he got back to the Cathedral.

"Very well, lets go over to the fire where it's warmer"

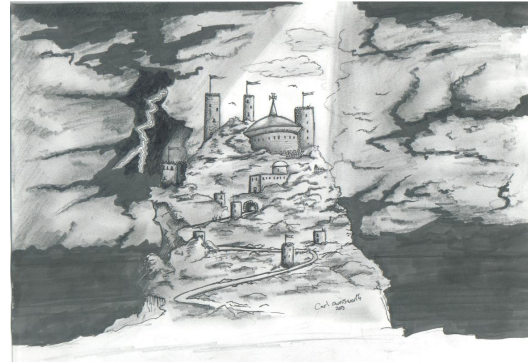
James moved over and sat on the fur rug, while Martaine moved his chair round. Opening his back he pulled out the teaching's he carried with him, copies of sacred scriptures from Skylove written by Michael's hand, and turned the pages.

"I think we'll start with this one" Martaine settled and cleared his throat. Sipping his wine he began:

In the beginning, of course, were the gods. And in the beginning, the gods were one and they were called the "SOURCE". The first grand epoch was an era of inquisition during which the "SOURCE" ruminated upon the nature of their being, a riddle so formidable that it addled even the divine intellect for some seven score and one aeon. Early into their query, the Source began to understand their nature as a

reflection and prepared themselves to ponder their purpose for time everlasting. But since the "SOURCE" alone was all that was, they eventually came to realise that they were capable of inventing their conundrum. It was thus that the "SOURCE" learned to understand Creation as an Essence superior to contemplation.

With this understanding came the dawn of the second grand Epoch, an age of imagination. During the aeons ensuing, the "SOURCE" contemplated their being from a new vantage. They now pondered the essence of creation itself. If creation was their purpose, they wondered, then what must they create? In an attempt to answer this query the "SOURCE" consumed forty and one aeon's and in so doing so the "SOURCE" became many as the other GODS came into existences as Idea's of the greater and the Gods created from pondering of the creation essence.



Chapter Mount of War Abbott Vayle D'Lyte
[Artist's Impression]

During the forty second aeon, the gods created mortal Female to join with mortal male to beget more mortal males and females and their forms where as diverse as the stars as each god moulded the races as he or she saw fit.

During the forty third aeon, the gods created the flora, the fauna and the multi - faceted acana so that mortal male and female could hold dominion over their lessers just as the gods held dominion over the mortals.

The third grand epoch began with a great schism within the ranks of the Divine. Frustrated with the progress of their living experiment a few of the gods rejected Creation and started to pursue new pathways into the mystery of their being. Within an aeon, these gods became convinced that the true essence was not to create but to destroy. Instead of looking towards an epoch in which all that existed was filled with objects and concepts that comprised an elaborate pattern of divine design and creation. These gods plotted to return the cosmos to a state of purity. They resolved to eventually destroy even that which cannot be destroyed - namely, themselves and their fellows. By the time it had run its course, their speculations led them to the conclusion that the true mission divine was the Elimination of the divine itself, an event that would leave the cosmos in a state of perfect emptiness.

As part of an attempt to sway their comrades the rogue gods laid waste to the ancient fortress of RAAK-PO, one of the largest of the manor states built by mortal man. And with this act, the gods were no longer one. Those who accept the rogue view adopted a philosophy later known as Destruction, Chaos, Evil, while those in opposition adopted a philosophy later described as Creation, Law, or Good.

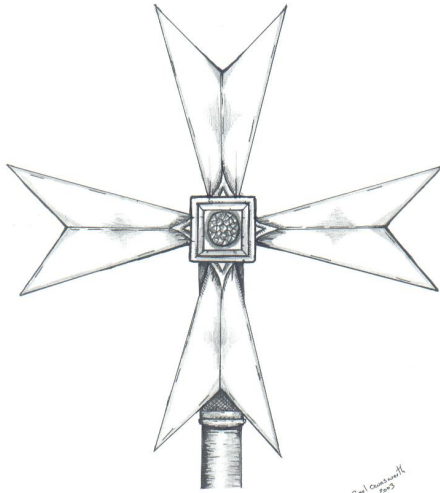
A quizzical look passed over James face. As Martaine paused to take a sip of his wine he asked: "But can't some laws be evil and cause people to suffer?" Martine finished his wine:

"The term Law being used here is in a context referring to The Laws of Nature as it were. The fact that the Sun Will

Divine Guidance

rise every day that Summer will follow Spring, that a living creature has a span of years, that life and death are all part of a lawful cycle. Indeed we are talking of the Law of Gods not necessary the Law of mortal rulers and yes some of their law's can seem Evil and some are but I have known some laws which seem evil to individuals but have been devised for the betterment of society as a whole, this does not mean that I agree with them, but I can understand the reason for them to be in place"

He continued:



Michaelian Warstaff

The gods then spent the next sixteen aeon's warring upon each other as described in "Auroras Tempus". But then exactly seventeen aeons's after Raak-Po was laid waste, the gods came to understand the futility of conflict and agreed to sit in conference to discuss their differences. During this first grand conference, the gods of Chaos continued to argue that the true mission of the divine was the purification of the cosmos by the eradication of all things, the gods of Law countered by continuing to assert their belief that the true mission divine was the Creation of a elaborate pattern of concepts and ideas to fill the cosmic void, though they admitted that they had yet to discover the true nature of this pattern.

"So which is right?" James asked. Briefly puzzled Martaine almost laughed when he though how most of his church would answer:

"Now this would depend upon who you spoke to young man, and what ever I say here is obviously my opinion and that of my teachers. I have learnt and whole heartedly believe in the Creation essence and through living in a manner that will add to the Pattern of the cosmos and by serving my fellow Beings and thwarting The Destruction Essence in its many forms so that people like yourself can sleep sound at night. Where you ask the same question of a servitor of the destruction essence well, you would likely hear a different tale, most do not even realise what they serve or do not care and with some you would be lucky to escape the encounter with your life. As to which is right or wrong. In truth only the individual can answer that and that is what you young man must decide with your heart and mind and with what your soul speaks to you!

Smiling, and realising life would be so much easier if the priesthood asked these questions rather than which way to hold a mace Martaine resumed the lesson:

Obviously reunion was impossible, though representatives of both factions were able to reach accords that allowed the

followers of each philosophy to at last pursue their inquiries with only limited interference from their rivals.

This first divine conference is also distinguished by the Genesis of the "Corpos Diabolis" now know as the various races of demon kind. During the impassioned speech in the defence of the creation essence a goddess of law demonstrated that the gods were not alone in the cosmos. This goddess revealed to all the existence of another primordial concept known as decay, that had lurked unnoticed within the divine intellect since the very beginning of all things. She also speculated that the influence of this concept was responsible for the great schism and the evolution of the destruction essence. To help prove her point she used her divine power to isolate the concept from the divine intellect, an event that recast decay in the form of hideous monsters who immediately started to beget yet more of their kind.

"So who made decay, or was it part of the source?"

"Indeed you are correct, decay was part or the source as are all things originally, whether they still remain in the form originally wrought by the source today is another matter! Decay in one form is part of nature, but what was wrought then was a manifestation of the concept, putting flesh to the bones of the concept. For instance it would be like me saying: Here is Love, this is what it looks like. I do not know what it would look like I can only imagine"

James thought briefly and then looked up, waiting for Martaine to continue.

Although the demonstration effectively convinced them, of its existence, the gods of Chaos challenged the notion that decay had secretly swayed them to found their rogue philosophy. Instead they offered the assertion that decay was the corruption of purity responsible for swaying the gods of Law to pollute the cosmos with their creations. The day that they embraced the destruction essence, the forces of Chaos argued, they successfully liberated themselves from decay and its influence. Despite their differences, all the gods agreed that decay was dangerous. To forever isolate themselves from its influences, the gods combined their might to create the "Infernus" and imprison the ever-growing ranks of decay monsters, Within its bowels. Once separated from the divine intellect and its creations the decay beings began to suffer a hunger that drove many of them to madness. Most of the demons vowed to avenge their fate as soon as a fitting opportunity presented itself.

Some Thirty and three aeon's later, during the fourth grand epoch, the gods found themselves at war once again. This latest conflict arose out of a series of arguments over each factions desire to seize the souls of the fallen mortals, each soul thus seized by the gods in this fashion allowed them to partially replenish their depleting divine energies. Meaning that the faction that seizing the most souls enjoyed an obvious advantage over its rivals. Ultimately, the gods again settled their differences by convening a grand conference. Over the next three aeons's each faction proposed scores of solutions to the problems at hand. But in the end only a single proposal was acceptable to both parties had emerged.

This proposal called for the gods of Law to create the concept of free will, allowing each mortal an opportunity to select a final destination for his or her own soul. The accord ultimately ratified by both factions granted the gods of Law dominion over each soul at the instant of its birth, but allowed the gods of Chaos a life long opportunity to seduce the mortal into freely forfeiting his or her soul to their dominion. To conduct such seduction most efficiently the gods of Chaos struck a bargain with the gods of Law and the Demons of decay that allowed the demons an opportunity to leave the infernus to tempt mortals on behalf of Chaos.

James looked shocked, not knowing how to phrase it, he simply blurted out his question. "Why would the Gods

let this happen? I mean if they had had wars with the demons wouldn't they leave them trapped and why would the Gods of light let the demons out?"

Martaine paused, slightly baffled. He'd never been asked before why, just how to stop it. "A very difficult one to answer. As you have seen in the past the Gods have warred and where unable to beat each other this was because when they first came into existence they all were equal in power, as the source decreed. Now the Gods of Good, to stop the war which laid waste to the lands of mortals, had to agree some terms now the fact that all souls at birth belong to the individual the gods of light had a advantage. Who in their right mind would want their Soul to reside for all time in the pits of hell? And the fact that most people, if treated well, treat others the same. It is only through hardships, or temptation, or lust, or jealousy, or such like that people start down the slippery slope.

Now to balance this the God of Light had to at least allow the Gods of Evil a chance to steal souls but by the individuals own actions and because they love us and trust us to make the right choice they agreed to the compact, if to do nothing else but to bring the war to a halt and allow mortals to grow and thrive rather than be crushed by the titanic forces unleashed during the God war. As you might have noticed the gods very rarely interact directly with the world of mortals, this is because should one then all are allowed to and we would soon have a world in ruins so they must act through their mortal worshippers or lesser servitors like Angels and Abishai. Now this is where they Gods of Light where slightly cunning, they told there loyal followers what the Gods of Dark where doing. They told them that Demons where foul creatures set upon the world by dark powers to steal and devour souls and so you see why the churches of light and many others hunt theses creatures down where ever they may be found. True some who serve the dark let the foul creatures into the world to do the opposite but the balance of power amongst the Gods tips as more or less Mortals worship them and the souls that boost their divine power to the point where with the intervention of mortals Gods may be destroyed as so recently happened to the Mad one eyed god! So Proving that the power and strength of the belief of mortal Souls.

"I still don't understand. You said the Gods of Evil blamed the decay for turning the Gods of light from the true path, so why would they use Demons if they blamed them for the world being wrong? It seems stupid."

"The gods of darkness felt that they in their purity where immune to the corruption that decay presented, they are obviously wrong, and as such could utilise the Demons as tools as they where above the influences of these creatures! As to them using them being stupid, well that is your opinion and just the kind of thing I was hoping our conversation would stimulate. You asking sensible questions and coming to your own opinions on the subject! I am not here trying to convert you just teaching one version on a subject you will hear from many different sources, generally shouted into large crowds I have noticed and it seems some of the lesson is sinking in, well done. Just make sure you keep asking questions and come to your own choices "

Martaine smiled and went on:

Despite their rivalry with the gods, the demons accepted the accord because it allowed the periodically to relieve themselves from the torment of their prison. Because each mortal successfully tempted would sate their hunger to spread decay. Today the demons continue to function in this capacity.

But as the wheel of time turns and tensions mount between Law and Chaos, the demons grow ever more bold, most remember the vow's of vengeance they made many aeon's ago, and a few have started to ignore the rules that bind them once out side their prison, daring the gods to intervene.

The very boldest of the demon lords are already laying plans for a great war aimed at toppling the gods themselves, drawing mortal worshippers of their own gaining the power of the divine through worship and souls, biding their time until their power is great enough to challenge the gods.

So ends chapter one.

As Martaine closed the book James smiled.

"Of course this is just one way of looking at things, and may not be the truth, just a truth"

"Thank you sir. When I grow up I want to be a big hero like you"

"I'm not a hero James, just a simple man trying to help"

The sound of the rain had faded without either of them noticing and the sun shone outside.

"I should be off, I've still got a long way to travel"

"Will you come back soon?"

"I'll try"

Martaine went outside. James watched from the window as he turned into a blur of light and streaked towards Halgar. Yes when he grew up he'd be a big hero like Martaine.

James went back inside and cleared away Martaine's wine cup. As he finished the door opened and a man walked in, he wore a long travellers robe.

"Might I troubled you for a morsel of food good sir. I'm afraid I have no money, but I could perhaps tell a tale or such"

James, thinking on what Martaine had said, and how if you treat people well they will treat others well smiled and agreed.

Sitting by the fire the man pulled up his robe, his feet muddy from the paths; he stretched them out to dry.

"Thank you young sir. To the story then"

James pulled over his chair and sat ready. The man smiled and he began:

In the beginning, of course, were the gods. And in the beginning, the gods were one and they were called the "SOURCE"

Saladin's Tale

It's a very very long story. I started life of as a Hospitlar then became a Paladin and when I turned into a Paladin it was because I was getting tortured by a bunch of evil priests and their minions in an Evil Temple in Halgar.

I took up arms and I destroyed the Cult of scum that was in the centre of this building and claimed it in the name of my Lord. I founded the first Temple of Saint Michael. It was not a temple to Saint Michael then it was merely a building. Once I had cleansed it I invited my good friend Anarchus who had also been looking for a path of Light and was like myself looking for a Righteous path to follow. We both had a calling but did not know who was going to answer our call. Anarchus then had a vision of sorts from Saint Michael in the Land of Skylove. I became Saint Michael second follower and Anarchus was his first and we started the Church of Saint Michael him as High Priest and I its Champion.

Divine Guidance

Our church did not have much of a following at the beginning we were rather alone and we endured all that the land of Skylove and the demons of Vor threw at us. I died a few times as did Anarchus at the hands of the Demons of Vor. It was during our battles with the Vor the high priest of C***** "The Destroyer", in the land of Skylove, that Anarchus and I had an epiphany vision call it what you will and It was revealed onto us that the opposing force to The Destroyer was The Creator. Saint Michael revealed to us that he was in fact an Arch Angel of the Creator. So we then knew that the Creator was the force that was guiding us all.

I then asked the Creator for the Blessing of Saint Michael. This Blessing was paid for the by my blood and through my faith in our Lord Saint Michael who had become more than just an Arch Angel of the Creator. The priesthood of our church where able to move faster and have magical and spiritual Armour as well a part of the Life of Saint Michael, the supernatural gifts bestowed to the Church's guildmembers. I believe this blessing of Saint Michael had the greatest influence on our numbers increasing. With the new worshippers we attracted and the numbers of Michaelian increasing the influence of Saint Michael increased exponentially, to be in fact what it is now.

Saint Michael is now a God of War with the single largest religious private army in the world as we know it. It is the largest faith in the Empire and must carry on growing for the sake of Primus and all that live in it. For, we are ever the champions of the people and its defenders. It is our powers that have kept the Land which we call Primus safe alive and thriving.

I do not know about the Naming Wars I will leave that to others who know better. All I can tell you is of the beginning of our faith and how two brothers of the same mind in one belief started a vast following for the powers of Light and all that is good.

The Life of Saint Michael before he ascended to become an Arch Angel of the Creator is another story all together and perhaps when I can find the time I will pass on what I can remember about him. Or perhaps Anarchus could share with you all the stories of Michael MacCloud the man that was to become a God through his acts of Mercy and Courage in the face of all adversity.

Saladin

Written By The Hand Of Isha

Commentary

In its time the Church of St Michael has been one of the single most powerful and influential Churches in the Empire. Its long history is filled with the names of great martial Heroes of the Empire, a list rivalled only by the Churches of Border and Elbereth.

Leadership: The Church has always followed closely the lead of its High Priest, almost without question and as a result the style of the High Priest has always coloured the attitudes of its most active members. At this time the

current holder of the post is Anarchus, Deva of Light. His strange combination of pragmatism and fiercely strong belief in the correctness of his faith in all things has lead many to observe that he does not act as a traditional proponent of the ways of Law and Light, however the blessing of his god has never left him and he has died untold deaths as a direct result of his unwavering beliefs. However he should not be underestimated as he is an extremely shrewd man and despite his very strong personal beliefs insists that each may follow St Michael in their own fashion. It is important to him that his Church remains strong and he is aware that the diversity of skills and attitudes amongst his priests grants it great strength and fortitude, something many outside the Church fail to recognise.

The Faith: As noted previously the faith encompasses many different views but the most fundamental are as follows: St Michael is an Arch Angel of the Creator. In time he ascended to god hood in his own right, he is still however a servant of the Creator and many Creator priests are members of the faith of St Michael as it provides the shelter of a strong organisation. Likewise many of the priests of St Michael acknowledge that through their devotion to him they support the Creator. St Michael is a Martial God and his worship demands that all his priests are in some fashion able to support the battle against darkness either by direct conflict or through support roles such as Healing and as a result all the Spheres of Spirituality available to the followers of light are employed by the priests of Michael in their crusade. It is interesting to note that at this time the Church, unlike those of Shaehan and Elbereth, has few exponents of vivemantic powers but it has several Holy Berserkers. The Church is based in the Imperial Capital of Halgar and has its Cathedral there, though strangely the main Tryst Temple backs onto it. Unsurprisingly another fundamental belief of the Church most is the vehement opposition to worshippers of the Destroyer, the antithesis of the Creator.

The Namer War: The events of the Namer War were most interesting and had several effects, some obvious, some less so. It consolidated the Church in a way unlike any other and it made St Michael himself the Champion of the Pantheon of Light and fully placed him in the role of War God. However less well documented is the fact that it also catalysed the organisation of the Church. During this period the political influence of the Church grew in order of magnitudes as did the strength of its Military Arm, Lyte Force, by the skilled leadership of the Church's hierarchy. It still remains one of the most influential factions in the Empire and its military arm probably the biggest private army in the Empire.

The Foe: The Church fully committed itself to supporting the Southern Baronies in their continued battle with The Demonic Foe, driven by the direct word of their deity who was present at the Battle of the Shriven Planes in IM1001 and fought against and slew the then Demongod of the Foe.

Shaehan

Name of Deity: Shaehan



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High Priest: Duchess Latona Stoneheart
Avatar: Chernobyl
Guild Founder / Celestial High Priestess: Lady Torwin Mortis Blacksoul

Guild Founder: Torwin

Spherical Leaning: Healing

Centres of Religion: Sellaville, Scarlene and the Heartlands of the Empire

Symbol: A Dove

Prerequisites: Goodly non-weapon using priest.

Miracle List ~ Lawful Good

- 1st:** *Cure Wound, Detect Spirit's Nature, Halt*
2nd: *Cure Serious Wounds*
3rd: *Cure Disease, Talk to Spirit, Dismiss Ghoul, Protection From Spirits, Spirit Shield, Bless*
4th: *Heal, Spirit Shift**
5th: *Dismiss Wraith, Remove Fear and Paralysis, Spiritual Invisibility*
6th: *Total Heal, Dismiss Vampire, Spiritual Freedom*
8th: *Restore Life*

**Spirit Shift:* As Words From Above but is a 4sp goodly miracle. *Verbal:* "Shaeahan, Take me hence!" however members may only cast this miracle if battleboarding the Church as a Professional Guild.

Ethos

Shaeahan is the Goddess of Healing, Mercy and Charity. Shaeahan priests will cure all who ask for it, though may ask those of evil alignment to repent before doing so. The priests have a similar outlook to Hospitallers but realise that fighting is a way of life and thus will not always try to stop a fight, although they will advise against it and will *tidy up* afterwards. They must never kill, or they will be instantly excommunicated by the goddess, unless it is against undead or evil supernatural creatures which are antagonistic. Above all Shaeahan priests believe in healing, mercy and the right of life regardless of alignment.

History

The Church of Shallya (as it was originally called) fell into decline about 320 years ago when the temple and its priests were attacked and killed by an army of undead. Finally, only the High-priest was left standing and in a desperate attempt to save the souls of his priests he unleashed all the power within his holy amulet and gave up his own spirit to Shallya. In reply the Goddess Shallya released a huge burst of blinding light and destroyed all the undead and the temple sank below the earth. The faith of Shallya died on Primus along with the priests of Shallya. The temple remained empty and undiscovered until about 20 years ago when Lady Torwin found the temple in the Remus Hills and revived the faith. Their sister church is Mortai.

During the 'namer war' Chernobyl, Demi-god of Healing, and Torwin, Celestial High Priestess - was High Priestess at the time, found that Paragon, the God opposing Shallya was in fact Shallya from one thousand years in the future. Therefore they sought to join the two and so Shallya and Paragon became Shaeahan. And rather than just Goddess of Healing and Mercy Shaeahan also embraced Charity in deference to Paragon. Lady Torwin has recently ascended to live in Haven with Shaeahan and has become the Celestial High Priestess but is still sighted in Labyrinthia on occasion. She has been succeeded by Duchess Latona Stoneheart, the current Governor of Halgar.

The Southern Baronies

Since the fall of Emperor Amora the Church of Shaeahan has enjoyed an immensely good relationship with the Southern Baronies, amongst The Circle, the people, the Grafts and even it seems many of the Ritter. Their desire to simply act as healers without any desire for payment or to even spread the word of their Mistress, which would contravene The Accords, first impressed itself upon those in power in the South through the selfless acts of Chernobyl.

With Chernobyl's eventual withdrawal from mortal affairs this work was continued by Haruld of Shaeahan, a man respected amongst the Baronies not just for his skill

as a healer but as a diplomat and Merchant. Much of the work to build up the good relations that have been enjoyed between the Empire and the Southern Baronies have been in no small part due to the efforts of Haruld. His simple and effective attempts to spread Peace and Prosperity, with his personal belief that prosperity begets peace and free trade reduces the need for war, seems to have so far yielded very good results.

Major Exponents of The Faith

Lady Torwin Mortis Blacksoul, Chernobyl, Gysmo / Mo, Serrafin, Haruld, Alex, Cloud.

Memories of Gysmo

written by his spirit, Mo

I write these words looking back at my shared memories of the past few years and how the faith of Shaeahan, or at least our personal concept of it, has developed. Although I am only part of what Gysmo was, or indeed is, I remember these times through his eyes and feel what he felt. Please note before I begin that I will not speak of the old names in such open form, to us now she is simply our beloved lady Shaeahan. Speak to me in person if you wish to know more of that past and why I am reluctant to speak of it.

Gysmo began his life in Deci and was introduced to the faith of Shaeahan at a young age in the unfortunate circumstances around the death of our mother Sadi. Where the city failed us the church offered him the shelter he needed and time to understand things. Over the years he grew to realise that Shaeahan gave him a way to provide for others the nurture which was missing for Sadi and others like her.

This is what I believe is at the heart of our faith. We seek to alleviate suffering, to help those who can't help themselves or even better bring them to a point where they can. The methods used to bring this about vary considerably and, like many of the stronger faiths, we draw upon the individual strengths of our followers to face the tasks ahead of us.

I digress. Gysmo left the shelter of the temple in Deci and began his adventuring career. The early years were often spent in the company of a group known as the White Templers who believed in the Source.

I won't go into great detail of this faith here but it does affect our views so is worth some mention. Rather than being a conflicting faith, the teachings tell of one form that existed before all others, some say even before the Creator and Destroyer though I would not be so bold as to say so definitely myself. In truth I think it more true to say that the Source is another aspect of the Creator. The Templers were a group distinctly for the good - many being Paladins - but they believed also through these teachings in a need for a balance between light and dark else order would be sacrificed to chaos.

In this way although I strive to protect all people I appreciate that it is the goal and how we act as individuals that matters most. An ultimate victory is maybe something to strive for but in the end will it be a victory and at what cost does it come? What cost indeed!

As months and years passed the Templers and I found differing goals and many of them returned to their homelands to protect their families more directly. Our journeys were far from over, many lands were travelled to, many people saved but by no means all. The cost began to tell on Gysmo and he sought to settle somewhat himself. He spent more and more time in Scarlene slowly

Divine Guidance

honing his skills to protect the people of the city and yet he did not forget those beyond. This is where I truly begin, for he created me from his own essence such that I could travel in his stead to aid those of the Empire and further a field. In this act he slowly attuned himself to the city so that he could channel more of our Ladies strength through me.

As of the end of IM1002 he truly became part of Scarlene though he is still there watching over us and probably always will be. There are still things he must do, things that he would see undone and to that end I continue to work in Shaeahan's name both as his form in Scarlene and beyond. So where does that leave our concept of the church of Shaeahan?

The church is a distinct set of individuals each with their own strengths and beliefs formed from the very effort of their faith. Some choose a more marshal path in the defense from the supernatural; undead, deamons and suchlike. Others steer more towards the strictly non militant path which is certainly our choice. I would like to think that Gysmo has had an impact in the tendency of the views towards the non militant end of the scale.

It is a fine line we don't cross though, for in many cases action is the only answer, in others inaction. We have countless times been faced with the decision to let a fight happen or indeed aid in those doing so that they might survive in the knowledge that if it doesn't happen many more will undoubtedly die. I absolutely hate the phrase but it sums it up well, 'For the greater good'. The point is that through our actions we at all times do our best to save those we can.

May you live in Peace

Mo
Spirit of Gysmo
Priest of Shaeahan

Holy Days

20th Februar ~ Reformation Day [High Holy Day]

This day in IM990, the church of Shallya was reformed, 300 years after it's priests in Labyrinthia were destroyed.

3rd Juon ~ Illumination Day [Holy Day]

The birthday of Towrin, Celestial High Priestess and Founder of the Church of Shaeahan. Date is as near as can be calculated.

1st October ~ Contemplation of Shaeahan [High Holy Day]

Celebration of the successful harvest and conclusion of the "living" year. Praise rises to Shaeahan for the food given to sustain people for another winter and asking for her mercy and protection as the nights of dark winter close in.

Commentary

Few Mercenaries would have ever reached the level of personal power that they enjoy without the ever present healing hands of Priests of Shaeahan, I for one personally owe many of my lives to Chernobyl and Torwin. Without the ministrations of the Priests and Priestesses of Shaeahan Emperor Cerus Amora's visionary Mercenary Caste would never have attained the level of influence and power that it now wields and the rolls of the Dead Heroes would undoubtedly be far, far greater.

The relationship between Shaeahan and Mortai is most interesting. They are often described as brother and sister and at one time both were of the same Church before it was divided so that those martial priests followed Squire and those who bore no weapons followed Torwin.

There are of course complications regarding the relationship of Shaeahan and Mortai with regards the Namer Paradox.

Watching-Owl

Slavik



Guild Head: Unknown (NPC)

Name of Deity: Slavik

High Priest: Unknown

Guild Founder: Kith Kahan?

Centres of Religion: Thimon, Trollsville

Symbol: Nine intersecting sticks in an interlaced circular pattern

Miracle List ~ Neutral Evil

1st: Halt, Spirit Of Seeing

2nd: Set Ward, Temporary Curse

3rd: Protection From Spirits, Spirit Shield, Talk To Spirit

4th: Rune Of Power, Control Ghoul, Cause Disease, Cause Fear

5th: Minor Ward Of Power, Spiritual Invisibility, Cause Grievous Wounds

6th: Spiritual Mastery

7th: Flood Of Putrescence

8th: Major Ward Of Power

A Tale of Slavik

A tail, a tail to found the Pack

A tail, a tail to birth it

A tail, a tail to hide the Pack

A tail to see what surrounds it

A tail, a tail to thief the food

A tail, a tail to eat it

A tail, a tail to whisper the words

A tail, a tail to sicken it

A tail at last not part of the Pack

A tail, a tail that dies in the dark

A tail a tail not part of the Pack

For the foolish above to count and to mark.

History

That a Church of Slavik exists at all has only come to light with the wider prominence of the ratfolk within the society of Thimon. Their rats tell of a time when they were little more than the common vermin who scuttle in every city devouring and living upon the scraps discarded by the men and women in the land that is now the Empire. Their ancestors though did not subsist solely upon the physical waste of man but also upon the plentiful scraps of supernatural power that were as common then as rotten meat and fouled wine.

Their ancestors though suffered greatly as the Magiarch's increased their conflict until by the time the Choas Wars were in their twilight months only a single member of their species survived still. He escaped the land and the pestilence that had savaged his siblings to live instead upon the thousands of tons of rock that circled Primus born upon the turbulent winds of magic. There he lived and found a new source of food, there he dwelt and spent his days merely surviving in solitude and prayer.

A Rat's Tale

If we should die before we wake

We pray that Slavik his thirst will slake

Upon the spirit of another

Divine Guidance

If the Pack does mourn our leaving
If Slavik then does hear their grieving
Then we pray he take us as his brother

Mathercurdle crouched in the burrow. Long since he had seen his brothers and sisters die as the food became scarce and the hunting more grim. They were the harshest of times, the whistling sky above filled with the great clumps of rock and stone that had been cast up by the great and foolish castings of the hairless, thoughtless creatures who wore the skins of others.

But Mathercurdle had learnt, as others had not. When his first brother had crumpled when the magic in the rivers had soured, bold Mathercurdle had left the rivers whose life that they had once supped. When the sly whelp of their pack had taken too much too soon from the scattered and hairless ones Mathercurdle had found the softer charms to use. Charms of prayer. Now alone, bold Mathercurdle had discovered the means to seek out the magic veined stones and ride them to the swirling tundra above that swept the earth high in the realms of air that he had but recently taken to his aid. He could skip and jump upon the currents of the air and take the discarded spiritual power that littered the mighty tide of rock that was swept up by foolish humanity.

He was the last of his kind he was the survivor. He was the last and for him there would be no mate. There were no scraps for him to claim and no rivals over whom to aspire. But Mathercurdle knew the truth that the others had forgotten in the darkness into which they had swam.

It was not the 'to be' that was important, it was not the 'has been' that was to be considered – it was the **now**. The now was all that mattered and tomorrow's troubles concerned him not, they concerned the Mathercurdle that would be. It was the now, always the now...

Mathercurdle was alone and though this gnawed he felt no concern, allowed himself no concern. His memories were unimportant for what lay in the past existed no more than grain twice eaten. He repressed the desire for another and even in his instinctual fortress he was aware that the need for the pack was the need for sanity. The vermin feared insanity, the vermin desired certainty and order of the self – if not the world. The vermin needed to know themselves and Mathercurdle pushed down the aching need for the pack...

...but Mathercurdle was the pack he needed no other even as he yearned for another. It was not in time as could be reckoned that he smelt the scent of the many-bonded creature. It soared upon the rocks as did he and took power in his druidic harvest as did Mathercurdle. Mathercurdle though knew to hide and crawled into the most hollow of stones.

Mathercurdle waited for time to pass but time had no meaning and the smell remained. Only the now, and the now was hungry for the feasting of the power in the rock was sore depleted. Mathercurdle moved in stealth and magic to the hole and there a hand snatched him upwards, stretched him, pushed power within until Mathercurdle hunched on unfamiliar haunches to stare eye to eye with the gaunt man who had swept him up.

"I am Kaharn." The man said in the speech of the ratfolk that lay now forgotten.

"I am Mathercurdle."

"You are the first."

"I am the last."

"You are the first." Kaharn whispered and broke the round stone he bore in both hands. Within was a mate, a rat of fair pelt and golden brow. Mathercurdle touched the mind of his kin that was beyond his kin. He felt the warmth of the nurturing

presence. Together they were greater than the sum of their parts and their pack would be nine and in nine would there be one.

How the rats grew and spread is not known and in the manner of rats, in the manner of the survivor Mathercurdle, they care little for the greater past. Only the now.

Organisation of the Faith

Spiny knife and quickened eye
Luck in shadow, prey shall die
Hunting, hunting – never flustered
Bright as needle, sharp as mustard!

Slavik is not a single entity. Rather the term refers to the nine aspects of which the Faith is composed and together the nine 'tails' of Slavik make up the greater whole. Ratfolk are a varied species and whilst many offer prayer and worship to each of the Tails of Slavik, there are those who restrain their abeyance to but one aspect of Slavik. They make little secret of the individual Tails and the majority of the Thimonese population know something of the Faith.

It should be noted though that what is known about the Faith has come from the majority Caslevasp and Hislehasp of that city and the tenants and very style of the Faith most likely vary in different areas of Primus where other Clans are more prominent. All though owe their very existence to Slavik of which each is a small part.

Curiously, it is only in recent years that any formal organisation of the Church has been seen due to the Ratfolks greater exposure to the Empire. There are several scholars however that believe the varied titles and positions that are being observed more commonly now are little more than a mask to aid in the Ratfolks interaction with the Empire itself.

It is known that the Ratfolk have an ordered and regulated society based upon Breed and age and the almost total control of that society by the Horstval demonstrates the extensive control of the Church over its people and the almost universal loyalty the rats show to their God.

Nine, yes nine, yes nine, yes nine!

Meat our feast and blood our wine!
Nine, yes nine, yes nine, yes nine!
Sister, brother, sire benign!
Nine, yes nine, yes nine, yes nine!
Carve the back! Break the spine!
Nine, yes nine, yes nine, yes nine!
In city, village, oak and pine!
Sicken shield and sword arm droop!
Stew and sup and make them soup

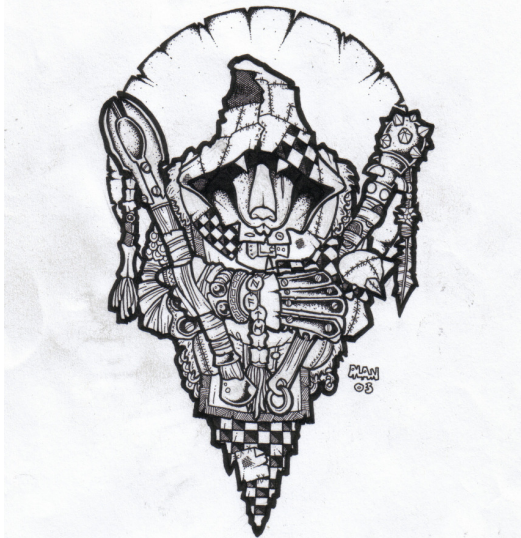
Whilst Ratfolk do not rely on outward symbols of status and power, three icons have arisen over the years. Before the Ratfolk came to their current position in the Empire they were forced to be more secretive than even they are now. The symbol they used to mark places for others of their kind was a circle of nine cuts and now many of the more martial of the race wear this about their armour to show their devotion to Slavik.

Secondly, during the attack upon the Ratfolk by the Knights of the Land the followers of Slavik needed a quick way to identify one another in the streets of the city and so each stitched a patch of broadly checked cloth upon their clothing. Even now, many of the Ratfolk still have their garments edged or patched with such cloth.

Lastly, and most curiously, the priests (and indeed the

Divine Guidance

druids) of the Faith often wear a roughly made glove puppet of a rat on their right hand. Scholars are divided as to the meaning of this symbol, some postulating that it shows that ultimately every rat is but a puppet of Slavik whilst others see it as a symbol that when they speak the leaders of the vermin do so with the voice of the Nine Tails. Certainly, those of the Ratfolk who develop neuronic ability tend to use their powers 'through' the puppet (if only in a purely theatrical sense),



The Nine Tails

Mathercurdle the Survivor
Latherwisp the Mother
Loathvile the Sneaky
Bracetwitch the Watcher
Spittlewipe the Thief
Snatchgather the Bully
Whisperguile the Advisor
Brittlewheeze the Diseased
Scourlimp the Dead

Allies and Foes

Worse than poisoned meat and summer light
Worse than once Mathercurdle's plight
Is the evil oath-breaker Knight...

The Church of Slavik distances itself from other Churches since it is, by its very nature, given to survival and the eternal present. Ratfolk are not the most trusting of people and if they were prone towards any Faiths they are most likely to aid those who follow more Primal Gods since, despite the Deific nature of their own God, they are firmly part of Primus.

If there is one universal hatred they share it would be for the Knights of the Land. A former Lord Knight swore an oath to the Ratfolk that he would find land for them where they might prosper and be safe. The land provided was then 'conveniently' used as a battleground between the Empire and the Far North and many vermin were killed as they fled.

The most prominent of the survivors entered Thimon (which was then a place of desperate disease and a dwindling population). Rather than fulfil their oath, the Knights of the Land attacked the vermin in force and killed hundreds of the Ratfolk. The rats are a fast breeding and often short lived race but if they remember or care about only one thing from their past – it is this.

Tenets

Traitor, traitor – lost to we
Though he hide by house or tree
Though he scuttle in the day
Though most hated of the fray
In his death we find our play!

Traitor, traitor – evil's bride
Rat who lives from Slavik denied
Turnskin traitor, hide in night
Run from we in terrible flight
His life is short, his time is slight...

The Church of Slavik is focussed on survival more than any other aspect and it is this that drives the Faith. Even if the world falls then the rats will struggle to survive – not matter the cost. There is a curious flipside to this for many of the faithful in that they will often strive to forge strong links with people and cities that have shown themselves to be attendant to their views but ultimately it is the survival of the Ratfolk that is the guiding premise of the Faith.

Ratfolk that do not give their prayer to Slavik run counter to this and therefore are to be hunted down and killed without exception. There is no Tail that is given to betrayal of the vermin.

Commentary

The story of Ratfolk in the Empire is perhaps one of the more shameful chapters of Imperial history. It is also one of the most disputed and acrimonious parts of recent Imperial History. Generally attitude is polarised between the view held by the Knights of the Land: "We did everything in our power to help you" and that of the Ratfolk: "You came and slaughtered us in our nests. You sought to exterminate us." As a result the Ratfolk in general hate Knights of the Land with a passion that seems to grow with each generation, and the Ratfolk breed fast.

Temple of the Rose

High Priest: Rhiannon

Guild Founder: Rhiannon

Spherical Leaning: Communication

Centres of Religion: Halgar

Symbol:

Requirements: To be ordained as a Rosarian priest, a Lay member must be able to demonstrate basic competency with weapons and armour. They swear loyalty to the Faith and to the Empire, and pledge their lives to its defence. Religious dress is a black robe, some form of armour, and a weapon. It is a religious consideration to *always* carry armour and weapon; the only exception to

this is in the Inner City of Halgar.

Miracle List ~ Lawful Neutral

1st: Cure Wound, Detect Spirit's Nature, Halt, Spirit of Seeing
2nd: Spirit of Seeing and Hearing
3rd: Cure Disease, Protection from Spirits, Spirit Shield, Talk to Spirit, Detect Lie
4th: Communication I, Spirit Bolt, Control Ghoul
5th: Minor Ward of Power, Spiritual Invisibility
6th: Control Wraith, Total Heal
8th: Communication II

Ethos

An almost militaristic order, the Rosarians are karmic reincarnationists with no deity as such, however they do believe in a *source* of all knowledge, or rather that while all knowledge is attainable, it is only the mind of the person that limits the knowledge. They do not pray to this 'source' as such but do attempt to connect with it through willpower, rigorous self-control and meditation. It is said that the most disciplined Rosarians could achieve a state known as *Vorder* or enlightenment, in which knowledge was made plain to them. They had connected to the Source of all knowledge. The seeking of knowledge and universal Truths is the core of their belief. Also fundamental to the Rosarians are the lives and deaths of past 'heroes' of the order: *The Jinnar* who have achieved enlightenment and have transcended the wheel of life. These spirits act as go-betweens for the Rosarians from the Spirit realm to the physical realm. Rosarians will often invoke the 'spirit' of a particular Jinnar, while a task is being attempted. This is not in a religious manner; these entities are benevolent and tend to behave like retired officers, or a member of the family. It should be noted that these entities are invoked in a similar manner to shamanic ancestors.

In this way they are a lot like Hermit priests or Shamans in that they perform their "miracles" without recourse to a deity – spirits under their will are bent to perform the task. However unlike Hermit priests or Shamans they lead a very ordered lifestyle. Also, because they understand that the world is a violent place, all Rosarians are trained in the ways of combat, both armed and unarmed. Because of the nature of their priests, former soldiers and archivists etc and the nature of the talents and organisational skills, the Rosarian faith has always had strong links to the Imperium. They follow a strict militaristic adherence to a chain of command.

They have a strong belief in reincarnation, and as such are quite blasé attitude to death, corpses and undead; they regard undead as tools, being as they are spirits bound into dead flesh. Likewise their disciplined training leaves them with a slightly superior attitude. This means they will generally allow people to suffer the results of the mistakes, believing that they should learn from them. All this leads to their attitude to curing. Rosarians treat their talent for healing as a closely guarded secret. They will not heal those who ask for it, believing that they should learn to fight/parry with more skill and will only cure unconscious allies in extremis. It is considered a breach of discipline (read; a sin) to heal an outsider. A Rosarian who performs a miracle of healing upon an outsider or is healed by an outsider is expected to present him or herself to the Abbot to explain himself. Some form of penance is usually meted out, which the Rosarian will have to abide. Typical penances include: not drinking herbal curatives, not receiving spiritual healing, performing a task for the benefit of the Order.

This attitude extends to herbal curing potions. Central to the Rosarian creed is the reliance on self. This means that a member of the Order will not carry or drink more than a bottleful (normally about ten doses) of healing draughts in a day, as an over reliance on these potions leads to sloppiness.

In short, Rosarians are seekers of knowledge, with a militaristic view to life, for whom training and self-discipline are essential parts of day-to-day life. They are cautious with outsiders, and have a slightly superior attitude. They refer to themselves by name as "...of the Rose". Thus Gerren, Rosarian priest, would define himself as "Gerren of the Rose".

They refer to each other as Brother/Sister, e.g. *Brother Gerren*, and the Head of the Faith is referred to by Rosarians as Abbot-Marshall or just Abbot, although the old Imperial term 'vo', meaning the person who is the head of the Faction / Church / Great House for the purposes of Imperial bureaucracy, is normally used by the Abbot-Marshall when dealing with outsiders.

Holy Day

12th Martius ~ Remembrance [Holy Day]

This is one of the Rosarian faith's veneration festivals. The priests give thanks to past 'heroes' whose example inspires them.

1st Aiprus ~ Asiet [True Holy Day]

This day is very special to the Rosarians. It commemorates the day when they first took up arms. Traditionally Rosarians will give gifts of sticks to their friends to their friends and comrades, although in later years this has become more symbolic, with people giving confectionary or bread sticks instead.

28th Maii ~ Spring Vigil [Shadow Day]

On this day Rosarians stand a symbolic vigil over their weapons. This is a required "day of rest" for Rosarians who will only travel with the Father-Superiors permission.

7th Orgus ~ Remembrance Secundus [Holy Day]

This is one of the Rosarian faith's veneration festivals. The priests give thanks to past "heroes" whose example inspires them.

27th Orgus ~ Summer Vigil [Shadow Day]

On this day Rosarians stand a symbolic vigil over their weapons. This is a required 'day of rest' for Rosarians who will only travel with the Father-Superiors permission.

21st Septus ~ Taunest Serie [Holy Day]

The Festival of Enlightenment - a day on which Rosarians seek knowledge in a hope to achieve "Vorder" or enlightenment. Traditionally Rosarians engage each other in tests of wits, such as puzzles or logic problems.

The Rings Of Talthar

Name of Deity: Talthar

High Priest: Aven

Avatar: Harpell~Who~Is~Elbrime

Avatar: Thor~Who~Is~Justice

Guild Founder: Aven

Spherical Leaning: None

Diametrical Opposition: Valcoma

Centres of Religion: Alguz (Cathedral), Bildteve, Scarlene and Caer Talthar

Symbol: Seven interlocking rings forming a circle

Miracle List ~ Neutral Good

1st: Cure Wound, Halt

2nd: Cure Serious Wounds

3rd: Cure Disease, Dismiss Ghoul, Bless, Talk to Spirit, Spirit Shield, Protection from Spirits

4th: Heal, Spirit Bolt

5th: Voice of Power, Remove Voice of Power, Spiritual Invisibility

6th: Total Heal, Regeneration, Dismiss Vampire

8th: Restore Life

Ethos

Talthar is the Lord of Hope, a burning beacon of inspiration to his followers. Whilst the vast majority of Talthar's priests spend their time ministering to their congregations within the Church of Talthar works a dedicated core of worshipers, these are known as The Rings of Talthar. The Rings of Talthar are some of the most fervent worshipers of the Lord of Hope, those of the faith imbued with Vitae.

Tenets of the faith

- Hope is eternal and enduring.
- Hope is the bright light that shines in the heart of all.
- Hope is the sure and certain knowledge of the blessings to come.
- Hope is changing and constant.

The Tenets Explained

"Hope is eternal and enduring"

There is no beginning and no ending to true Hope. It exists and always shall exist. Men may turn away from Hope, but it will always be there for them to embrace. No catastrophe is too great, no disaster too terrible to extinguish Hope. It is in the times when things look darkest that there is the most need and chance for Hope.

"Hope is the bright light that shines in the heart of all"

All men have the capacity and potential for Hope. All who think and feel can acknowledge the brightness of the future and embrace the ways of Hope. Some may choose not to, and it is to these the teachings of the faith should look to. Some may choose to deny Hope to others, and this is the greatest sin of all. Those who turn their backs on Hope and who deny Hope to others should be stopped. This may be through peaceful word and actions, talking to change the view of a wicked man, or it may be through violence, to take the life of such a man such that others may have Hope. This tenant is perhaps the most controversial of the teachings of Talthar, that to take a life denies Hope to that person, but allows the soul to move on, that there is a different form of Hope for the dead.

"Hope is the sure and certain knowledge of the blessings to come"

Hope is not selfish; it is a bright and good thing. Hope is more than simply wanting a better house, or more money. It is the unselfish giving Hope for others that is important, cherished and holy. It can be simple and every day, such as wanting a relative to get well, or for the family to have enough food to eat. It can be deep and complicated, Hope for your neighbours spiritual welfare.

"Hope is changing and constant"

Constant in the fact that it is ever present. Constant in its nature. Changing in its method, in people's perception of its nature. Changing in terms of the comfort that individuals gain from Hope.

The Aspects

Whilst Talthar himself is worshiped as the true Lord of Hope, the faith preaches that there are seven Aspects of Hope, and the symbol of the faith reflects this: seven circles inter-linked to form one large circle. Within the faith there are those who would dedicate their service to but one of the Aspects of Hope, seeking perfection of Faith or perhaps just understanding, in their singleness of worship. The majority however, worships Talthar as a whole, seeking to bring each of the seven Aspects to work in their lives.

Subtlety: Hope unlooked for

One of the most commonly found and yet most profound of the Aspects. It is about performing a kindness without thought of reward, recognition or even acknowledgement. Be it leaving a gift of bread for a widow or canceling the debt of a man who owed more than he has. It is giving unselfishly.

Renewal: Hope in new life

The aspect is tied most closely with the after life and the rebirth. Those that service the aspect are commonly responsible for conducting funerals, comforting grieving families, blessing the newborn and such. If anything those that serve the aspects perform many of the daily duties you would expect a priest to do. It is, however, not uncommon to find those that serve the aspect take a more militant stance, sometimes being confused with the servants of Elbrime. The simple theory being that some people in this mortal life have sinned so much that, while there is still hope for them, they will bring too much suffering to this world before they find redemption so they should be sent to the next life in the hope they will learn from their mistakes and move on.

Unity: Hope through standing together

When men work together more can be achieved than any working as a lone figure. This is what the aspect embodies. Helping those that need you, lending aid where you can. Co-operating to achieve an end. While one man can build a barn in a week, two could build it in three days, while four in but a day. It is through this that a greater hope can be achieved and found.

Serenity: Hope from within

The Aspect of Serenity is an inward looking philosophy. Self-examination, prayer and meditation are tools of the Serene. Serenity teaches acceptance of ones own place in the world, of how a person can best serve those around him. It is a virtue of modesty and humility.

Diplomacy: Hope for Peace

Those that serve Diplomacy are often counters to Justice and Adversity. They would seek to find compromise and agreement to resolve a problem. While the solution they reach will not always be the best solution it will be the one that keeps the most people happy, and preserves hope for as many people as possible. It could be said that the servants of Diplomacy look to the now and seek to give those that live here and now the best life possible.

Justice: Hope for what is right

Often confused with the concept of law and order Justice has nothing to do with the mundane laws of the world, but the heavenly mandates of God. In a world where darkness exists, where people seek to gain from others suffering, where men deceive and cheat others, where people call upon the powers of the darker lords, Justice moves to counter this. The laws of men are made by those in power as a means to hold power, the laws of heaven are made so that all may learn and become stronger. It is the duty of Justice to protect the weak, to avenge wrongs upon the innocent, to seek out those that have turned from the light of heaven and try to show them the error of their ways. It is the duty of the priests to stand against the lies and falsehoods of mortal society that lead to the laws of heaven being hidden or denied to mortal man.

Adversity: The last, desperate, Hope

Often seen as the most militant of the aspects, and indeed in the present day it. Those that follow this aspect, and its embodiment Elbrime are seen as the

warriors of the faith. All are skilled in the arts of battle to one form or another. It is their duty to stand and fight when all seems lost, when everything says defeat is at hand those that serve this aspect will fight on to the death for it is the act of trying and continuing to struggle no matter the odds that matters, for even when everything else is lost they still have hope.

Words of Harpell

We the Church of Talthar are, above all things, charged to bring Hope to all peoples of all places. Any who are willing to let the light that hope brings into their hearts will be welcomed and will find solace with the church. We will not discriminate against race or creed as long as the individual or group concerned truly wishes to be comforted.

Our second duty is to oppose by will and arms those who would bring harm to our charges, or those who would act to take hope from another. We will stand united and strong against the Darkness of Despair.

Upon Primus we will work with the established governments of any and all lands be they North, South, East or West to ensure that the peoples of Primus have Hope in their hearts. We will however, with or without the aid of these governments, discharge our duties to those we are responsible for.

Harpell.

History

Those who follow Talthar in the new age owe their calling to the workings of a band of mercenaries active during the Second Age. Few of these still travel, fewer still as the mortal men they once were. The priests who were to become the Rings of Talthar discovered much of His teachings upon a plane known now as Razcar and brought word of the faith to Primus. It was through their work and their faith that the Aspect of Hope in Adversity was awakened and revived to consciousness, the God that is Elbrime arose to join his father. With the turn of the last year the aspect that is Justice awakened and entered the world, though at this stage it is still young and barely awakened.

Towards the end of the second age, after the death of the emperor Ceres Amora the faith of Talthar turned its attention towards the city of Ickybiggle and worked there amongst noble and peon alike to bring word of their God to any who would hear.

When the city of Ickybiggle was destroyed at the turning of the age the faith moved to Alguz at the invitation of the city's governor. In short order the city became a shining beacon of Hope and the Cathedral to Talthar was constructed, a home for the God of Hope.

The church has also long battled against the Church of Malice, and it's Goddess Valcoma (though few of the church ever mentioned her name). Her faith almost mirrors the church of Talthar, were they seek to bring hope, She brings despair, where they would bring Truth and Justice, She brings lies and injustice, where they would bring unity, She brings discord.

While the church has little, but growing, influence on Primus it holds a great deal on Lansas and seeks to use this to encroach on the Empire.

Recently the church has also been forced into battle with the Spiter. The Primal deity using several of the priesthood's dislike of the Empire to blame them for various acts and drive further wedges between them and the Empire.

The Modern Church

To this day the church of Talthar works spread throughout the lands of the Empire and beyond. It's members share a bond of fellowship, but are free to seek their own paths in the world. Some of Talthar's faithful work alone in small villages, while others congregate around larger areas.

Holy days

The day of Awakening (Renewal)

The holy day celebrates the birth of the new-year. It is a day of Joy and celebration. Prayers are held in temples through out the morning. The afternoon is set aside for preparations and come the evening a feast is held with merriment and much drinking lasting into the small hour. It, unsurprisingly, takes place on the first day of the year.

The day of Gifts (Subtlety)

The day takes place on the 21st Juon. For the month before hand all of those within the congregation of the church place their names in a large in the church. The week before the day the names are pulled out by the congregation. Each then buys a present for the person they have pulled and leaves it at the temple. No one say's who the gifts are from, it is a simple gift given to bring happiness to those around you.

Day of Purity (Justice)

Celebrated on the longest day of the year. It marks the fact, that in this time, the light out ways the darkness. It is very metaphorical in it's nature and is often ignored by the smaller temples. It is very much a day for the priest hood of the faithful. The day begins with the sunrise. Prayers are conducted and the day takes on a very purposeful tone. The various Oaths members of the church have taken are re-affirmed, especially those of the Paladins. New members of the church are often anointed on this day. The day concludes just before sunset with the lighting of a candle on the altar of the temple. One of the gathered priesthood then remains awake all night in prayer, ensuring the candle does not die or fade.

Aranal's Day (Diplomacy)

The tale of Aranal comes from the plane of Razcar. Aranal was a young noble man, heir to a vast fortune. Whilst serving in his nation's army Aranal fell in battle and was captured by his enemies. In prison he impressed his captors with his humility and kind nature, by his willingness to work at the most menial of tasks. He found the time while he worked to speak with his jailors and to tell them of his faith. There came a time when his homeland paid for Aranal's ransom and he was set free. Rather than return to his estates and riches Aranal remained within the realm of his foes. There he worked to spread the Word of Talthar among the people and thus he spent his life. While no one is certain when the actual release or capture occurred but the day is celebrated on 10th October, the day he died.

Day of Flowering (Adversity)

An odd day, considering the nature of many of the aspects followers. The day is celebrated when the first flower of spring blossoms in the Cathedral gardens. The celebrations go on for a week afterwards. The celebrations is a giving of thanks that the hardships of the winter have been endured, much as the flower has survived against the frosts, rain, winds and snow the people have strived and come through the difficulties of the winter. Many would consider this closer to a celebration of Renewal but its origins lie in members that worshipped adversity and were not militant in their

outlook.

Searching (Serenity)

A very personal day, rather than a festivity. One of the least popular times in the Talthari calendar the day of Searching is foreshadowed by a week of fasting within the hours of sunlight, meditation and careful prayer. It is a time where a person considers the wrongs they have done in their life and seeks absolution. It is traditional that on the day following the day of Searching a Talthari will seek out a person he has wronged and seek forgiveness, and that he will forgive any wrong done to him and seek to be at peace with all men. The day itself occurs on the last Sunday of Novaus.

Coming together (Unity)

On this weekend the priests of the Faith spend two days within their local place of worship. The first day of the weekend is spent in prayer and fellowship. The priests share something of their lives with one another, just spending time in one another's company. On the second day members of the faith travel to reach the largest place of worship they can get to, villagers will travel to local towns and whole communities will journey to a city temple rather than their local shrine. The highest-ranking priest present leads worship and the afternoon is typically spent relaxing and enjoying the companionship of the faithful. Children especially are brought along and games and races are organised for them. It is somewhat traditional for members of the faith to be married, or to propose marriage, during this celebration. The weekend occurs on the first weekend of summer.

The day of Hope (A high Holy day to the entire faith)

Officially celebrated on 1st Maii the festival lasts closer to a fortnight. Prayers begin a week before the actual day in the Holy places of the church and continue daily till the day itself. The week after the day is taken up with games, feasts, exchanging of presents and in general joyous celebrations. The day is there to commemorate the founding of the modern church when the seven, Aven, Harpell, Boggins (now Galdor), Unable, Liteheart, Yosam, Lothas and Krishak, answered Talthars call as the first hopefuls did. The sermons throughout the week tend to contain the words from older teachings, harking back to the roots of the church forgotten by the younger members of the priest hood.

Shadow Days

Winters fall (Renewal)

The day the first snow of December falls on the cathedral of the faith marks this day, or rather week. It is a week offering remembrance for the fallen. Offerings prayers for those that have passed on in the previous year, and years previous. It is a marking of the end of the life and preparation for the new one to be ushered in.

Day of Lies (Subtlety)

Occurring on the 7th Moonsday of the year, the temples open their doors to the faithful. All then come to the priest and confess the deceptions and lies of the past year to him that have brought harm to others. He then tells them how things should be put right. Never is the penance an obvious one, those benefiting from the acts do not know why, or even if possible from whom.

Day of the Fall (Justice)

The day remembers the fall of Glaval on the first day of Autumn (the day he fell). Glaval a priest of the faith that was captured by the followers of despair and slowly over time lost his faith and turned to the path of the Dark Lady of Despair. Then he was cast from her embrace left shattered having betrayed his oaths to his

Lord, lied to his friend and himself. Left to forever suffer knowing he was a traitor to those he had once held dear.

Islanil's Tears (Diplomacy)

This is a day when the faithful consider the horrors of war. A day of quiet mourning for those who have lost love ones to violence, a day to gather and remember mutual friends. It is said the day, the 17th of Octuar, is the day that the steps of the High temple in Razcar ran red with the blood of the faithful as they sought to hold it against the forces of despair. While successful many fell on that fateful day.

Day of the Fallen Hero (Adversity)

The day is a calm and solemn one. Services commence in the holy places at sunset. They consist of each of the candles in the temple being extinguished, except for the Altar candle. Then the story of Francis is read. The tale is one of a simple priest of the church striving to carry the word of Talthar through a land ruined by Despair, whose people were all but lost and the battle she endured. Of the conflicts he fought, with words as often as blade. The story ends with his eventual defeat on the steps of an Altar to the Goddess of despair, striving to save the women he loved from being sacrificed. Francis' acts are remembered on the 17th of Aiprus, the day he is said to have entered the church and began his fight at the steps of her altar.

The day of Madness (Serenity)

The origin of this day is shrouded in myth. Most tales state that this is the anniversary of the day, the 4th of Februar, the then High Priest of the Faith was stricken with madness, a crushing insanity that led him to believe that he was Talthar incarnate and that all who did not subscribe to this view should be put to the sword. The carnage that followed is said to be a sad time in the annals of the faith. It is unknown if the tale is true, but what is true is that any priest of the faith who seeks the calmness of meditation on this day will be troubled by cruel visions of violence and bloodshed.

The day of fracturing (Unity)

The most recent addition to the calendar. The day is remembered on 26th Martius. It marks the culmination of a dispute between various factions in the church over suicide. Some said that any act of killing one self was a sin, while others said they giving of one's life so others may live was the greatest act that could perform. Why this dispute began is uncertain but it resulted in at least one priest leaving the church, and left tension with the faithful for months to come. The day is one of remembering this dispute and also that no matter what the argument it should not break a friendship, or come so close to shattering a faith.

Avatars of the Aspects

~ Harpell; He-who-is-Elbrime ~

Once a mortal man, and the physical guardian of the faith, the past of Harpell is shrouded in mystery. Few outside the faith know of his actions before embracing the teachings of Talthar. As the church gathered followers the aspect of Adversity, Elbrime, saw a need to walk on the mortal world to guide and protect its faithful. Choosing from those present at the time Harpell became its Avatar. Slowly as time passed the two become closer till soon Harpell become one with Elbrime.

Now Harpell can be found across the Empire, and beyond, aiding in battles where he can. He is well known for disregard, and often disdain, for mortal law.

~ Thor; He-who-is-Justice ~

For a long time a mortal priest of Talthar called Thor worshipped no aspect, just his Lord as a whole. Eventually his Lord called upon him to enter the fold of the Angels, as he was needed to fight on a heavenly level. Finally at the close of the 2nd year of the third age, after the Aspect that is Justice was released from the prison it had been held in, Thor was gifted with the ring of Truth, Justice and Honesty. Taking this ring the power of the Aspect slowly began to infuse with Thor, and eventually he walked in the mortal realm as Harpell walks for Elbrime. Thor is often seen in Alguz preaching at the Cathedral to his lord there. He is perhaps the most fanatical priest when it comes to spreading his Lord's word having been responsible for many of the temples in the Empire. He is also widely known for his dislike of the Empire and the Nobles' preaching regarding the significance of the Throne of Glass.

Major Exponents of the Faith:

~ Aven ~

The metaphorical son of Talthar, Aven was once a renowned and famous mercenary of the empire, now Aven has faded into the background. He travelled from the faith after disagreements over his father's teachings. He searched within himself and undertook a pilgrimage that spanned the worlds for nigh on a year. He returned to the faithful a quieter and more thoughtful man, the burdens he once had gone. Rarely seen acting as a mercenary, Aven currently holds a position on the Senate and can be found in the various temples and shrines across the empire.

~ Baron Selgard ~

In keeping with the nature of the aspect of Subtlety, the Aspect he follows, very little is actually known about the psionicist known as Selgard, although there is much rumour and conjecture. He is known to be a staunch supporter of the Empire, and has held a number of positions within the Inquisition, as well as being ennobled. His methodology can be summed up in the phrase "use what works", which occasionally leads to a conflicts of viewpoint with some of his fellow Talthari, but his support of both the Church and Faith of Talthar has never faltered.

~ Galdor Bogginson ~

Galdor, one of the few founders of the guild and current Governor of the Holy City of Alguz is still active upon Primus. Unsurprisingly he is often seen in Alguz, attending to his duties as Governor, holding sermons in the cathedral or tending to the needs of the citizens. He is known for his hatred of the foul creatures of undeath, and more than one evil priest has thought better than to try and summon undead in his presence.

~ Baron Saul Omacron ~

A priest of Elbrime Saul is the third son of Baron Ullion Omacron. He is often seen in Alguz, the city he governs, aiding its people. He has been slowly withdrawing from political activity (He is a former senator and candidate for Emperor at one stage) over the past 2-3 years. He now mainly concentrates on aiding the city he was born to. Saul is a skilled diplomat and often speaks for the church on political matters, his skill at arms however is not to be shied at, when combined with the spiritual power he draws from Elbrime he can be a truly fearsome foe.

~ Tasha ~

In her life Tasha was the daughter of a winter elf tribe from the chilling fields, her father an unknown human man. She found the faith of Talthar and became one of its strongest guardians. Upon her mortal death the Lord Talthar took her soul to his side and shaped her a new body, one suited to acting in his name and guarding the

faithful, an Angel. She returned more driven and focussed in her goal. During the day of Fracturing Tasha became disillusioned with the mortal faith and it's actions, believing to give one's life, as she had done many times, so another would have hope was the greatest of acts. She turned her back and left the temple that day and has not been seen since. Some say she returned to the Heavens to seek solace in the arms of her Lord, others that she still walks Primus spreading the word of the Lord but avoiding the faithful, most likely only Talthar knows the truth.

~ Gravain ~

A staunch protector of the faith Gravain stands over six foot tall. He has long given his life to ensure the ideals and goals of the church are met. A kind man, Gravain carries a smile on his face in all but the gravest of situations. He was often seen now days in Halgar acting as Senatorial attaché to Duke Stoneheart but now more often carrying out his duties as Watch Captain of Alguz. He has recently been taken into the arms of his Lord Elbrime, his body changed and rebuilt into that of an Angel of Battle.

~ Rand ~

A quiet man Rand found the faith at a young age. He grew up on the streets of Scarlene. He often says the church saved him from a much worse life, but never comments what. Rand is, often, very calm and collected letting others argue and row while he stands and tries to resolve the issue with words. However when angered he is a powerful warrior, using his magical skills to great effect. Rand is little seen these days, though people occasional speak of seeing him moving through various cities and towns tending the needy, or sitting in silent prayer at the back of a temple to his Lord.

~ Egor ~

The first Paladin of the modern faith, Egor was never really suited to the role, he was full of pride. The spirits of light turned from Egor when he murdered an evil priest in a way so foul as to be no better than that whom he slew. Talthar thought took pity on Egor for his work in defending the less militant members of the church with his very life. He was then put through a test by the spirits of light, one that rocked all Egor believed in to his very soul. Out came not the Egor those had known before but a much more humble man who was cast in the role of Champion of Good on Primus. This role seemed to fit well as Egor was always the first to step to the aid of any in need and would always be gone again before any thanks was given. Then came the event that nearly shattered his faith and all bar destroyed the man. He was placed in a situation where he stood to either have to murder an innocent or let his lifelong friend Thagor die. That day Thagor did not die but the man that was Egor was no more.

After that event Egor withdrew from life amongst the church and even from that as a mercenary, he instead took on the role of farmer. He stayed here for close to two years, no one knows where or what happened during this time, and Egor does not speak of it. After this he came back to the faith, not looking for forgiveness, as he in himself does not believe he deserves it, but meaning to serve out his days doing whatever he can to make life better for those in need.

Egor has recently undergone a change, his mortal form slowly becoming that of an Angel. Little is seen of him; occasionally he can be seen praying at a shrine or temple in a small village. He rarely visits the centres of the faith and is a man that keeps much of himself to himself. Men have commented that he seems to carry the woes of the faith on his shoulders.

~ Charles Featherstonehaugh ~

Charles Featherstonehaugh is the second son of the late Leopold Featherstonehaugh, who's family is distantly related to House Omacron by marriage and is a retainer of that House. He has recently become a Councillor of the Physicians Guild House. Charlie, as he is more commonly known, cares for the people of the land and strives to help them in any way he can. Though a priest, he is never parted from his trusty bread knife and faithful lump hammer.

Commentary

Lead by Thor the Church has been expanding across the Empire with remarkable speed. The only major faith to currently possess a Cathedral this has been in place for some time in Alguz. The aspect of Talthar that at this time is the most prominent is that of Elbrime. In our troubled times this is hardly surprising when the only solution to problems seems to be that of bourne arms. However it is easy to overlook the other aspects of the faith that as a whole serve to produce a goodly faith of surprising balance and harmony.

Watching-Owl

The Servants of Evil

Guild Head: Diomedes

Name of Deity: None

High Priest: Diomedes

Head of the House Fylaas: Elan

Symbol: An ornate Dagger, the colour depends on the house of the member.

Prerequisites: The non-deific embracing of spirits of Darkness has allowed the Church to gather under its wing all manner of users of the Dark Arts. As a result this guild may be joined and benefited from by any Evil Spirit User *who is not already a member of another church*. This includes Anti-Paladins, Hermit Priests, Witches et cetera, who retain their own miracle lists.

Miracle List ~ Neutral Evil

1st: *Halt, Detect Spirit's Nature, Spirit of Seeing*

2nd: *Animate Zombie*

3rd: *Protection from Spirit, Animate Skeleton*

4th: *Control Ghoul, Spirit Bolt, Create Ghoul, Beguile Spirit*

5th: *Spiritual Invisibility, Voice of Power, Create Mummy*

6th: *Control wraith, Summon Wraith, Spiritual Mastery*

8th: *Summon Vampire*

Ethos

The guild draws power from the thousands of nameless malign spirits that reside in the Netherworld, binding and summoning them to this mortal realm for their own purpose. The guild is not, as many evil churches are, out to 'Destroy the world' or even 'Enslave everyone for our Lord' instead its members seek to gain a deeper understanding and mastery over the arts of necromancy. Members will often make unholy bargains with dark powers to further their own goals.

The church also advises it's members to cast its variety of raising miracles on those bodies which have no vitae and when a sacrifice is required it is one that would be slain anyway. The church has no desire to start a full scale war with the followers of the various goodly deities.

Tenets of the faith

- Life, and unlife, is to be lived. Do not cower but take it to it's fullest
- Knowledge of the spirits, no matter what sort, leads to power, seek it.
- We are our own person and not bound by others. Do not tether yourself to another's will.

History

The church itself is an exceptionally weak one over the Empire. Its origins are hazy at best. It appears that the church came to be through the actions of Lord Ullion, Abashi of Death as part of a soothspakken involving the Triune of the second age. Many dismiss this, though no one, except maybe the High priest, knows for sure. The church was little more than a gaggle of priests that went around unleashing undead on the

Empire and killing at random, those these days have past.

The Modern Church

The church is unique in many ways. Firstly it does not have a deity of any form, instead it's members draw power from the various spirits that exist. In many ways it more resembles a mages academy with members drawing together to learn from others and to gain knowledge beyond what they previously had.

In recent changes Diomedes has begun to institute a structure to the faith. Due to the diverse nature this proved difficult but has been achieved, at least in theory.

The High Priest rules the church; a quote he has been heard to use is "Of course my church is a democracy. One man one vote and I'm the one man". He is however advised by a council of the church. The head of each of the orders within the church makes up the council. Currently only Elan as the head of House Fylaas has taken a seat upon the council, mainly because the church is so short.

Obviously rumours exist that the church is somehow trying to take over the world, or destroy it. Or that they secretly serve a darker patron, or even are ruled by an elite group of the church dedicated to spreading their own power. These are however all false; well that's what the church say's. However the current High priest has been involved in thwarting various threats to Primus, as have other members of his faith.

The orders within the church are: House Dethosis, House Mendaris and House Fylaas and further details of the Houses are found below

House Dethosis

The house is dedicated to the study of Necromancy. Currently the most powerful of the orders, and the one the current High priest is aligned to. The house teaches that Necromancy has three aspects to it. The summoning, the Control of and the Banishing of Undead. Many of the houses number specialise in the summoning of undead, while few, if any have any true degree of skill in the banishing of undead.

The ideal of the house is to be able to summon, control and banish any undead they may need. Those that dedicate themselves wholly to this study are rarely seen outside the churches simple because there powers do not lend themselves to the mercenary community.

The Dagger of the House is Silver

House Mendaris

The order is dedicated to self-mastery and inner control. They tend to be skilled in the arts of

Divine Guidance

controlling people's desires and emotions. They also tend to be strong willed and dedicated. The head of the faith normally comes from this order, though with the collapse of the church and lack of members they could not dispute the rise of the current head.

The dagger for the house is a bronze colour

House Fylaus

Dedicated to the arts of wound weaving and blood sacrifice. They are perhaps the weakest of the orders, though the ones most suited to life as a mercenary. What exactly their practices are is shrouded in mystery. Already the High Priest because of the nature of the sacrifices they make has removed several of them.

The dagger of the house is a blood red.

Holy days

31st October: ~ The joining of worlds.

Celebrated by the faith as the day when the walls between the Netherworld, where many draw their power from, and the Primal planes are at the thinnest. Spirits find it easier to cross over, and more power can often be drawn on this day.

It is custom for all of the church to gather as the sunsets and perform a single rite to draw this power to grant them all strength for the coming year. It is also the day that many make new bargains with the various denizens of the grey lands.

The Tenets Explained

Life, and unlife, is to be lived. Do not cower but take it to

it's fullest

A strange law for a church often believed to be Necromancers. The ideal is simply meant to mean do not be afraid to try, or to die. Death is not the end, as has been proved many times. To hide and shy away from opportunity leads to weakness and self-doubt, avoid this wherever possible.

Knowledge of the spirits, no matter what sort, leads to power, seek it

No matter what form the knowledge takes it may prove of use to the church. If the opportunity arises take the knowledge and use it, otherwise pass it onto those that can. It is rumoured that the current High Priest can manipulate the spirits of light to heal others.

We are our own person and not bound by others. Do not tether yourself to another's will.

Believed to have arisen because of the nature of the churches conception and the manipulation of various parties involved by others. The fact that the church has no God and serves no Patron is seen as the results of this law. No member of the church should be bound in service to another. The church is here to grow and gain power, not to be used by others to gain power for them.

A prayer of the Faith

The truth is that life is hard and dangerous that he who seeks his own happiness does not find it that he who is weak must suffer that he who demands love will be disappointed that he who is greedy will not be fed that he who seeks peace will find strife that truth is only for the brave that joy is only joy is only for he who does not fear to be alone that life is only for one who is not afraid to die.

The Tryst

Name of Deity: None

High Priest: Barab Khan III

Guild Founder: Washall

Centres of Religion: Halgar

Symbol: The faith has various symbols:

- A multi-faceted Gem held aloft by a pair of demonic arms bound in chains or being borne aloft by a pair of demons.
- Deep reds and black coloured designs edged in silver.
- A clawed demonic hand.

Pre-requisites: Any Evil Priest can join this guild

Miracle List ~ Neutral Evil

1st: Halt, Power Meld,

2nd: Cause Wound, Spirit of Seeing and Hearing

3rd: Curse, Talk to Spirits, Spirit Shield, Cause Serious Wounds, Protection From Spirits

4th: Spirit Shift Spirit Bolt Cause Disease Create Ghoul

5th: Spiritual Invisibility, Cause Grievous Wounds

6th: Control Wraith, Steal Life Essence, Walk Through Walls*

7th: Suspend Life

Ethos

The Tryst is a church that draws spiritual power from the Imbaiu demons. It is important to understand that the church do not serve the Imbaiu, but binds and commands them. References to the Imbaiu Masters refer to those Imbaiu with mastery over lesser demons. The Imbaiu Masters that accept the bindings of the church do so because this link to Primus gives them strength upon their own worlds that they use to remain at the top of their demonic hierarchy.

The church's growing experience at dealing with demons

is making them increasingly more able to fight the many demonic invaders that incessantly attack Primus.

Notes From Aramis De'Ville

Under recent leadership, the Tryst has strongly aligned itself to the Empire, and power is used for the benefit of the Empire and the general populace, they believe very much that the end justifies the means. Members of the church should bear in mind that their high priest is a proud member of a strongly pro-imperial noble house and has in the past excommunicated priests for acting against the Empire or causing unjustified harm to ordinary people of the land.

Ancient Tryst

The Ancient Tryst were very firmly demonologists, servants of the Imbaiu seeking to duplicate the diabolic arts of the Ancient Folk. The fact that their High Priest Washall eventually became one of the Imbaiu that the Church served only highlighted this. The secrets that the Ancient Tryst had uncovered are now all but forgotten and this particular Chapter of their history was quite quickly hidden and some might say denied by the most progressive, and shrewd of their leaders, the outspoken Truthspeaker Lazarus Long.

Traditional Tryst

At the end of the Second Age the control of the Tryst fell to Truthspeaker Lazarus Long who espoused a different sort of Tryst. A man of quite some cunning man and diplomacy, as befits one who makes deals with demons, he did for a time prove to be a thorn in my side until discussion made him a great ally within the Inquisition which he served with great distinction.

Divine Guidance

He turned the powers of the Tryst to serve the Empire in a new way, yet made it seem that this had always been the way of the Tryst, he made known a great number of Traditions within The Tryst which only served to further the acceptance of the manipulation of demonic powers in the minds of the people. A testament to his skills as a diplomat lie in the fact that his church backed onto what at that time was the old Michaelian Cathedral in Halgar yet he never came to blows with the more militant amongst the Michaelians.

Eventually Truthspeaker Long left, where he has gone is unknown but the Church then fell firmly into the hands of the Empire with the leadership of Aramis De'Ville.

Modernised Tryst

The Modern Tryst under the guidance of Aramis De'Ville of House De'Ville are very strongly of the mind that the demonic powers they draw upon are there for the service of Primus. They use them as both tools and tutors that they might fight and understand the forces that seek to assail Primus. They are very much of the view that the primary Symbol of the Church is of Demons looking up to and supporting the Nagrech. As opposed to an interpretation that the symbol of a Demon bearing aloft a gem would represent the demonic forces seeking to run off with the Nagrech, the Empire and ultimately Primus.

Where it will go under the most recent change of leadership when the Aramis De'Ville left to join the faith of the Dead Heroes in memory of his dead kinsman the Custodian of Primus, Amora De'Ville, is a mystery waiting to be unravelled.

It is certain that the Inquisition will no doubt be keeping a close eye on the new leadership without its moderating influence of a De'Ville at the helm.

Holy Days

3rd Januar ~ The Festival Of Mortal Light [Shadow Day]



Mar'Eth

Spherical Leaning: Healing & Warding

Diametrical Opposition: Asa Volk & The Spiter

Centres of Religion: Scarlene, Keys and Port Miere

Symbol: A stylised fish, dolphin or staff made of bamboo

Requirements: Non-Chaotic, Goodly Priest. Hermits, Vivemancers and Friars may align to the guild and retain their own miracle lists. Paladin's may also join and benefit as full members.

Miracle List ~ Lawful Good

1st: Cure Wound, Summon Spiritual Candles, Halt

2nd: Cure Serious Wounds

3rd: Cure Disease, Healing Hand, Bless, Talk to Spirits, Spirit Shield, Protection from Spirits

4th: Heal

5th: Remove Fear and Paralysis, Remove Voice of Power, Spiritual Invisibility

6th: Total Heal, Spiritual Freedom, Stronghold of Goodness

8th: Restore Life

Name of Deity: Tsu Ling

High Priest: Sol

Guild Founder: Tsu Ling

Avatar: Ling Chan Noh
Panama

First Disciple: Shao-Ling Noh
Panama

Champion of the Way:

Tsu-Ling

Ethos

The Lingists follow the Ling Chan the teachings of Tsu-Ling, Oceanic god of Peace and Tranquillity.

They believe in promoting the cause of peace and aiding the lives of the common folk of Primus, protecting them from the ravages of war. As such the followers of this young demigod are primarily opposed to the teachings of the wargod Harpell~Who~Is~Elbrime. However this opposition is generally a philosophical one rather than one of actual battle with both Tsu-Ling and Harpell understanding that the "conflict" between them is for the hearts and minds of the people. Indeed the two deities have stood side by side to protect Primus with each employing their different methods for the same aim.

Restrictions

1. **Tranquillity:** May never use rages
2. **Peace:** May only attack in self defence
3. **Poverty:** Suffers Item restrictions as Paladin
4. **Restraint:** May only kill living creatures as a last resort

The Ling Chan [The Tenets of the Faith]

Treasure the Silence, for a Tranquil Mind can understand all mysteries

Promote peace and seek tranquillity. It is the tranquil mind that can hear the heart beat of a cricket and feel the breath of a bird for the greatest part of our world is rarely seen and rarely heard. Learn to listen and learn to watch.

A day of retreat for Tryst priests, a day when all reflect on their mortality, and how even great power cannot save their lives from destruction. This day commemorates the final death of the Second Master of Secrets of the Faith.

15th Martius ~ The Shadowed Herald [Holy Day]

The festival of the Shadowed Herald is a holy day for the servants of the Imbaiu, lords from other worlds, some named Daemon, others simply powerful entities in their own rites. The Shadowed Herald must be greeted on this day by followers of the Tryst less unfortunate things become of them.

23rd Juon ~ Faer-Dagaeum [Holy Day]

On this day the fires of the home of the Imbaiu burn strong and close to Primus, weak points develop and power leaks into the Empire.

15th Septus ~ The Dark Dawn Festival [True Holy Day]

Followers of the Imbaiu, Priests of the Tryst believe this day opens many paths to the hells that contain their masters. A powerful servant of the masters is deflected from Labyrinthia this day, power stolen from its entrance bringing woe to the commonfolk and diverted to the rites of the Tryst Priests, generally for the good of the Empire, even if in an evil fashion.

1st Octuar ~ Spritael Dagaeum [Shadow Day]

In respect of the collection to the Harvest, and the strength of spiritual goodness at this time, Spritael Dagaeum is a day of retreat for Priests of The Tryst, a low day when power for rite is less forthcoming from their gods.

Commentary

Not all heed, or all believed the words of Aramis De'Ville... The faith is old and murmurs exist that the older priests of the Church believe that it is still their duty to serve the Imbaiu. Even now there is talk of splits and schisms within the Church with even a recent sighting of Washall on Primus.

Learn the arts of battle that you may understand how easy it is to bring harm

Study the martial arts. They strengthen mind, body and soul, teach discipline and grant insight. See how many arts are dedicated to the infliction of pain and understand that it need not be so. Take heed and stay your hand. Never strike first and never strike a blow in anger.

Learn the arts of war that you may understand the art of diplomacy

Understand the General's arts. These are men who have devoted much time to study. The General knows not just how to wage a war but how to avoid a war. There may be a time when such knowledge can be used to keep a sword in its scabbard. If you prevent a sword leaving its scabbard, you may prevent a fight. If you prevent a fight you may prevent a battle, if you prevent a battle you may prevent a war. So do not despise the soldier's art.

Learn the arts of healing that you may lessen the pain of others

Study the arts of healing. It may be that only a snatch of knowledge may save one life. And if only one life is saved as a result of years of study it has been worth it. All life is precious. All life is sacred. All life has the right to be. It is our duty to respect life and where we can aid it.

Never let a cry for help go unanswered: It is the duty of each to help one another

Let the strong give strength to the weak.
Let the bold give courage to the meek.
Let the rich give coin to the poor.

You need not draw sword to defeat your enemy

Violence and conflict rarely bring anything other than violence and conflict. An enemy can be defeated in many ways. Strength of arms is not the only weapon. The truest way to defeat an enemy is to make him your friend.

A day's food, a night's shelter and a week's clothing are all the wealth a man needs

There is enough for each man's need but not enough for each man's greed: That which you take beyond your requirements deprives someone of theirs. If by good fortune you have then share with those who by misfortune have not. Do not be distracted by the search for wealth.

Contemplate upon the world around

Contemplate upon the world around you. It is wondrous to behold. Stop to feel the warmth of sun, the passing of the wind. From the balance of nature comes peace of mind and purity of spirit.

Meditate upon the world within

Be mindful of your inner eye. Listen to your inner voice. You are within. Let not those without distract you from who you are. Quiet meditation is essential to a peaceful mind.

Family is your strength

We all belong. In the first instance we belong to our family. We all have a place. Our first place is with our family.

Laughter is a gift

Never underestimate the gift of laughter. The rich and noble have their own amusements and the poor and common must make theirs. Life should be enjoyed. Laughter relieves the burdens of the poor and promotes brotherhood and fellowship. Where there is laughter and fellowship there is no need for war and strife.

The Considerations of Tsu Ling

These are the thoughts and considerations of a man on a journey. Does he know where his journey will end? Is it important? Or is it the manner by which he travels?

"Confuse not vengeance with justice, for vengeance is like an icy rage that burns the soul yet chills the heart."

Always be certain that what you seek is justice and not vengeance. Justice done will lead to calm, vengeance will deaden your heart and empty your soul. Be wary of your actions in such matters lest you deny yourself peace or deny another their redemption.

"When wrong, admit so. If you commit wrong apologise. If wronged forgive."

Our errors are our teachers remember that. There is no shame in error only shame in failing to heed those errors.

"The Future?"

What is the future? Who can truly say? Is it solid as the rock? Set in stone. Does it flow like a river changing course at whim? We cannot know our thoughts until we think them. We cannot know our actions until we take them. Why should the future be any different?

"The Path"

Each man must tread his own path. Not even his friends can tread it for him. You can no more tread the path for another than you can breathe their breath or pump their blood. You can however choose to walk with them wherever your paths cross.

"The Divine"

When a man has been touched by the Divine how can he look back? The end is but the beginning by another name. Where pools are still, where the Oceans roar and where streams are heard there will I be my love and thoughts for my friends and family.

"The Fellowship"

My journey has been marked by many events of no great import to any other than myself. But at each of these events one thing has been constant, the fellowship of many, many, good, good friends.

"The Gift"

My Avatar is my final gift to my friends. I summoned the vision he had. Shao-Ling, he is your student, teach him all he needs to know and guide him as he grows until he can understand his purpose.

"The Master"

Shao-Ling, you are Master now. Though you did not know it you ceased to be my student the moment you knew what must be done to defeat Ginawa. Do not underestimate yourself. That which was the final lesson I learnt from you.

"The Final Lesson"

[This lesson is only for the initiates of the faith and is generally known only to the most devout of disciples]

Major Exponents of the Faith

Sol

Little is known of Sol, The only thing which is known of his past that he was once a beggar of Port Miere before he found his faith, What is known is his dislike of battle and war and his never ending search for peace. Sol has now found a new home in the City Of Keys where he speaks daily of his faith and helps all those that need his help without asking for anything in return. Sol was granted the title of Squire of Armastas by the Empress for his continual help to the people and currently acts as Stadus for the City of Keys.

Mar'Eth

First Paladin of Tsu-Ling Mar'Eth is fearless in the face of evil and seeks always to protect the weak even at the price of his own life. He has a fondness for humour.

Living in Port Miere is simple attitude of being at one with the people there has lead him to be held in high regard.

Shao-Ling

First Disciple of Tsu-Ling little is known of Shao-Ling, a crystal Dragon of the Oriental Realms. What is said by Tsu-Ling is that it was a sacrifice made by Shao-Ling that enlightened him as to how ultimately to oppose the darkness of War and it was through a similar sacrifice he later made that he acquired his godhood.

Holy Days

The passing of time is important. Forget not that which has gone we are as much the past as we are the present. Listen to the rolling of the tides and the turning of the seasons for these serve to remind us that, while there are many dark forces in the world and no calm can last forever, it will, no matter how bad things get return. There will always be a place for peace and there will always be a time of tranquillity.

Tsu-Ling

1st Febuar ~ Day Of Tears [Shadow Day]

This Shadow Day is a day of remembrance and marks the first true death of Tsu Ling, from which he reincarnated as a fledgling Sea Spirit. Though it is a weakening of his power through the recollection of his own death it is, at his request, diligently observed by his followers and worshippers as a reminder that despite his current form of immortality he once had mortal form and lived as a mortal. It is called the Day of Tears both in recognition of the sorrow and as metaphor for the dangerous flowing of rivers swollen by the floodwaters of the Spring thaw.

5th Martius ~ Day Of Family [Holy Day]

This Day is a day of celebration of the importance of family whilst neither actually a Holy Day or Shadow day it is the day that Tsu Ling leads his followers in the Spring Festival of Fish. Thanking the deities of the Oceans for the Winter mercies and the sparing of loved ones from the seas ravages.

1st Maii ~ Day Of Tides [Holy Day]

This High Holy Day marks the great day of praise of the whole of the Pantheon of the Sea Gods. It is nothing more and nothing

less than a celebration of the life and the life giving nature of the Oceans, their majesty and their danger. It is a celebration of both the benevolence of the Sea for providing and of its destructive malevolence from which grows strength of mind, body and soul. The Summer Festival of Fish is held on this Holy Day

1st Orgus ~ Day Of Drought [Shadow Day]

At this time of the year the heat of Summer has scorched the land and the oceans feel its thirst as the rivers which feed the seas are weak and the natural order of things causes this Shadow Day to be felt, but this is a moment of anticipation, for whilst the oceans are at their weakest the coming of Autumn marks the beginning of a renewing of strength for the seas.

1st Novaus ~ Day Of Renewal [Holy Day]

This particular Holy Day is observed by the Sea Spirit Tsu Ling and his followers as the day of renewal. For on this day he is granted new energy and his Life Force is replenished. This day marks his Ocean given immortality. The Winter Festival of Fish is held around this day prior to the onslaught of winter, asking the sea gods to protect during the long winter months.

Commentary

Arguably this religion is less a religion and more a philosophy. When questioned as to whether he is a god Tsu-Ling's usual response is reported to simply be: "So it is said". There are of course two obvious possible reasons for such a response. Firstly, he is not a true deity and never claims to be. Secondly he believes that it is up to the individual to decide for themselves. Should the first statement be true then of course that has interesting implications for the nature of his fellow Primal Deities.

Events at the Cave in the Brandin Mountains at the time of The Choice show that he is at least the equal of the other Primal Deities.

At one of the Scarlene Fish Festivals, during the time of the Nagrech Heresy, the Empress herself appeared at the Festival and spoke. She too refused to define the nature of faith or the deities in a manner not too dissimilar to his refusal.

It is not known whether he claims divinity himself but it is a fact that his personal influence, if not power, on the Eastern Coast is quite considerable.

Watching-owl

Unity



Name of Patron: Everdawn

High Priest: Tavis of Delldeep

Guild Founder: Tavis of Delldeep

Diametrical Opposition: None

Centres of Religion: Trollsville

Symbol: A candle, with the inscription: "Better to light one candle than curse the darkness".

Requirements: Be a goodly priest, Elysian priest or vivomancer or paladin unaligned to another church.

Miracle List ~ Lawful Good

1st: Cure Wound, Summon Spiritual Candles

2nd: Cure Serious Wounds

3rd: Healing Hand, Bless, Cure Disease, Protection from Spirits, Talk to Spirits, Spirit Shield, Dismiss Ghoul

4th: Heal, Spirit Bolt

5th: Spiritual Invisibility, Angelic Shift, Remove Voice of Power

6th: Total Heal, Spiritual Freedom

8th: Restore Life

Ethos

The church of Unity believe in the service of goodness itself, rather than following any one god or goddess.

The collection of virtues of mercy, love, courage, faith, hope and peace which members hold dear are gathered together under the banner of Unity. The Archangel Everdawn embodies the virtues that the church believes in, and is to be seen as an example of the faith, rather than a being to be worshipped.

The name Unity also springs from a firmly held belief of church members that all people are part of a community, and have a duty to aid those less fortunate than themselves. The members of the church believe that every person has goodness within them. Everyone has the capacity to perform good deeds, and by doing so gain the aid of the spirits of light. Forgiveness and mercy are

virtues upon which much value is placed – more than one member of the Church has previously owed allegiance to far darker powers. To kill a creature for it's actions will deny it all hope of redemption. It is for this reason, amongst others, that the symbol of the church is a candle, and one of most common stated maxims is that "it is better to light one candle than to curse the darkness."

The church also strongly believe in the concept of free will. Any person, they claim, has the right to live as they wish, with the sole restriction that they should not hurt others. It is this belief that has lead to the unusual mix of pacifism and a willingness to use weapons within the church – priests will not act violently unless there is no other choice, and then generally only to protect others.

Disadvantages

May not attack any living being except in defence of self or other living beings (e.g. can defend non-players against the actions of fellow party members). Violence is generally considered regrettable, and should be avoided where practical and possible.

History

The original faith of Unity existed some time ago, and was a popular faith with the common folk and peasantry. It served an important role in mediating between the different goodly faiths and it has been suggested that the Namer War and the division between the Churches that arose as a result of that event have led to the need for Unity to re-establish itself.

The original priests of Unity did not bear weapons,

relying upon their faith and the spirits of light to protect them. Betrayed from within by dark powers and with most of their number slain those that survived were entombed in stone to protect them from their enemies and await the day when they would be needed once more. The soul of the Archangel Everdawn was trapped in one of the hells for an age, until found by the representatives of the modern goodly churches that at the time comprised the Circle of Light.

Everdawn's soul was freed and he chose to sacrifice himself to bid together the goodly faiths and grant strength to their unity. The part of his soul that remained he placed within Unifier, the holy sword of Unity, which can never strike a blow, as a symbol both to priests of Unity and those of other goodly churches of their pact to aid one another.

Drawn together by signs and dreams, the individuals who would re-establish the Church of Unity travelled to the village of Nearwood and released those priests still held in stone, re-consecrating the altar of Unity and re-establishing the faith. The faith as it is today is very similar to its original roots but whilst some chose not to wield weapons, other modern Unity followers claim to have learnt from the lessons of the past and will bear arms in defence of their faith and those unable to protect themselves.

Holy Days

27th Juon ~ Candle Day [True Holy Day]

The day the church was established and the old faith of Unity revived upon Primus

Lesser Faiths

The faiths listed here exist within the Empire but at this time have little visible impact on it as they are rarely followed by Mercenaries and often do not have organised worship, churches or even widely

known or defined miracle lists. However they are sometimes met by Mercenaries and it would serve a wise mercenary to be aware of their existence and their nature just as a matter of course.

Bhaal

Bhaal, there are those who would claim that Bhaal does not even rank as a deity but is something different, something of equal power but a Demon Lord. What is known of Bhaal? Remarkably little. Described here as a lesser faith this is something of a misnomer. The worship of Bhaal is widespread throughout Deci and he seems to be the patron Lord of Assassins and quite possibly of the City itself.

Its description as a Lesser Faith is simply as a result of their being no known Church, that of course is very different to their being a Church. The insidious power of Bhaal should never be underestimated. By his nature he is hard to oppose. Assassination being the effective political tool as it is.

Several powerful mercenaries of the Empire have been linked to Bhaal, the truth of the matter never proven and only suspected.

It is rumoured that Emperor Michael I made a Pact with Bhaal and failed to keep it. It is said that at the time of the approach of the Final Dawn Bhaal requested 10,000 Souls slain in his name. The result of that pact is unknown but it is widely believed that the Emperor refused to fulfil such a pact and paid with his life instead, either by conscious design or default. If by design that would make him a hero of the Empire, if by default then, well that would make him something else. Whatever the truth of that however the hatred of House Stoneheart and its retainers for the followers of Bhaal is Legendary.

Chernobyl

The direct worship of Chernobyl is quite rare most being followers of Shaehan who venerate him as her son. His appearances upon Primus are increasingly rare and this to some extent has lessened his direct influence. There was a time in the 2nd Age when few of the Heroes

of Primus could not at one point say that they had been restored to life by this man.

He does however have a small following and it is said that Serrafin is in fact his Avatar.

Crol Creator

The creator, is to many the thesis, the maker of all. However this deity that wears many different masks, he is known in many different forms, to the faithful on the plane of Scyla the Father made all. To the Crol, mother created all. He is many things to many peoples.

However we were all created with differences and those differences aid us in some way, so in some way perhaps we should celebrate them rather than hate them on the basis of these differences May the creator bless you.

Joshua Arnhelm.

Cult of Iron and Empire

High Priest

Baron Ashgaroth of The Felldraken Isle
Ambassador to the Southern Baronies
Mennihaf of Bildteve
Magriarch of the Mimram Treaty

Centres of Faith

The Felldraken Isle (Zombie Isle) is the main focus for the Cult but has also strong links within Bildteve. There is a statue, ten foot tall and exquisitely worked in hardened brass, copper and steel this monolith shows the Empress as a Goddess, a living incarnation of Empire to which the undead of Felldraken may follow their leaders example and swear allegiance in death. There are small pools of worship in other areas of the Empire mainly where old soldiers or loyalist undead dwell.

Places of Worship

The Cults shrines are often built near to barracks and other places where determined Imperial soldiers might lurk. The shrine itself is dedicated to elevating the ideal of the Empire's iron soul, of determination and glory, both past and present, in battle, in conquest and in its citizen's iron resolve and stout hearts!

Name of Deity

In no way conventionally deific, this is an Imperial Cult that typifies the dark, unyielding side of the Empire, but certainly does *not* see itself as being opposite or contrary to any other Imperial and Empress cults. It is an uncompromising faith that is preached here but offers simple answers to complex questions. Such listed Faith can only be drawn upon by ritualists who are loyal to the concept of Empire and Empress but only for Rites of a darker nature.

Divine Guidance

Ethos and Church History

Despite the dark heart of the cult it is extremely loyal to the Empire and the Empress. Many of its members are loyalist undead such as those raised and then survived the Battle of Amoras Doom after Rorthril. Never had such a horde of diverse people been raised as undead and after the battle many had been able to break the bonds that tied the will of undeath. Even now there were many villages where dead sons had returned to

work the fields – never tiring zombies who drew a plough more reliably than any draft horse.

All priests follow the Arathelian Accords, the High Priest follows them strictly.

The Cult has reappeared after the current High Priest has re-established its places of worship. Any early history of the Church is lost.

Demar

Demar is not a deity as such, more a powerful spirit similar to an Arch Angel. He is a guardian spirit of trade. It is the duty of his priest hood to ensure all trade deals they witness, or are involved in, are fair and all the terms are adhered to. This is not to say they will not charge as much as they can get for something but they will not lie about what something does or otherwise mislead you.

The priesthood is relatively small, numbering currently a score across the Empire. Their only known priest is Lothan Westwind. A skilled man who has made a small fortune selling his services to mercenaries in need.

Lothan's description of Demar seems to indicate that Demar is an ascended mortal of some kind. He likened Demar's ascension to a man who wishes to see that which happens around him by climbing up a hill, the higher the hill the more that he can see of the world around him. Lothan claims that it was for this reason that Demar ascended so that he might see more and more the mercantile trades, deals and bargains of men that he might further ensure their fairness and that all parties involved come away with what they desired from the deal.

Demar seems greatly interested in the fairness of trade.

Geldonvol

Little is known about the slowly increasing influence of this faith. The deity itself is said to be resident in Golden Scarlene, that bright Mittlenacht reflection of our own Scarlene. It's most avid followers are Merchants and Traders. The faith would seem to be spread by the very act of trade, with the exchanging of goods by fair barter and cunning deal acting as a sacrament of the faithful. The acquisition of gold by fair means seems to be very important amongst its faithful.

The faith lacks Preachers, Missionaries, great armies, edifices of shrine and temple on Primus yet despite this

the rise of the worship of Geldonvol in the Empire is strong and has been swift. It is a new faith yet its political influence is great, if understated, for by its very nature its followers are wealthy and wealth can buy a lot of influence.

It is easy to be suspicious of such a young, quick growing faith in the Empire and its unusual nature of propagation and strength. The last faith in the Empire to grow with such speed was that of Redaip, who's popularity amongst the scribes stretched Imperial Resources by an alarming amount.

Glass



Name of Deity: None
High Priest: Earl Edwige
Avatar: The Mistress of Primus
Guild Founder: Unknown
Spherical Leaning: None
Diametrical Opposition: None
Centres of Religion: Halgar
Symbol: A stylised Gem or The Imperial Eagle

The Church of Glass has been extant since before the Oath was sworn by the Sallow Princes to protect the centre of all, though only formalised with the rise of the Magiocracies. The Church is very strong within the nobility and the armies, but rarely followed by mercenaries. The religious tenets that causes most argument in the church arises because the Nagrech stone is itself above belief, yet if that is the case how can belief in the stone provide it with the power to bestow upon its priesthood. In fact contrary to popular belief the Church does not worship the Nagrech but rather draws on the power that flows through it to protect it, and therefore all of existence.

It is more lawful than goodly in outlook, though evil

would find no place here. The over-riding tenet is Duty, to the Mistress of Primus, the Empire and its people, more or less in that order. Members of the Church will do what needs to be done for the good of the Empire and not for their own personal gain. Priests are usually militant and often paladins or spirit warriors. However one or two less military followers are known, most notably the Senator, Duke Stoneheart. Lay believers are welcome to the faith, and frequent amongst the nobility and occasionally the Kallah of Halgar.

Summary

The Church of Glass is a highly lawful pro-Imperial, pro-Primus church, founded to protect the Nagrech Gem, the Empire and Primus itself. Whilst there is a High Priest, currently Senior Mennihaf Earl Edwige, the incumbent Emperor / Empress is accorded respect as a demigod in their capacity as Master or Mistress of Primus.

When speaking as Mistress of Primus, the Empress' word is acknowledged to be indisputable and her commands are to be obeyed without question.

Alignment

The Church serves and reflects the Throne. Under the present Mistress of Primus, who is perceived to be a good, kind and generous Empress, the Church is of Lawful Goodly inclination. Under another Master of Primus, goodly may tend towards neutrality. However, founded on the urge to protect others, the Church is not and could never be evil.

It must be remembered by the faithful that whilst goodly intent is at the core of the church's beliefs, it is the rule of law that governs its strictures. It would be more of a sin to disobey a properly given order by one accorded the authority to do so than to commit an act that may on the surface appear to be of dubious morality. Breach of one's authority is perhaps the greatest evil.

The Church of Glass has a strong following amongst the Nobility (as Church teachings support the Nobility's right to rule), the Yeomanry (who are sworn in their own way to defend Primus and serve the Nagrech) and amongst the Legions (because it is highly lawful and has a strong ethic of devotion to duty).

Focus of the Faith

This is not, contrary to first impressions, a Church about "supporting the Nobility no matter what". Rather, the Church espouses the belief that everyone has a role to play: the Nobles to rule and if need be, shape, the peons to works and believe, and the heroes to defend and bring about change when need arises. All must do their duty. The Empress is to be revered because she does her duty, to protect and defend the Empire and Primus itself, and by fulfilling their duty to the Empire and to the Empress. To fail to do one's duty, or to falsely claim to do so, such as a Noble who lives from their peasant's toil but does nothing but revel and drink at their expense, is a grave offence, as it perverts the line of authority running from the Empress down to the lowest peon.

In a similar way, although the power of the late Emperor Cerus Amora was twisted by evil men such as Madrak, yet he himself should still be respected as a man who made the ultimate sacrifice of his sanity and his life to defend the Empire. Those of his deeds that were done *within the remit of his duty to his people* should be likewise respected.

The Legion View

The Church has acquired a good following within the Legions, as its ethic fits very neatly into the military life.

In some cases, this has been taken a step further, such that the chain of command, which derives from the delegated authority of the Empress, is to be treated in all ways as possessing that authority. Thus the orders of superior

officers acting within the remit of their authority become quite literally the Word of God.

The Church does not go out to preach an afterlife, or give false promises of miracles, rather it states that, in times of trouble, all must do their duty and some must lay down their lives. To do this requires faith, not in some otherworldly heaven or hell, but in the reality that by so doing the world is made better, that one dies so that others may live.

To have faith in one's officers and leaders in the face of adversity is a finer and nobler thing than to follow blindly a god because his followers can heal or restore the dead. To follow a faith which can demonstrate a heaven or hell requires far less true faith than one that asks much and can promise no more than that others will do their best, in their way, also.

Although it may seem to be so, the Church does not preach blind faith. There is no great honour or sacrifice in blind obedience, to *knowingly* submit oneself to the will of the Empress, regardless of the personal consequences, is what is asked.

Opponents and Allies

The Church does not have any great enemies, save that it would set itself against those who would speak against the Empress and seek to overthrow her authority as Empress or Mistress of Primus. There have been strong disagreements with the church of Talthar founded on a disagreement about the nature of reality, although it is hoped that these times have passed.

The faith does not seek to dictate to people what they may and may not worship and is not evangelical. All are free to worship as they will, provided that they do not by so doing offend the law or threaten the stability of Empire or Primus.

Because of its Primal links, the Church is perhaps better disposed towards the Primal deities than their other worldly compatriots. The faith of Dead Heroes is one which shares much in common with that of Glass, especially amongst soldiers.

Commentary

The Church of Glass is an unusual one, until recently its existence was unheard of amongst the Mercenary Caste. Perhaps a good thing given that many see it as a faith that exists purely by virtue of stolen power. Power that is said to belong to other deities and siphoned off by the Nagrech.

It is the Church of the Wardens of the Nagrech and it is the Power of Glass that is most often called upon to fuel the rites of the Nobles of the Blood.

Harlequin

Harlequin (The First Fool, The Grand Jester) is a figure of much mystery and debate by theologians.

To be honest little is still known about this figure and some even question whether he is a God or just a powerful being that wanders the planes. All that can be certain is that since his appearance in Labyrinthia some 5 years ago he shows himself sporadically and looks to have taken a keen interest in Primus.

So far only those with neuronc powers have had any long contact with this entity. This has again made theologians believe that the Harlequin is maybe the first god of the mind powers.

Appearances

The first time that he was seen on Primus was by a young farm girl, Felicity Lockhart of a small village outside Deci. Felicity describes his appearance as garish of that of a court jester with a bleached face, pointed floppy ears and large macabre grin upon his face that showed a mouth with too many teeth. When Felicity first told people of her strange friend they believed this to be nothing more than a childhood fantasy, an imaginary friend if you will. Only later when she began to predict future events did people remember her mentioning of the strange jester like figure.

Divine Guidance

Later Felicity was found to have powers of the mind and was taken by the Empire for training. This Felicity had predicted, her last words being "Goodbye Ma, I will await you in heaven."

It appears that the Harlequin only appears to one person of a group at a time and shies away from holding audiences with too many mortals at once. This has led many to believe that he is a Being that can only project himself for a limited time, whilst others take this as a sign of considerable power, that he can hide himself from all bar those that wish to see him. Others have mentioned that the powers of the mind are still relatively rare and as such few people possess them and can thus make a link to this Being.

Other appearances of the Harlequin have described him as wearing all black with a sad expression upon his face in contrast with a large broad smile. Another described him as wearing rags and clothes that hid his frail body and a glinting smile visible from beneath a deep hood.

Faith

From those that have conversed with this Being it seems it is obsessed with something that it calls "The Tapestry". It would appear, from those that have managed to gleam some understanding of this Being's chaotic mind, that the Tapestry is some great design for life. The Harlequin describes each thread as a person's destiny, with the all the strands weaving to form complex patterns that, when viewed as a whole, depict all of Existence. Only he and the Gods can truly see the Tapestry. Only a handful understand it.

It would appear that the Harlequin sees himself as some form of guardian of this Tapestry and oversees that the threads do not come away. At other times it would appear the Harlequin has wanted to change the Tapestry in some subtle way by changed the weaving of these threads. One such small change was described by Karl Klissman a Scholar of Halgar.

"It was not the first time that the being known as the Harlequin had appeared at night to me. I awoke with a light start to find the Being sitting at the bottom of my bed, a glass of my red wine in his hand and one of my cigars trailing smoke into the air. He spoke to me of the Tapestry as he often did late in the night. I was going to attempt to reach towards his mind but early attempts had left me flat upon my back. He said that he saw a man in armour in the picture and that the eyes were closed. He wanted them to open. What followed was a rambling conversation and to be honest trying to follow it was more than I could manage. The result was that the Harlequin seemed quiet pleased with himself and mumbled something about a Nexus before disappearing through my bedroom door."

Others speak of the Harlequin's love of practical jokes which seem to have some alien sense of humour. Often these jokes have some ulterior motive that only become clear much later. Some of these jokes are even known to have a dark and sometimes fatal punch line.

On the whole the Harlequin appears to work for the benefit of the common good with the idea of seeing a world where all are merry. For this he is often linked to the God Pan.

Followers

A few followers of the Harlequin have been found wandering the planes. All have had exceptional powers of the mind. Many appear to have information gathering capabilities able to look upon this 'Tapestry' and focus upon certain 'threads'. They all speak of having a very personal relationship with the Harlequin. These followers have never been seen preaching their faith rather moving through the land upon quests that few can fathom. Often they are dressed in garish clothes like their master, this often makes them seem foolish or lax which belays their true worth.

If someone is trying to stop a mercenary company's threads fraying then they could be a follower of Harlequin. As they generally take no sides in the Good and Evil debate they are well suited to act as intermediaries and often interspersed humour can help lighten the mood. But that isn't to say that they will not take sides... some strands have to be tied off or the weave might unravel.

There are rumours of a militant wing, devoted to this Being. A sparse group able to manipulate the Tapestry to assist them in combat. People able to confound foes with their trickery. Whilst not blasé about death they are confident that when their time finally comes their threads will be rewoven into something that pleases The Jester. There is a tale told by these men of the Harlequin saving his first follower by tricking Death out his prize. This game is supposedly played each time one of his followers falls allowing them to return back to the Tapestry.

It seems that there is no real organisation to this religion and prayers take place in the form of performances or jokes. Those able to commune directly with Harlequin do so knowing that the pomp and circumstance usually associated with such sessions generally take a back seat to their master's sense of humour. Certainly the questions asked are answered but sarcasm, "helpful" bits of advice and constructive, and not so constructive, criticism occasionally creep in according to Harlequin's whim at the time.

The most well known follower of this faith on Primus is Bernie, affectionately known to some as a "Stinker".

Raven

Name of Deity: Lybor'Nech

High Priest: Unknown

Guild Founder: Flockmaster Corvic

Spherical Leaning: Causing

Diametrical Opposition: Shaehan

Centres of Religion: Scarlene & Roxbridge

Symbol: A black Raven

Pre-Requisites: Traditionally only ever Pure Priest or Spirit Warrior though of late other classes of Priests have been found amongst their numbers

Miracle List ~ Neutral Evil

1st: Cause Minor Wound

2nd: Cause Wound, Temp Curse, Halt Undead

3rd: Cause Serious Wounds, Curse, Protection from Spirits, Talk To Spirits

4th: Cause Disease, Beguile, Spiritbolt, Spirit Shift, Prot From Neutral Spirits

5th: Cause Grievous, Voice of Power, Spiritual Invisibility

6th: Spiritual Mastery

7th: Suspend Life

Divine Guidance

Ethos

Worship of Lybor'Nech, he who brings pure death. Raven Priests believe that Restore Life, Animate Life or similar defile the sanctity of life by cheating death. They are opposed to these miracles and anything that duplicates their function. They are also violently opposed to that which is created in mockery of life and death, namely the undead, which they seek to destroy with a great passion.

The Mantra of The Raven

"One Life, One Soul, One Death!"

History

The given history of the Church of the Raven is an extremely odd one. As faiths go it is young. As to the origin of its deity this is even stranger. Lybor'Nech was said to have been created by the acts of Chernobyl, Demigod of Healing.

Chernobyl had lead a number of priests of Shaeahan on a quest. Part of their quest involved traversing one of the Totemic Spirit Planes. Whilst such planes are generally closed to those who do not follow the totemic ways the

Shamanic nature of Chernobyl's power was such that he was able to open the gateway. Of courses as is the nature of such places he had to face the Gate Keeper of the plane (the nature of the Gate Keepers is described further in Shamanism page 51).

The Gate Keeper is a construct created to oppose whoever seeks entrance. It a test created in the likeness of the supplicant and created as an equal force to whom it would oppose. In this form the Gate Keeper could not destroyed except by Divine means. Whilst Chernobyl defeated the creation he did not destroy it and the plane was unable to un-create it or re-integrate it into itself due to its divine nature.

Since then Lybor'Nech has created a cult from which to draw power and has to a degree become a force of its own.

Strangely whilst opposing the faith of Chernobyl and Shaeahan it has worked with faith of Mortai and for a long time the town of Roxbridge and its environs have been safe from the predations of undeath as a result.

Redaip

Name of Deity: Redaip

High Priest: Classified

Guild Founder: Classified

Spherical Leaning: Communication

Diametrical Opposition: The Tryst...

Centres of Religion: Halgar

Symbol: Quill

Miracle List ~ Neutral Neutral

1st: Detect Spirits Nature, Halt, Power Meld, Spirit of Seeing

2nd: Spirit of Seeing and Hearing

3rd: Detect Lie, Enhanced Stasis, Protection from Spirits, Spirit Shield, Talk to Spirits

4th: Communication, Rune of Power, Spiritbolt

5th: Minor Ward of Power, Spiritual Invisibility, Voice of Power

6th: Control Wraith, Converse with Spirit

8th: Communication II

Ethos

- The Holy Redaip Eternal Everlasting.
- Triplicate is holy.

History

The Imperial Church of Bureaucracy has had a strange history. For a time it threatened to quite literally overwhelm the Empire in bureaucracy and red tape. Such a threat has passed though and little is heard of this faith with Scribes turning now to other faiths. It is rarely followed by those of the Mercenary Caste.

Holy Days

1st Deeber ~ Sealing the Gates of Accounting [Shadow Day]

Towards the end of the year, bureaucrats throughout the Empire call upon what mystical powers they control in order to close any unfinished business that the Imperium may have. Such a large draw of power effects followers of the powers of Redaip, leaving insufficient for greater rites on this day.

Sean Chan

Name of Deity: Sean Chan

Centres of Religion: Scarlene, Port Miere and Keys

History

Seanchan is the God of the Seas and Oceans. God unto all the animals that live within his domain. He can be calm or vengeful such is the will of the Sea. Seanchan has no strong beliefs as displayed the many goodly and evil faiths. Seanchan believes that there is a time for peace and a time for action. Whilst Seanchan is no friend of the darker faiths he has no real enemy nor friend.

The followers of Seanchan are a mixed collection of people. The faith is not as organised as others. The Sea Alfar do not believe in bending their knees in prayer for example. They have great respect for their God and thus will meet him like men standing proud to look into his face.

The Festival of Fish is the most famous of the gatherings in honour of Seanchan. Normally held near Scarlene with

smaller celebrations held in Port Miere. This is seen as a great time for the followers of the faith to relax and celebrate their faith rather than be in fear of it and their deity.

Should the follower of Seanchan be a captain of a vessel he is not permitted to accept cash for travel aboard his vessel. It is believed that Seanchan gives the gift of passage upon his ocean and as such any passenger must give a gift unto the Captain. The more thoughtful the gift the better the portents of the journey.

Stories of the Faithful

The Sea Alfar believe that long ago the Alfar were one race. That at the dawn of time the Alfar all lived together and in peace roaming the new world. Yet the Alfar were alone, they had no God to watch over them or protect them from the dangers of the world. So their numbers dwindled and life became a struggle for survival. The Alfar travelled the lands looking for a patron, for a God to look after them and protect them.

Divine Guidance

They travelled across the lands until they eventually came to the Ocean. Here the tired and beleaguered Alfar set up camp and held a meeting. Many amongst them were arguing as to what was the best way to go, within which direction they should search. Others believed that they should stay in one place and try and survive for many of them were old or too young to travel.

One amongst them came forward and spoke to all that were there. His name was Mayene and he spoke calmly to them all, he offered to travel across the Ocean and seek their God, whilst they would remain and be safe. The crowd were taken a back by this young man and agreed that this would be best for all concerned. So Mayene built himself a small boat and upon one cold and windy day set sail out into the Ocean in search of a God for his people.

Of his actual journey little is known but what is commonly known is that one-day he landed upon an island. The boat was smashed and unusable and Mayene older by years was tired and exhausted. This island was small and appeared to have a mountain rising from the middle and a forest around its base. Mayene climbed to the top of the mountain to see all around, and all he could see was ocean, and the sun reflecting from its majestic beauty and he was moved for a deep moment. It was then that he felt the presence of a God. Mayene fell to his knees and called out to this presence.

What words were spoken is only written in the most Holiest of books. What is known is that this presence left Mayene upon the island refusing to be the God unto his people.

Mayene cried but he would not now leave after all his years of searching and hardship he would remain and force this being to look after his people. And so Mayene remained.

It was the animals of the island that first came unto Mayene and so moved by this man that they brought him food and water that he might live and continue in his quest. The animals were not beautiful in appearance or noble in stature yet Mayene perceived their inner beauty.

So it was years later that the presence returned to the now greying Mayene. During this second visitation the God and Mayene spoke and the Presence was confused as to why Mayene would remain. Yet again the presence refused to tend to Mayene and his people and left him.

The word of Mayene spread through the animals and many travelled to this island. The animals that were ugly and without patron, the Sea Dragon and snake, the ugly misshapen animals of the depths and birds that lacked feathers upon their heads. It was these animals that brought food unto this man during his long meditation and wait.

The Presence paid Mayene a third visit. It was now that the presence spoke unto him.

"Raise Mayene for I am Seanchan your God"

Seanchan spoke unto Mayene and accepted him and his people. Yet Mayene looked at the animals that had guarded him and fed him during his years of ordeal. So it was that Mayene asked Seanchan if he would be God unto these creatures as well. Seanchan refused and fled this Holy Man. So Mayene sat and meditated still. The animals fed and protected this man that would do so much for them. Seanchan returned to the Island that would forever be called the Holy Isle by the Sea Alfar.

"Raise Mayene for I am Seanchan your God and God unto these beasts as well. Return now unto your people."

With Tears that ran down his face Mayene returned to the beach to find his boat repaired and ready and so he set sail once more back to his people. The water spray that splashed into his face stained his face with a permanent glow that marked him as Seanchan chosen.

When Mayene returned to where he had left his people he was now an old man. His skin glowed with an eerie light and his people were frightened of him. Mayene explained his journey to his people and told them that should now worship Seanchan. Yet his people had changed and now laughed at Mayene thinking him gone mad or a ghost, whilst others hurled rocks at him and mocked him for being old and senile.

So Mayene grew angry and asked for those that would heed the word of their God follow him back unto the island. Some did follow; they went down to their fishing boats and set sail with Mayene to return to the Holy Island.

Those that remained Mayene cursed and Seanchan in his anger at seeing his prophet so treated accepted. Of the Alfar that remained some lived upon the plain and forest by the Ocean. Seanchan commanded the moon that night to bleach these Alfar white so that they may never forget their shame. Of those that lived in the caves, Seanchan sent his dragon Lactor to collapse the entrances into these caverns. There the soot from their fires did stain their skin black. Of the last those that fled unto the mountains the dirt from the ground in which they hid did mark their skin brown so that all those that ignored Mayene's words would forever remember their shame!

Of those that travelled with Mayene they became the first followers of Seanchan and the Sea Alfar, "*The People of the Sea*".

Commentary

The events at the end of the second age, just prior to the Coronation of Emperor Michael I, made it apparent that Sean Chan is in actual fact leader of a pantheon of sea deities. At the Fish Festival that took place to mark the end of the second age several deities of the sea accompanied him. Interestingly was the presence of a tentacled monstrosity, whose insanity was kept in reign by Sean Chan. Amongst those gods present were the Asa Volki and Tsu-Ling and a number of other unnamed deities accompanied him from the depths.

Watching-Owl

Thanatar

Name of Deity: Thanatar

Diametrical Opposition: Border

Miracle List ~ Neutral Evil

1st: Halt, Spirit Of Seeing, Detect Spirit's Nature

2nd: Cause Wound, Temp Curse

3rd: Spirit Shield, Talk To Spirits, Curse, Cause Serious Wounds, Protection From Spirits

4th: Spirit Bolt, Communication, Create Ghoul, Cause Disease

5th: Cause Grievous Wounds, Voice of Power

Divine Guidance

6th: *Spiritual Mastery, Control Wraith*
7th: *Suspend Life*

Commentary

This faith once prominent in Scarlene seems to have all but died away. Either that or, as is more likely, it is

festering away as some secretive dark cult.

At this time the only prominent follower of this dark deity is rumoured to be decorated and famous Imperial soldier Parmonian Darkseed.

The Spiter

Of all the Primal Deities this one has been the one most hounded by Mercenaries and those of power. His grip on his realm has been tenuous and he has been most shaped by being forced into actions not of his own choosing. Few would realise the effect of the sheer number of victories arrayed against him by the Heroes of the Empire in one form or another and even by the other Primal Deities. Actively opposed by Ikhala, who quite quickly wiped his influence out in the Far North, Asa Volki who took the fight to him and destroyed much of his fleet, Tsu-Ling who unravelled the madness he had spread and directed mercenaries against him and now Milora who stands where Heroes are needed to stem the tide of Spiter's influence.

Yet still he exists, spreading his power in yet more and more devious ways... The history of and tactics of The Spiter could fill a tome on its own and provide invaluable lessons in smoke and mirrors.

Of amusement though was the incident of "The Choice". As the Primal Forces gathered in their meeting cave to vote on their choice of the Primal Spirit, a choice between

the Sire and the Sallow, it was discovered that Spiter was incapable of telling the truth, even when he wanted to. Faced with an either/or decision and forced to answer of forever be condemned to remain trapped within the cave he could only give the answer he least wanted and had no choice but to lie and answer "Sire" when he really wished "Sallow", in the end events transpired that the vote stood with the Sallow but still Spiter left enraged.

At this time it is said that Spiter has transferred his power beyond Primus and ascended from a Demigod to a full deity. The truth of this is as yet unconfirmed. However he has made of parts of the Southern Baronies a terrible wasteland, the Sunless Lands, where he has shaped and moulded the world around him and learnt to shape and mould the very flesh of the Blauze.

It should be noted that The Spiter is not without a sense of humour though in the evil manner of his kind and he takes great pleasure in his manipulation of truth and the physical world around him. And even now he works great rites of the Tree of Flesh that constantly reshape the form of the Blauze.

Zaroan

Name of Deity: Zaroan, Lord of Life

High Priest: Thyrn Rhys Diabolo Panama

Avatar: None

Spherical Leaning: Dismissal

Diametrical Opposition: Accabus. Zaroan is opposed to Accabus. Where Zaroan stands for life and cleansing Accabus stands for undeath and disease. Accabus will corrupt souls and use them for his needs, destroy crops and cause havoc and mayhem wherever he may go

Centres of Religion: No organised Church exists on Primus

Symbol: Silver cross on a Gold heart. The cross is slightly larger than the heart and starts at the junction of the two lines at the top of the heart, thus finishing below the bottom point of the heart.

Alignment: Lawful Good

Paladinic Vows: None specific as yet but relevant to the tenets below.

Tenets

Zaroan's aims are the destruction of undead and the eradication of disease. He is not a Marshall God so beating things until they stop moving is not always the only option and if it is not possible to accomplish something on the spot it is allowed for his priests to fall back and regroup. However the greater good is not a good enough excuse and each deed or situation must be undertaken on its own merits.

History

First there was the Mother. She created the plane and lands of Kaden. To watch over Kaden she created Zaroan and Accabus. Zaroan was set to ensure life flourished and prospered whilst Accabus was set to cause hardship and turmoil whether they were alive or dead. This eternal struggle caused the lands to deteriorate and finally the Mother destroyed all that she had created, to recreate again with a new pantheon of seven Gods each set for different tasks but with Zaroan and Accabus still the strongest and most diametrically opposed Gods. So for a while the struggle continued until an invading entity from another realm caused the Gods to set their enmities aside to unite and destroy it. Once destroyed the Pantheon's unity crumbled and each God went back to the struggle and the 'tasks' set upon them. Though Zaroan's powers and the powers of all the Pantheon extend across the planes the main focus is on Kaden itself and the populace that live there.

Major exponents of the faith

The main defender of the Faith of Zaroan was Zeradia. A Paladin of Zaroan who stood true to his God through thick and thin and eventually succumbed to the forces of Accabus whilst defending Thyrn and George from a horrendous onslaught. From this noble act Thyrn took up the mantle and the task of keeping the faith alive and eventually became the high priest and champion of Zaroan. Even through death and rebirth Thyrn has stayed loyal to Zaroan and continues in his service to this day.

Shamanism

At the time of The Choice the acts of The Sire Primus, in league with Ikhala Hordehost, have caused a change in the Far North, it is as it once was and the ways of the Northern Shamans are not as those of the South.

Whilst the Tribes of the Empire differ greatly from the Tribes of the North they are of course all descended from one people. When the tribes of the North were dispossessed from their lands, the lands now in the hands of the Empire, those that remained learnt to live with the invader forces and their gods.

Those who travelled North chose to not leave all that they knew and take to the Armastice Gate. Those who stayed accepted a different way of life. The Tribes of the Far North are unforgiving of the tribes of the South for remaining and even to this day.

Of course such a change is all but forgotten and imperceptible to those who lack vitae but for those older mercenaries amongst us who possess such the lands of the Far North are not quite those of our memories. Few would remember that this history has not always seemed so. For, through the manipulations of The Sire Primus, by the influence of Ikhala, there has been a change in the Far North, it is as it once was, or as perhaps as it should have always been. Either way the great secrets of the Shamans are to be found now in the North and one who would seek to understand the ways of power from the 1st age would need to travel there, away from the influence of Amora's Night of Levity.

The ways of the Northern Shamans are different to those of the Southern Shamans. My people, those of the Lo-Thi, have wandered the many realms that ajoin Primus and the ancient Lo-Thi title for Shaman translates as "He-Who-Walks-In-Dreams" and it is one of the primary duties of a Shaman of the Lo-Thi that he be a Dreamwalker of sufficient skill that he is not only able to step between the realms but that he can lead his whole tribe between the realms.

Sallow Scholars and Magiarchs would argue that such realms are merely grey shadowed lands, offshoots of Primus, simple vestiges of long forgotten spirit realms or even just the Shaman's own dreams given form. Of course such is unlikely, is it not? That a shaman could dream a whole realm into existence?

The Shamans are the voices of the totems and spirits of Primus. Totems are most often the spiritual essence of a single animal, be it Bear, Wolf, Spider or Owl. But Totems can be as varied or ephemeral as Cloud, Oak, River or Rock, for in Shamanism history is of great import. The telling of what happened at a place gives the place significance and with each retelling the spirit of the place is given form and awakened. Such a spirit might grant power, just as any totem might to those who know how to appease it by the telling of its tales and stories.

At the core of Shamanism is the ability to work in respectful harmony with such lesser spirits, the art of the Dream-Walker and the Spirit-Speaker are the greatest amongst the Shamans. To call forth the spirits of the wild places, to observe and speak with them, speak of them and relate their tales. To learn from the spirit of Mountain, River, Tar and Brook, to coerce or even bind them. For by such actions are the rites of the Shaman powered. The way of the Shaman is the way of Primus.

Shamans work closely with the natural order and the nature of their rituals is such that they often leave little trace or unwanted impact and the curse of entropy rarely troubles a Shaman who has performed the correct observances for his rites and entreated the spirits with the respect they deserve.

The Tribes are custodians of the land. Taking of its bounty that which it can provide and little more. It is partially this that makes the tribes nomadic. A desire to take only what the land can give and move on before the land is starved and its spirit broken.

For each tribe is possessed of a totem and in the north it seems that each tribe may even have a Walking-god, not unlike the Primal Deities that are known to the Empire.

Shamans are rarely leaders in its truest sense, they are advisors, amongst my people the creed of the Shaman is simply this: "We exist to serve". Our skills are for the betterment and glory of our tribe and as High Shaman I serve all the tribes within the Empire and not just those of the mannish races.

Watching-Owl

Holy Days

These are the remaining Holy days observed and empowered by my people, the Lo-Thi, and consequently, by the tribes within the Empire. The calendar of the tribes of the Far North have a far richer set of days tied even closer to the flow of time in that hostile land.

9th Novaus ~ The Dreaming Day [Shadow Day]

On this day many totems enter a hibernation state, being bound by the turning of the seasons. Shaman's spend this day coaxing their totems back to the real world, and seeking contact with the drowsy forces of the totems.

13th October ~ Shamanistra [True Holy Day]

All Shaman's Day links all totems in a mighty circle for though they are many and varied, these primal forces ultimately work together. On this day they hold council amongst themselves, renewing ancient pacts and agreements that, despite their individual desires and conflicts they may continue to act in unity.

9th Februar ~ The Awakening of Totems [Shadow Day]

On this day shamans greet their totems as they awaken following the winter, and renew agreements made previously.

The Namer War

Background

There are those who say it could have ended there. We could have simply opened the voidal gate and sent the Namers into The Void to face the Voidgod, hindsight is a remarkable thing. This was not done and the gods from a distant place that eventually revealed itself to be a place from the far future were able to enter Primus and out rime and challenge the current pantheon for a right to

exist. Such challenge was met with by each deity in their own particular way true to their unbending natures, even when they could see and sense another path existed. Again seeming to prove the inability of gods to choose and revealing how they are at the mercy of their followers.

The Conclusion

Day One

Torwin personally observed the Power Well In the St. Michael Temple In Halgar. Certainly a wise plan judging by the number of corruptive actions performed by person or persons unknown in the previous few months. However, as she observed she saw nothing save for the odd pilgrim arriving, praying at the vortex and then leaving again having added to the now slower spinning star. The Well had grown quite considerably, but it was still a long way from filling its available space - shining pure white and slightly blue it filled the Temple with a great feeling of contentment and well being. However, it was still only a tool and its ultimate effect would depend upon the manner of its use. The kilted priest stood on the brow of the hill, great stones around him, the wind blowing through his long blonde hair and his piercing eyes stabbing into the fog bank, which was lying around the base of the hill this dewy dawn morning.

"Och, Forteeese, dun yuu cam heer ana whell discus eneou!" Kamac's broad accent was perhaps stronger than normal standing here in the place which reminded him so strongly of home. A tiny tug surprised Kamac, a twitch on his spirit indicated that he had been heard, and that the one he called was sending an avatar.

Down at the base of the hill a figure broke through the mist, and for a moment Kamac's heart missed a beat. The figure appeared to be that of Saint Michael, but as it came closer Kamac could clearly see the lines of age on the face of the god. Grey streaks in his hair showed the age of the Avatar clearly, but the most striking thing was the tiny rag of cloth tied with ancient worn knots to the avatar's belt. It was clearly Kamac's tartan.

"Child, I have come as you asked, but as ever, your accent is quite difficult to understand. If you do not mind please could you temper it?"

Kamac took a deep breath, formatted his thoughts, slowed his speech and read the prepared entry to this Avatar of Fortis.

"If you fight St Michael and win, do you realise that you still have nothing as the followers of St Michael will not follow you! This is because St Michael's ascendance to Godhead is a recent advent and as such it is him as an entity which many of the St Michael priests follow! Therefore they shall not convert, but would rather die! So If you are my lord from the future, tell me what else can be done! Help us, explain to me what else can be done!"

Kamac's shoulders sagged as he completed berating the avatar, half expecting to be blown away by some alien entity, half expecting derision. He was pleasantly surprised.

"Kamac, loyal and strong as ever. I still remember that time when, oh, never mind, that has not happened yet! Yes child, you see the right when you ask me what can be done, for the conflict that will arise between the older gods and the younger will not be a bloody battle, but a symbolic negation of identical manifestations. You can save your gods in several ways, though as time passes your options become more and more limited, and my own desire for survival means that those, which would destroy me, i am reluctant to explain. However you could save the younger incarnation of saint michael in the same fashion as permits letreal to be here at the same time as his younger version. The nature of the problem is that two versions of the same god cannot exist in the same exostance at the same time. Take one version out of the exostance with limited communication with this place, would avoid any dramatic conclusion of this event. So my friend, he who gave me this battle honour at his final death, look to the void."

Saint Michael or Fortis depending on your point of view, gently tugged the ragged bit of cloth from his belt and gave it to Kamac.

"Look at the cloth, I believe you can see that hooch stain on the end, yes, don't bother checking, it does match your own, note how now the cloth is in your real world, rather than as just part of my projection, notice how the stronger of the clothes overrides the other."

Kamac looked down, saw the edge of his kilt slowly wilting, dissolving, crumbling, until a neat swathe was present. The older cloth in his hand thrummed with power, familiar energies, great strength.

"Kamac I know you love me, but still cannot see that I and Saint Michael are still one and the same, but I give you this gift. Should the time come when my younger version has not sanctuary,

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no walls to separate us, I will make him an offer, I will suggest a sharing, a combining. I will be two gods in one. I do this not because I am weak, not because I have doubts that the millennia of knowledge and strength I have gained would fall to his assault, but because I love you, I love all those who stand for the correct cause, and that to lose a small part of me, to protect my earlier self is only right. Please talk to your fellows, explain to them that we are the same, and to fight is to refuse the inevitable. If this cannot be done, then as I said before, place a wall which will insulate the two incarnations of myself, your master will understand, place him in the void, your eight could easily defeat the one there, and you could still entreat with my younger self, much as do the followers of old one eye. Look to the void my friend."

And with that the avatar vanished.

A shattering silence drops across the chamber from where your prayers were being proffered, eerie ethereal images sway into existence, two circles one containing the other, the inner circle containing a variety of Solars, Angels, Diva's and yes, even humans! The outer circle, warding from intrusion are nine figures, gods if you would have it, incarnate and localised, rather in their diffuse nature, nine gods in total.

The first, being the youngest is Saint Michael, his vigorous face full of energy and the joy of battle, yet tempered with compassion that comes so easily to him.

The second, Shallya, takes the form most universally recognised by the folk of Labyrinthia, that of a woman covered in the sheerest samite, her heart shaped face warm and comforting, a sweet promise of aid to any that should ask for it in her eyes.

The third, Talthar, a staunch man, armed and armoured for any eventuality as is the heart of those who display his banner and follow his path, and that of his other aspect/twin/companion Elbrime.

The fourth, Humakt, old and wizened, bearing many scars and holding the sword named Death in his hands, the slayer of gods stood calm, though his followers numbered very few.

The fifth, Elbereth, Lady of the Stars, had a troubled look on her face, it is often said that the state of a gods church is reflected in the god herself, and perhaps the strain of matters temporal was truly bringing a challenge to Elbereth's Incarna.

The Sixth, The Source, had assumed a simple farmer's appearance, and the lack of practice at this task was evidently showing for the figure kept waving like a lapping gentle tide on a warm, sandy beach.

The Seventh, Border, Justice maker, matriarch and patriarch of culture, stood choosing a female form on this day, clad in sleek golden mail armour and carrying a slender lance.

The Eighth, The Bright Lady, could have been taken for the sister of Shallya, and the two had nothing but fondness in their stance for each other.

The Ninth, much akin to the Source, elected to take the form of a glowing ball of light, shining out like the heart it is, The Sacred Heart was definitely present, never

before assuming an avatar in living memory.

The Priests of these gods, somewhat surprised to be present in council with so many others, having simply sought to consult their deities on the eve of what could be the most traumatic event to date in the history of Labyrinthia, looked around viewing who else was present. Before St Michael was a veritable crowd, Anarchus, Kamac and Vayle. With Shallya stood Lady Torwin and Chernobyl. With Talthar Harpell stood, sword for once in scabbard. Humakt stood alone, nothing had been seen or heard from Captain Eagleblade for many years now. Elbereth was accompanied by Basil and Thomas, each watching the other warily. The Source, whose active worship was never very high but a respect for him and his functions regarded well by all simply smiled when people looked his way, as did the Sacred Heart, diffuse entities drawing forth diffuse worship. Border was a little concerned, she had expected Robin to be present, but had failed to make contact with him, but the presence of Frater Placido with the Bright Lady granted a little moral support. With an unfelt signal, the council began...

I am Michael, I am opposed by Fortis, I will fight unto death.

I am Shallya, I am opposed by Paragon, I listen to council.

I am Talthar, I am opposed by Hubris, I listen to council.

I am Humakt, I am opposed by Mortai, I am here to bring news.

I am Elbereth, I am opposed by Grace, I have troubled tidings.

I am The Source, I am opposed by Justice, I listen to council.

I am Border, I am opposed by Solace, I stand with Michael.

I am the Bright Lady, I am unopposed now, I shall tell of it.

I am the Sacred Heart, I am opposed by Letreal, as such I listen to council.

Having such clear facts laid before them caused the priests to look amongst themselves, here was news indeed, firm ground upon which to base their strategies. It seemed clear that a number of the priests wished to speak, by Michael, having taken charge of the impromptu meeting raised a divine hand.

Humakt, you bring news.

Yes, I am old, older than any of those present here, I was at the making of all, and brought the sword Death from the other place to allow mortal man an escape from life in this place. Not many knew the name of the one who opposed me, Mortai.

The following of Mortai has been practised in Labyrinthia for several years now and he and I appear to have existed congruently, but this is not in fact the case.

As the young god walked, I began to stumble. That he now returns with the Namers indicates the tales that they be our future selves, indicates that sooner or later his worship will resurface and that he and I will become the same anyway.

Mortai wishes to tread this land, I am prepared to allow him. No doubt my priests may well protest but as can be

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seen they are not here to argue. I ask that Lady Shallya help her younger cousin and that I be allowed to rest.

Various gods nodded, such a request at the god's own mouth must be considered well, and Mortai was indeed a native of this place, his active worship practically unheard of for many years, though it is known that nearly all Shallyans paid him homage, it could be that the two gods are now the one, with Humakt ascendant. Humakt spoke again:

However such is my choice and not one forced onto me by the Namers, even if they believe without ill will in their hearts that they as the elder versions of yourselves should continue rather than leave the faith with younger and less knowledgeable versions of themselves.

Such is it that I bear the sword which is death, and should one of you present here ask it of me I shall use death for what it was intended for, though I know that when my guard is down, Mortai will step forward, and envelope me in his love, leaving only Mortai, one who perhaps could ensconce a more vital worship upon Primus and hold the dead at bay.

Michael and the other gods, as well as the humbled priests, considered Humakt's words carefully, the consequences were there, Humakt wished peace but could defy one of the Namers in the process. Then the Bright Lady spoke, her manner gentle and unassuming.

I am unopposed. This means that the Namer who stood before me is no more. This was not done through violence, but rather that at the threshold of entry, which is now and past and yet to be whilst we reside in this council, she bowed her head and willed herself gone. As she passed she asked me to speak well of her companions, they are much as we, those of us who fight, can we expect older versions simply to surrender, after all they have been through this before and those that come now are the victors of before or they would ever have been able to come again!

The extreme logical nature of this statement creased the brows of a few of the non-omniscient beings present. In Vayle's case however, there was no problem at all, the whole thing had simply gone clear over his hairless head! The Bright Lady assumed a passive pose, and then did Elbereth speak.

I wish I could bring such joyous words to this council, but my church has its own problem. My church is not united against Grace. My faith is strained and my personal power as opposed to the power of my seat wanes as it is split.

Turning to Basil she speaks again

No doubt you may have wanted your enquiry to have been responded to in such a fashion as to allow you to discuss it privately before Thomas was addressed, but this is the one chance I am going to have to speak with you on it. Thomas, tell Basil what unfolds.

With the eyes of nine gods and so many legendary priests upon him, it is perhaps surprising that Thomas spoke so clearly and eloquently. "I have spoken with Grace"

Pre-emptive shouts came from several of the priests present, but Michael indicated they should let Thomas finish what he was saying first.

"As I was saying, I have spoken with Grace, and have agreed to work alongside her, following her, advocating her path as the Lady of the Stars. I realise that this will cause some hardship in the short term, and no doubt

those who follow Elbereth", nodding with respect at his previous goddess, "will feel a need to take to arms on the matter. This is their choice to make. However with the knowledge and experience that Grace brings with her, finally our church stands a chance in overcoming the one eyed foe."

At that even Elbereth herself had to agree

"Many temples across the Empire are with me, and though many of the most powerful priests will probably denounce me as heretic, stop and think first. I serve Grace, as do those beneath me, to gain the strengths and power we need to fight on against the true foe, which is not poverty, sickness or oppression, those are by products of his presence, and once he is dealt with can be answered to. So Basil, before you declare an immediate crusade consider this, consider why we are here, why Grace can fulfil that role just as well as her younger self here, and why we should limit ourselves for the sake of a name!"

Basil simply tightened his lips, his view of Elbereth standing stooped shoulders was slowly added to temporarily by the image of the same woman, standing tall and proud behind Thomas. He looked to Elbereth, who simply shook her head. The question as to which version of the Lady of the Stars would be ascendant was resting on his and Thomas's shoulders, or would they drag the whole church down with them in the process, granting Morgoth the opportunity he was waiting for. Elbereth spoke again

As I see it, Thomas is doing what he sees is best for the faith but once this council ends I can see only two paths ahead of us. The first is that the two of you cannot agree to only support one of us, and I would not expect Thomas to drop his worship of my older form any more than Grace would demand so of Basil. In this case, as happened in the past I foresee a holy war.

The god born or killed by the number of worshippers who stand at any one time, for without worshippers a god is nothing. Alternatively should the two of you agree that Grace and Elbereth both deserve to exist then we combine, obliterating alternate parts of each other until only one stands before you, the young and the mature, and we take our title as our name to please both factions. Thus those who stand by me can speak with the half that is Elbereth, and those who stand with Thomas can speak with the half which is Grace, but as the whole we shall be the Lady of the Stars.

How you divide temporal leadership will probably initiate a whole new series of wars, or you may divide the lands of Primus north and south, east and west, it matters not. When this council ends, Thomas and Basil needs speak and make their choices in the matter, and as such the two of you will be left linked with words to share with each other. Such matters are worthy of respect, and it seems that the Namer War is not one single conflict, but nine such battles, each with two bands of allies it seems.

The Sacred Heart spoke

It appears that at some point in the future I am slain by the one who is called Letreal. Some have speculated that Letreal be Morgoth, but I am not so sure. If he can appear as one god, cannot he also have appeared as many others in the intermediate time? I suspect Letreal was never born but part of this eternal cycle of moving forwards and backwards in time. Since I have no counterpart I will stand by all present, I wish no harm to the Namers, who are but your future selves, nor do I wish for them to hurt these younger versions. This whole matter simply assures me of my own mortality. I will ask my followers to prevent all forms of violence, be it physical or emotional, and deal with the

repercussions of that which cannot be avoided all may ask my aid, and all will receive it equally.

Michael snorted with disgust, but was swiftly shushed down by Shallya and the Bright lady, what The Sacred Heart had discovered this day was something which none of them had had to endure, a certain knowledge that he will die. The other gods present simply knew they were threatened, but the Sacred Heart was assured of death. Michael spoke.

I have here with me three of my priests, Anarchus, Kamac and Vayle, all legends in the fight against darkness, and incidentally two of them having been arrested by the empire fighting for what they thought was right. What kind of god could expect such willing and selfless dedication from his followers? Speak Anarchus, tell them what Fortis told you.

Anarchus stepped into the center of the circle, and full of animation in his hands and face spoke of his recent encounter with Fortis.

"Fortis requires me to follow him, and to abandon St Michael. Fortis CLAIMS that he and St Michael are one and the same. I, and my church, do not care. St Michael lived when we lived, he breathed what we breathed, he ate what we ate. Fortis said that it is still him. I say not St Michael is our friend, and we know him. This Fortis has lived many years longer, changed evolved. He may be the same god, but not the same person. We follow the person of Michael. We Fight!"

And how could I argue with that? We gods are what we are because of our believers. So I shall take up arms and engage Fortis. I will plan each battle of my war, I shall fight step by step, I shall enter the void if necessity demands it and I shall spring back with the faith of my followers when the time is right. However I do not believe this will be the case, if some of us nine are in different situations then fine, we are the gods of what we are, and as such I can only respect what judgements you and your priests make. Kamac here has also spoken with Fortis and his sympathies lie with my own. He related unto me a similar tale, listed options laid down by the Namer war god, and I would ask him to speak to you about it, except for his appalling accent. Sorry kamac.

"Och Noo, issa awlriit Meechal"

I see you all understand now.

Gods and men alike were still puzzling over what Kamac had said, when Anarchus burst in... He said "Oh, no, it's alright Michael"

A sudden understanding passed over the group.

One of my number here offended me recently, which is why he is here. Vayle, unwittingly, for he has no wits, nearly caused the destruction of the faith, which is unity. He has asked what he could do to atone, and so i cast the floor open to suggestions.

Michael looked around, until as one, all eight of the other gods spoke as one.

Vayle hear now the words of us, you fight for Michael, but you shall remember all of us, as long as your lord exists you will aid that which is unity, that which is all things light and just. Should another ask for aid you will provide it as long as the task is for the betterment of all. This is your penance. You shall serve unity, for unity serves all that is just, including your master.

Vayle's eyes opened wide as the meaning of this statement was hammered into his normally concept resilient mind and then he was gone, he had duties to perform. Michael spoke once more before yielding the floor.

Though I have spoken passionately about conflict with Fortis, do not think that I or any of my priests feel any ill will towards those who serve other gods and do not fight. As was said earlier this is in fact nine different battles, with nine different sets of causes and repercussions and as such each must be resolved separately. Though I love all of you, I understand intellectually that those who come are you also. It is simply that I must do as my church and believers say for we are one and one are we.

It might have been possible that a small tear rolled down his cheek, but Kamac swiftly gave it a wipe with a torn bit of his kilt. Harpell of Talthar took a half step into the circle, and with positive encouragement from those around him faced his god and spoke.

"My Lord, My God, My Friend, I am with you, I am of you, I am hope in adversity embodied by you, I am a portion of your power and I now return that to you my lord, you have my faith and my love now take my form and my strength. Let the light shine forth, forever. There is always hope my lord, you decision in the coming days will be a wise one, I have faith in what you are and what you will be"

Silence...

Talthar spoke

As ever your words are the power, your deeds are the strength and your hope is eternal, know this Harpell, whatever happens we shall preside on hope, we shall bring justice, light and truth to those who are not in a position to take it for themselves. Should it be that i fall, i ask you to serve the older me as you served me, do not die at this juncture, however there is faith we have at our hands, and together we shall confront Hubris and whatever results from such a meeting will shape this world and others. Michael, I stand with you, my faith fights for hope.

Harpell and the three Michaelians clapped shoulders, two of the gods would stand for what is theirs as they viewed it.

I hope you are pleased with yourself.

It was Lady Shallya who spoke.

I and my priests, Torwin and Chernobyl have spoken and we have as yet to agree to the path our faith shall walk, things are not so clear cut for us. We are currently of the opinion that the best solution would be to ask Paragon to enter the void, where his power of so many years learning would sustain him for at least a while against the depredations of Morgoth, whilst other alternatives are sought. Whilst some may

say that I should lay my life down for Paragon, this is the argument of an imbecile, and one that not even Paragon advocated in his moment of lucidity. It may be the only path lies along the combination of two gods, the forming of new god, who is simultaneously one and many. To do so would require worship in the name of the lady of mercy. What is in a name, eh?

Torwin turned angrily to Shallya

"Stop feeling sorry for yourself, you speak as though this were the only option! You told me to prepare, and so I have, along with many of the others of faith, a well of power has been formed, and yes, we don't have a prepared rite to direct the power, but things have not ended yet." Chernobyl joined Torwin

"As I see it Lady, we must keep the two of you separate until a resolution is chosen. This might be the many and the one, it might be that one should in fact lay their life down for the other..

...You know not what you ask, I have been dead before, and Torwin brought me faith and I lived again, I don't think I could do it again not with so much to do...

"... Or..." Chernobyl continued, "...Or there may be some other recourse. It seems evident to me that we cannot persuade the entire Namer pantheon to enter the void, after all they are the newcomers here; because in case you had not noticed Sir Robin is missing and he is the one who researched how to open the voidal seal!"

Chernobyl turned to Border, and indicated she could speak If she desired, Nobby was a familiar face in the heavens as an Avatar, so none thought this odd.

Robin is gone from my sight, my foe stands before me, I shall do as my church directs, for their faith is my strength. I await Robin's return.

Then the visions fade away.

The Michaelian temple in Halgar was full to capacity, hundreds of priests had journeyed from all over the Empire to gather here on the 13th Day of Juon, priests of Shallya and St Michael, Talthar, Humakt and Elbereth to conclude the filling of the well of power, and to draw that strength forth, directing it towards their gods.

Tension was high, for though the stone, which was the incarnation of the well here in the Empire, pulsed with eager glowing power, occasional arcs brought home to the collected that only pure faith was going to direct the energies therein contained, no specific rite had been named as the route that was chosen. Harpell, of the Church of Talthar assumed the responsibility of placing the priests appropriately around the towering chamber, whilst Anarchus discussed some of the finer aspects of what was about to happen with the heads of those factions who had marshaled such strength in this building. Torwin of Shallya, Gysmo of Shallya and Chernobyl of Shallya were to spread their faithful around the inner edge of the chamber assisted by Halvor Gowan, the Bishop of Roxbridge, Anarchus would symbolically array the Church of Saint Michael and The Avenging Angels of Lyteforce, along with such dignitaries as Vayle, Kamac and Lothan at the threshold of the temple, followers of the War god would keep unwelcome influences at bay.

The Church of Talthar and the Talthar Crew, lead by Aven their high priest would stand closest to the stone, with the guidance of Harpell, Jarek Mace and Saul Omacron in the hope that Talthar would help the rite function successfully rather than bleed away without effective direction. Filling the rest of the Chamber were the followers of Darig, Hero of the Lady Elbereth, who were quite insistent that they were going to pray specifically for their lady to draw strength from the rite, rather than share. The balance of the Church of Elbereth, under the flag of Basil, the True High Priest, sought to dissuade Darig's men of his plan, and it seemed as though they eventually conceded the point, but the tension was to be felt in the air, especially when Zak Smallwyck pointed out to Vardasian that if this rite were to take seven days to complete, that the Shadow day of Elbereth known as Summer Barrows Day, was going to fall right in the middle of the enactment. The notable Elf entrepreneur, Vardasian, loyal to his lady simply instructed Zak to shut up and not to get side tracked by such issues.

Word had spread amongst the priesthood that the troops of the Church of St Michael, Lyteforce and the Talthar Crew had been forbidden entry to Halgar. It seems that the Senatorial Guard was concerned for the wellbeing of their charges having so many armed troops in the city, especially as arms are not permitted to the general public. To avoid confrontation, those troops had been left outside the city with assurances that should any try to interfere with the ritual, special considerations would be undertaken. Anarchus, Vayle and Necromundi had taken the news stoically, and as such, as described above, had placed the most militant church at the entrance to the chamber, with Kamac to ward away intrusion, now was not the time to get bogged down In petty temporal politics.

Many miles away to the west, a dust cloud formed over the rift know as Amora's doom. Farmers, up to twenty miles away, described all kinds of unusual occurrences, like cows slowly drifting up into the sky, the leaves of tree's simply turning into gold, and the rich lush growth which sprang up on the battlefield of Rorthril where such vibrancy had not been seen since the great armies of the Empire and the dark Baronies had churned over the soft earth in their war.

To the east of Halgar, the city of Gileenim also rang with expectant energies, curious citizens wandered the streets looking Into the heavens as a ring of cloud formed over their heads high up in the sky. Though the heavens were blue and clear, within the ring could be seen the dark of night, filled with untold millions of twinkling stars. The priests knelt as the great oaken and iron doors boomed closed, each had been passed a small package of food by the lay of the church of Shallya after all seven days is a long time in contemplation, a long time to fast. Anarchus stood before the stone, and slowly, a quiet drifted across the nearly six thousand priests who had been brought together for this Rite.

Without saying a word, Anarchus faced the stone, and slowly raised his arms towards the heavens, an action duplicated across the chamber, without specific instruction, the many were becoming the few.

Arms reaching the zenith of their rise, small sparks crackled on the stone, hungry, expectant, thirsty sparks. A breeze picked up within the sealed chamber blowing inwards from all directions, charged particles of faith generated by the devotions of those present drawing the air with them. As the draft reached the centre of the chamber, it began to spin, granted motion by prayer and having no where to go, it rose above the well, slowly

twisting and turning until reaching the top of the dome, then being drawn down around the walls to be urged back towards the centre again and again!

Day Two

Still inspired, the many gathered advocates of the Defender gods, continued to pour their faith towards the power well, which had begun to radiate a stronger light, basking the forms of the gathered. Each and every upturned face showed an idyllic beautifiance, as the love, hope, courage and determination stored within the plain rock began to spill out, only to gathered by Anarchus as he continued to stand, arms upraised, as they had been for the previous twenty four hours.

Day Three

With the dull clang of a distant clock tower, the heralded Shadow day for the Church of Elbereth, The Summer barrow day began. The strain took a few hours to tell on these hard pushed followers of Lady Elbereth, the barriers dropping Into place between them and their goddess forcing them to concentrate harder and harder. Leaping to the front of the assembled masses Darig exhorted a cry to continue, not to flag, not to give in to this oppression and with redoubled efforts his and Basil's priests continued, under the worried eye of Vardasian, he could see the stress that these people were under, the knotted cords of muscles at their necks, perhaps the pace had been set too high to start with!

Day Four

In a fashion not to disturb the ongoing rite, the bodies of those followers of the lady of the Stars who had died during the previous day were respectfully removed and placed in the nearby Hospice of Lothan. The causes of death were mostly heart attacks, strokes and general exhaustion, the Shadow day had taken It's toll on them. However they were not the only weary ones present, four days of concentration was taking it's toll on the others, the small food packages provided three days ago starting to run low, and the lack of hygiene facilities making the chamber feel particularly close and would have been even worse bearing in mind how tightly the main door had been side, and how closely Kamac was watching the door, had not the wind in the chamber, charged with energetic faith been carrying the worst of the ill humours away.

Day Five

Ghostly images had begun to form around the power stone, images of the gods and goddesses represented herein, and this lent strength to the participants. Casualties however were mounting across the entire temple which for a rite of this magnitude and importance is only to be expected. These priests were not giving up, not resting, focusing their will and faith into tangible energy, and there are going to be some for whom this would be too much. The Hospice had filled to capacity, the dead were now being stored within local homes and taverns, believers helping where they could, as their priests made the ultimate sacrifice, they could suffer a little inconvenience for a few days.

The stone itself had begun to float a few feet of the ground, held on a pillar of intense white light, gently melting the stone slab upon which it had been placed, casting a reddish hue into the pillar and Anarchus had been lifted by the swirling vortex of wind, statue still, arms raised as they had been for the last four days, and appeared would remain for the rest of the rite. His figure, reflecting the white light, and occasionally catching the sparks of intense charged power from the stone took on a strange glow of It's own, in the shape of a curiously shaped suit of armour, complete with visored helm just

revealing his chin and mouth from beneath it's protection.

Day Six

Cracks beginning to show in the rite caused Zak and Harpell some concerns and the two of them moved around the focusing priests whispering sweet assurances in their ears, asking them to gaze upon the images of their gods who stood around the power well, numbering just seven, the Bright lady and The Sacred Heart having no Involvement anymore in this Naming war! Rumors had somehow entered the church, though it seems likely that Shfoug was the source, that something serious seems to be happening over Gileenim, some kind of energy build up, and deep in the night sky viewed even in the middle of the day through a ring of clouds, was a reflection of this very right, with Anarchus orbiting the power well, and Torwin comforting those reaching the ends of their endurance.

This rumour is strange indeed as confirmation is delivered to Saul Omacron, and it is most definitely an extension of this rite and not some attempt to mimic the benefits by the Namers. This effect seemed to be located over the Governor's mansion, and the ritual chamber there, created by Madrak during the reign of Armora. Towards dark, a ray of pure blue light sliced though the wall to the temple, and on into the image of Humakt, which grew rich and strong in colouring. The pulsing beam of faith had travelled all the way from the Zombie Isle, where the priest Felix and his gathered Rune priests lent their strength, even though unable to break the siege they had been placed under by the Ilvive Host at that unwelcoming place.

Day Seven

The rite was becoming very testing for those who remained, priests who had had no sleep for nearly a week now dropping with exhaustion, or thirst as the temples well finally run dry around dawn on this the seventh day. Kamac had barred the final methods of entrance and exit, even the smallest window had been sealed, now there was less than a day to the end there was no point in taking any chances. Minute by minute, hour by hour more and more vitae poured into the Power Well, the wind now a veritably tornado of dry and used air, and the force of the faith in the centre of the chamber so strong as to actually lift the temple, slightly, brick from brick until light poured into the streets of Halgar, as every stone was buoyed up by the strength of belief in the native gods.

Power

Power everywhere

At the first strike of midnight on the clock in the Halgar senatorial chambers far away in the inner city, the rite came to a crescendo, and with a cry, the energy contained within the stone was released.

To the East, Gileenim exploded in a tumultuous fireball, energy coruscating high into the heavens, and joining with the beam of purest light rising from Halgar, strengthening it, boosting it, pure wholesome light and truth, uncontrolled in it's release, levelling the city of Gileenim.

Utterly.

~

To the west, quiet falls at the mouth of the rift, the mist which had surrounded it for over a year now, clearing. To the very brink of the rift walked eight figures, where they

were met by another nine, a fuzzy dust forming shower developing between them. The rift at Armora's doom was busy with activity, on either side of Elbereth stood gods talking, fighting or simply fading away. Before the elven goddess stood another figure, that of Grace who sought Elbereth's place in this world. Both wanted, both desired the same thing, and after a short period of sizing each other up, were rather surprised to discover that both seemed evenly matched, Elbereth having received a significant boost from the Rite in Halgar.

So then, where do we go from here? Asked Grace

I think it is quite clear Answered Elbereth We both wish to live here in Primus, after all that is why so many gods seek to invade with their minions.

That was a little low, and unfair, you know that I have no choice in this matter, the rift, once formed, presented an inevitability, this situation was going to occur, and having let us grow to the degree we have, I and the other Namers had no choice but to seek an exit

You could seek to enter the void, you could battle Morgoth countered Elbereth.

And die. Without a concerted effort One Eye would have me for breakfast, and you know that! No, entering the void is not viable without others, and there now does not seem to be the time to discuss such with those around us, they seem a little, erm, 'preoccupied', at the moment.

I hope you are not asking to share my form! spoke Elbereth.

No, I as you can see, understand that my success in showing Thomas the true way has lead to a split in the faith, and with such a division no combination could be possible, not until a reconciliation is made, and all of our potent believers agree a path.

We cannot proceed any further, we are now stuck in an impasse, for we are connected and the balance is delicately set, we must await our followers to resolve the matter, they must either heal this rift within the temporal church, in which case we can combine, or dispose of the other half such that one of us is freed to ascendancy!

Elbereth and Grace looked at each other in agreement. As the two settled to wait, another idea hit Elbereth, after all, Grace agreed with much of what Elbereth proselytised, it was simply the precisely even division of their church, which created this state of affairs.

We could enter the void together.

What?"

I said we could enter the void together, since we are in a state of balance, there stands a good chance we would not negate each other, and we could take the conflict to Morgoth.

And as the void is nothing, we would not negate each other even if that balance was disturbed.

Precisely

The two slender elven figure observed each other, and smiled slightly, in exactly the same fashion as the other had done.

It's Insane!

Let's do it...

And with a simple act of will, both faded, travelling to the place where they could deal once and for all with

their joint nemesis.

~

Michael looked into the rift, knowledgeable that his priests had lent him vast amounts of energy through the enacting of the rite in Halgar. Though other figures stood beside him and in front of him, Michael had his eyes on just one figure, Fortis. The figure was familiar, the stance similar to his own, if a little more relaxed, the arms and armour the same as he wore when he went to battle, the emblem of the cross on both their tabards. Michael thanked Anarchus for his assistance over the past months, and his persistence in sending his love to his friend, not just to his god. Fortis drew his blade.

So, we are to do battle, I gathered as much from your followers who sought to speak with me. It is not easy for me to do this you know!

Then don't! snapped back Michael.

You don't understand, then I suppose you couldn't could you. You have not been through this already as the victor, whereas I have. Many years ago I stood where we stand now, and faced my opponent and fought. This is how I know what is going to happen and why.

Michael considered Fortis's words, as he slowly drew the blade he carried at his belt.

So, if you have done this before, you know who wins?

Yes.

And so you seek to drag out my death by this idle chatter, I shall do as asked by my followers, for a god is what' his faithful believe he is.

Michael suddenly brought his blade up on guard, and with a stamp of his right foot lunged with the sword. Batting the blow to one side, Fortis did not return the blow, but swayed slightly forcing Michael to twist his own footing to monitor the Namer. Michael saw in a moment what he had feared, In the matter of strength and skill, Fortis was more than his superior, after all Fortis was what he were to become, and had millennia to practice these skills. Michael lunged again, and again Fortis blocked the blow. Michael's mind raced, if Fortis knew what was going to happen and one last time, but was in fact Michael but older, the rules of paradox meant that Michael must win this fight, and that Fortis is indeed him simply aged after winning this battle. This was a foregone conclusion; Michael was going to defeat Fortis! Fortis cut a small wound on Michael's arm. Uh oh, what if Fortis does win this fight, and was not originally Michael at all, what if Fortis simply believed he was Michael, but in fact was born by this cycle of time travel simply always being? Then Michael could lose, and Fortis, without malice in his heart could believe that he was both the man as well as the god!

The two were the same essence that was clear, the dust forming between them was the byproduct of matter negating itself, so they were of the same material energy. In a flash of speed, Fortis struck Michael with seven quick blows, wounds erupting across the younger gods body, Michael could feel his strength fleeting, his power of faith in himself perhaps unworthy of his followers. Thoughts of his strongest believers passed through his mind,

images of Anarchus and Kamac, Vayle and Dalin, Lothan and Saladin. This was it, he was dying, he could feel his legs buckle beneath him, sprawled on the ground he could feel no pain from his waist down, holding himself up with his right hand as his left held his blade, the shield chopped from the arm earlier in the fight.

Catch! cried Humakt

Michael saw something spin towards him, and reaching out to grasp it by the hilt, Fortis struck a blow at his neck, severing spine and veins with what is described as a mercy blow by soldiers. Michael is a god however, and twisting, speared Fortis in the gut with the weapon Humakt had cast him, just before another god had struck Humakt himself down. Humakt's blade is called Death. At the beginning of time when men aged but had no release, simply ageing without a chance to escape to whatever heaven might await them, Humakt travelled to the other place and stole the Death from there, giving it to mortal men when it was their time.

Death killed gods as well as men.

Michael had won this fight, but with a bitter note in his heart, for one day. In millennia to come, he would come to this place and he would have to face this battle again, sure in the knowledge that he would fail, he would come to his old friends, Anarchus and Kamac, Vayle and Dalin, Lothan and Saladin, and be turned away and spurned. It would take courage to do what Fortis had done, but Michael promised to remember this day, and instruct his followers in the bravery of the Namer.

~

Shallya looked across the rift mouth at Paragon.

It seems that we have a choice.

You are correct as ever Answered Paragon. Paragon had taken a woman's form, as was his/her prerogative as a god and thus quite flexible in these things. She spoke again. ***You know that had your followers been more fortunate in the past, this eventuality may never have arisen, and you and I may not have to make this choice.***

Ignoring the comments Shallya continued, she was aware that Paragon was just trying to be nice, comforting her, but this nettled, after all Paragon had been here before, he knew what was going to happen.

Our Choice is as follows: Paragon, you go to the void or I Shallya go to the Void or we combine and combine as a single entity and exist under the name of The Lady of Mercy or whatever our followers elect to call us, as long as that name does not cause our combination to breakdown

I agree, these are difficult choices, neither of the two of us wish to enter the Void, for because of our nature we would swiftly become victims of Morgoth. Just as I would refuse to go to a senseless death, I would not ask you to go, for exactly the same reason.

Paragon nodded, he reached forwards, knowing that his strength and focus had exceeded Shallya's, he could have just waved his arm and she would have been gone. Instead he did the only thing a merciful god could, he gave all of what he was to her, and she in turn, realising that life eternal, beyond even conventional immortality,

had been assured to her. Joyously the two held hands and merged, safe in the knowledge that in millennia to come the same act would be repeated and the cycle would carry on for ever, for there was no doubt that the divinity of Mercy would return to Labyrinthia as Paragon thousands of years hence and simultaneously at this precise moment, and again combine to become the power of mercy! Mercy seeking a definitive name sent out a message to all her angels and mortal followers, for this day was to be a joyous one, for both Shallya and Paragon lived, the strengths of both had combined to the power of one, and all were to celebrate! The Power of Mercy left the rift calling to Torwln and Chernobyi, to Gysmo and Halvor, to Serrafin and countless others, Shallya was saved, Paragon was saved, and light could now shine easy upon the Empire again!

~

Humakt and Mortai stood there watching each other, gods on either side of them fighting or talking, it didn't matter which as both those present knew how this was going to turn out. Humakt was too weak to succeed, and Mortai recognised the desire to see death in the eyes of the old Runelord. This was no usurpation, this was a handing over of control from one to another, bringing in Vitality, for even though Mortai was millennia old, Humakt had been since the beginning of time, and sought that which he gave to others. At the correct time Humakt cast his sword "Death", to Michael as he battled with Fortis, ensuring one of the defenders survived, not feeling the blade of Mortai pass into his body, fading away as a memory from the land.

I am Mortai, I am Runelord, I am of the Line of Shallya, now Lady of Mercy, all those who would take up my banner, and the banner of the fallen god Humakt against the Undeath I call to arms now!

~

Talthar stood at the entrance to the doom, despairing and hopeful gods arrayed on both sides of the rift. Talthar stared at Hubris. Both being the gods that they were, they understood the importance of this moment, and neither wished to sound bullish and speak first, so Talthar took time to reflect over the inspiring speeches made by his followers in Halgar, both Aven's and Necromundi's words, sounding quite similar, echoing around his ears. Hubris spoke

I am stronger than you, I am wiser than you, I am more skilled than you. I am Hubris and you are Talthar, together this matter needs to be ended.

Hubris's blade flew across the gap, and cut across where Talthar's belly was. Talthar did not flinch. Hubris fell to the ground and slowly faded.

What you forget Hubris, is that only the underdog needs to hope, you may be faster and stronger, wiser and older, but I am the weaker, and as such this means I hold the hope in this place, and without hope you are nothing but your own name, pride.

Pride falls

Talthar turned from the Doom, events, which unfolded here, were beyond his remit, and the very act of suppressing his own power, veiling it until the last moment, blanking it from his own mind, meant he must leave NOW!

~

Divine Guidance

Light settles in the Temple in Halgar, many of the gathered are nursing wounds caused by such intense amounts of heat, and those with powers left pass amongst the ritualists healing what they can. The masters and mistresses of each faith stand as if transfixed watching something far away, something very important.

The ghostly images surrounding the Power Well slowly turn to face the assembled priest hood and as the high priests of each faith came out of their state of vision, some of the forms became animated, some started to change shape. Anarchus fell to his knees, sending a rippling wave across the chamber of people following in his stead. The Gods Spoke

I am Michael, I stand victorious.

I am The Lady of Mercy, I am two gods in One.

I am Talthar, I am Hope Eternal!

I am Mortai, I am Runelord, I am Humakt's Successor.

I am Justice, the source is within me!

I am the Bright Lady, I continue

I am the Sacred Heart, Letreal seeks to destroy me

I am Border, I have survived

Noticeably absent was a figure representing Elbereth, or Grace or some combination of the two, and when the High Priest of Elbereth was turned to for an insight to the matter, he was seen in close council with Darig of Elbereth. Then unspeaking, they gathered their fellows and left, grim looks of determination on their faces.

The Beginning...

Deities And Demigods

The Nature of the Divine

Deities by their very nature are beyond the true understanding of mortal men. What we see of deities is but a mere fraction of their existence, both in terms of scale and time. One might study a single deity for an entire mortal lifetime yet observe little more than the equivalent of a passing fragment of the deity's existence. One would never be foolish enough to consider to intimately understand the nature of men or even of a single man by observing a slice from a strand of his hair, for in our desire to understand gods that is what we attempt. All we can say is that to our observations some things seem to be constant. Those things that our constant to our perception we define as being the nature of the divine.

The veracity of such observation is of course flexible. It is liable to change but given we can only go by that which we can test we must call that "truth" and it is that truth that we use to define the nature of the divine.

Whilst understanding the nature of the divine, as mentioned previously, is hampered by the scale of what we are attempting certain things are apparent: Deities are as varied as the different races of Primus and the different members of those races. The varying races of deities are referred to as Pantheons. For instance the Namer Pantheon, The Primal Pantheon, The Elder Gods, The Outer Gods.

Deities are most often divided into two basic categories: Gods and Demigods. Demigods, as the name implies, are

weaker than gods but still beings of immense power in their own ways.

Characteristics shared by Demigods with gods is that they themselves appear to be sources of the Miraculous and, this would seem to suggest, in order to maintain the balance of the flow of faith, that they are in some manner capable of consuming belief.

It seems however that the gulf between Demigod and a True God is almost as wide as the gulf between Mortal and God.

The best known example of demigods are the Primal Deities, who walk Primus seemingly uninhibited and unimpeded by their divinity interacting with mortals as and how they feel and leading their followers by their very example.

Something else that seems to characterise deities. The inability to make choice. A lack of freewill. It seems that despite their great power gods are constrained by their nature. They are predictable and not subject to change of their own volition but rather are changed by the nature of their followers. Of course, again, this apparent lack of freewill may just be a failure to appreciate their lifespan and that it is not a lack of freewill but an inability or lack of desire to "change their mind" at a rate that we short lived mortals can visualise.

Watching-Owl

Ascended Mortals

It is not unknown for extremely powerful mercenaries to ascend to godhood. The first stage of such ascension is to achieve the status of Demigod. At this time a mere handful of well known Heroes of Labyrinthia have achieved this status: Og, Chernobyl, Harpell, Tsu-Ling, Thor and Torwin. Several things appear to mark such an ascension.

Usually these are mercenaries who are powerful either in personal power or personality. Such power seems to in a way lend itself to following the path of the divine. It seems that they are in their own way natural leaders and the faith and esteem that they are held in turns to belief in them possessing great otherworldly power, divine power. Such belief once given grows amongst the Peons who have heard of them and this effect seems to be self-propagating.

Of course the important aspect of such power is that the ascended mortal must be able to withstand the assault on their personality. Demigods often fulfil roles and it is said that these roles sometimes subsume the personality of those who assume them. Failure to control such forces can lead either to complete loss of the personality of the original being or simple insanity.

In the case of those who ascended by design the very nature and stability of their ascension would be lost with

the loss of their sanity and personality as these were the driving forces of their ascension and such ascension can simply fall away leaving an insane and broken individual. One infamous example of such a failing was Titus Sharp.

Such ascension by mortals seems to often require the assistance or interference of another divinity, to act as a guide and tales of such guidance are not uncommon.

Indeed experiments to create deities were undertaken by the Magiocaracies, with varying levels of success. The most well known of such experiments being The Ambrul, more commonly, but incorrectly, referred to as Woland's Brood, or The Brood.

It is also not unheard of however for an Ascended Mortal to reject such power. Why one would choose to step away from such power is not something easily understood but few things about the divine are truly comprehended and such individuals are rare. One such individual is Duke Saladin Bin Noordin. Once raised to join the deity he has for so long faithfully served he found that the constraints placed upon him were more than he could bear and returned to the mortal realms he so loves.

Watching-Owl

Divinities and Death

Can gods die? A question not easily answered. The Peon, will answer you without hesitation: "of course not, they're gods" but is this true? Well given that the perception of the average Peon does not extend to registering change but rather to accommodating and incorporating it directly into their understanding and memory of "How things have always been" they will never be able to comprehend or probably even remember the death of a Deity. If the strength of belief of a group of Peons is enough to hide a single man from scrying eyes then their belief that deities are immortal must lend credence to such an existence and create the situation whereby gods are indeed immortal.

In the end though whether they are affected by death or not is perhaps irrelevant given their longevity compared to the lives of men, again it is the matter of perception. As we cannot even perceive the life of a god the death of such would seem an all but meaningless concept to us.

There are of course various bits of evidence that point to the fact that the existence of a god can be extinguished. The most recent of these is of course the defeat of the Void God by the Lady of the Stars. Then prior to that was the culmination of the Namer War, an event that resolved itself by removing a number of deities from existence, prominent of these were the "Deaths" of Fortis, Hubris and Humakt. (The Imperial record of the final days of the Namer War is contained within this tome starting on page 52).

Followers of the Black Sun claim that in their vast Necropolis lie the remnants of ancient deities, passed on beyond normal time and memory but that claim itself presents further problems when looked at closer, especially with regards to the power source of the Priests of the Black Sun. (See Black Sun page 7).

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Angels and Avatars

Angels

What is an Angel? For this discussion let us leave aside the issue of the morality of an Angel. It is a term that could theoretically be equally applied to servants of non-goodly deities. For example of Redaip, a less than goodly deity, has been known to make use of Angels, just as goodly a goodly deity might.

An Angel, it would seem, is a fragment of the will of a deity. A more real expression of the power and force of a god.

But why would an Omnipotent being have need of an Angel? I believe that it is not a matter of need but rather a matter of self preservation. I postulate that Angels protect a deity from change. Gods are shaped by those who serve them. This seemed to be adequately proven by events during the Namer War. St Michael himself declared that he would fight Fortis, the Namer god who opposed him because that is what his follows wanted, not because he chose to do so. In fact it seems, in retrospect that he would have chosen another path had he the power to choose, as was suggested by Fortis.

I have already theorised that gods lack freewill and that gods are unable to develop, evolve, or be changed except by their followers. It is of course, following this line of reasoning, plausible that they are then susceptible to a mode of attack whereby their very nature can be altered by the acts, words and prayers of their followers, perhaps even to the extent of changing them beyond their original precepts. Of course this could just be a false perception but, again, the conclusion of the Namer War seemed to provide insights that corroborate this as being a truth of sorts.

If one accepts the above theory that a deity's nature can be changed by its mortal followers then one might wonder what may be done by the deity to guard against such change.

It is my belief that those followers of a deity powerful enough to evoke change in the nature of their deity are

themselves consumed, altered or changed by the deity. They become a part of the god and thus less likely to desire or attempt to change it or to even be able to bring such change about as they lose their own free will and become bound in servitude to that nature. Such beings we call Angels.

Those faithful who become Angels will insist that they have accepted the path laid before them, that they have been rewarded for their devotion and faithfulness and that they have willingly embraced this change in themselves. But those who knew the individuals before they became so transformed will often note that they have become intense, single minded beings. Lacking in the striking adaptability that marks men and mortals.

Whatever their purpose and whatever the reason for their creation, each Angel reflects a portion of the deity they serve, like facets on a diamond with differing Angels responsible for differing aspects of the deity. And it is from the observation of many such reflections that can learn a great deal about the nature of a deity, though perhaps not as much as by understanding its Avatar.

Avatars

It is obvious that an Avatar is of greater power than an Angel but what is the purpose of an Avatar? What can service can they perform that an Angel cannot? And again why are they necessary? The following appear to be facts relating to the nature of Avatars. What can be drawn from these facts is up to the individual scholar.

- Avatars, seem to suffer even further from the loss of freewill that accompanies the greater proportion of deific power invested in them.
- Each deity seems, at least on Primus, to be capable of only investing power or manifesting in one Avatar.
- Whilst the faith may have an Angel as its head strangely the Avatar is rarely the High Priest.
- Avatars seem to have the ability to directly manifest

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a portion of the will of a deity above and beyond the simply calling upon miracles. In fact Avatars exist that are not even priests or remotely capable of Priestly Skills.

I can draw many conclusions from the above observations but none seem to be suitably acceptable to place in word here and as a result I have not committed them to this tome.

As it would appear that Avatars are the eyes of a deity then it would also appear that the Avatar is the window of the deity's soul, the essence of the deity.

Elves

Whilst on the subject of the nature of Angels it seems worth discussing the existence of Elves. Elves appear, similarly to Angels, to be a

manifestation of the will of the Mana Dragons. By their very make up the nature of an Elf is strongly tied to the will of their elemental dragon. Their overriding sense of self and morality are that espoused by their dragon. Even more similarly like an Angel they are able to express supernatural powers related to their Dragon, trivially so in fact.

As in all things those with vitae are capable of developing beyond these restraints and such observations hold less true for Elves of the Mercenary Caste but in some ways Elves seem to serve the Mana Dragons in a very similar purpose as Angels serve deities. It is because Elves are almost "commonplace" amongst the Mercenary Caste that we tend to ignore the wondrous implications of their existence.

Heavens and Hells

Heavens and Hells, dwelling places of the deities. With one unusual exception of certain Demigods there are no deities native to Primus. Why it is the case that there are no deities native to Primus has been speculated on many occasions. Various theories abound.

Divine Compact

Legend tells of an agreement between the gods referred to as the Divine Compact. This legend tells of an agreement adhered to by all the deities which prevents direct manifestation or manipulation of Primus. Reasons for this theory are simply that it is the best means to prevent a destructive god war on a place of such import as Primus.

There is obviously something on Primus that is of great value to the gods. Rather than risk it being destroyed that they agree to work together.

Nagrech Filter

This theory states that the existence of the Nagrech prevents sufficient divine power from reaching Primus. This constriction in divine energy prevents the manifestation of divinities on Primus. All evidence presented to the Inquisition during my tenure as Lord Inquisitor pointed to this being correct. The Nagrech can be used to filter the power that flows between The Upper Planes, Primus and the lower Planes. The effects of this filtering are determined by the Master of Primus.

Nagrech Compact

This is a personal theory of mine and is little more than a loose combination of the Divine Compact and Nagrech Filter theories. This is the idea that guardianship

of the compact between the gods and the power to enforce it was given to mortals and the manner by which this control could be exercised was the Nagrech. Given the vast power of deities and yet the fact that they are in some way susceptible to being manipulated by a mere mortal and controlled by the Nagrech it would seem therefore that the only reason that this is the case is because the gods agreed to make it so.

This would go to some way to explain the rites of Acclamation, Assumption and Coronation that recognise and empower the Master of Primus. Present must be the representatives of the most powerful and influential of the Churches. Since the influence of the Church reflects the power of a deity on Primus it can be implied that this means the Master of Primus must have the support of the most powerful deities, effectively those who would lose most by having their power on Primus restrained.

The Primal Paradox

It is my belief that the Primal Deities either represent something wrong with the nature of Primus or simply are not actual true deities. It is a long held belief that gods do not or at the very least should not exist on Primus. Those beings referred to as the Primal Deities are not gods but rather some form of "Spirit" or embodiment of an aspect of Primus, perhaps in a similar fashion to City Spirits.

It is worth noting that each of the known Primal Deities seem to be bound to a location specific to Primus and it is this restriction, along with their great freedom of action, that seems to most confirm that fact that they are simply powerful spirits rather than true deities.

Faith and the Faithful

Faith and the Faithful

What is it that gods want of mortals? What do they desire? What is the importance of worship to the gods? A wise oracle once said: "What do all men of power want? More Power."

In the case of gods it would seem that that the means to such power for a deity is the worship and devotion of mortals.

Those willing to apply themselves to providing such power are the faithful of the deity. Their prayers and their preaching providing power in the form of belief.

Gods and the Godless

It is relatively common for Hermits and Shamans to draw power without recourse to deities, placing their faith in places, objects or simple forces. Less common are organised faiths and Churches that do likewise. However, whilst they are certainly far less common, there are faiths that do just that. Drawing power from the many, many nameless spirits that dwell upon the upper planes or demonic powers of the lower planes and have no figure head or deity, such as The Sacred Heart, The Disciples of the Bright Lady, The Glassians, The Rosarians, The Tryst or The Servants of Evil.

Interestingly it appears that such churches have little by way of Folk Following, or worship amongst the common

people. This has important implications for the consideration of faith. Do these faiths lack Peon Worship because the simple mindset of the Peon requires a figurehead for it to follow? Or more interestingly, if one considers the origins of gods, do these faiths lack deities because the belief of the Peons has yet to give them a personification?

The case of Milora, the Primal Deity, and the Church of Dead Heroes seems to be a most unique and interesting one. Those Peons who follow the Church of Dead Heroes seem to do so through direct worship of Milora, the one armed spearman. Yet the Priests of the Church of Dead Heroes seem to universally ignore Milora and have existed for sometime in monastic seclusion without the need for a deity. They draw power through their contact with Heroes past and do not seem to require a personification.

Of course there are always other theories and considerations. There is the idea that the flow of faith, once strong enough will always attract the attention of a deity able to consume it. So if the flow of belief were to grow strong enough a deity, sympathetic to such power, would appear, adapting to that faith and becoming the personification of those beliefs or ideals.

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Dragons and the Draconic

The Mana Dragons are somewhat of an anomaly in the Divine Order. They seem to exist without any recourse to needing worship. They have neither priesthood nor a Laity dedicated to spreading their word.

Those wielding the powers of the Mana Dragons are either skilled scholars or those with natural links to the elements. It is not a matter of faith for one to cast a spell as it would be a miracle but a matter of correct gesture and incantation. It seems but a simple skill for a scout to trigger the stored power of a spell that has been bound to a scroll yet pass the same Scout a miracle bound to a scroll and that is a far, far different matter.

Their power seems to flow from the Athfash Ban Mir across Ishma and into the world. They rarely seem to manifest Avatars in the way that the more spiritual beings seem to constantly need to.

This of course could simply mean that their power is so entrenched that they have no need to vie for worshippers. Whilst many goodly gods will grant the power to heal only one Dragon seems to shed light, or roast flesh, or control the winds. Why should this be? Perhaps over

time all variations of the Draconic were subsumed into individual purer forms?

Perhaps each Dragon is but a pantheon in itself, similar in ways to The Rings of Talthar, the pantheon of Hope.

Some of the Dragons powers are unusual combinations to say the least. Although we accept without question when examined seem a little counterintuitive. The most obvious example would be the case of such is the White Mana Dragon. Even now it would seem to be two Dragons. One of Light and One of Cold. It is followed by two distinct sets of Elves, Light Elves and Winter Elves. Perhaps it is the combination of two Dragons that gives it its unusual ties.

Why should Light and Cold be allied? They would seem to be enemies, for, as any dweller of the wilds will tell you, the light of the Sun brings warmth and who would regard the numbing cold of the Deathly Season as a good thing? Should not Light and Fire be of one Dragon and Darkness and Cold be one Dragon?

Watching-Owl

Primus and the Primal

The Nagrech

The renowned Imperial Artificer and Scholar, Baron Layendar the Grey, has expounded the theory that the Nagrech is in fact an artificial construct. There are clues that point towards its being artificial in origin, the existence of Oeldwych dust for instance. Besides from this little is known of it, or rather little is known to those who do not sit upon it or are its Wardens, and perhaps as all great secrets this is the way that it should remain.

Whatever its true nature the Nagrech has become the symbol of the Imperial Reign, though it obviously predates the Empire. The concept of Glass, as the Nagrech is often referred to, has become a symbol of the Empire. The Throne of Glass, The Lake of Glass, the Church of Glass and so forth.

But what is known, or what, at the least is widely believed of the Nagrech at this time?

- The Nagrech controls the flow of faith
- The Nagrech requires a Master
- The Nagrech vents entropy
- The Nagrech sits at the "Heart of Primus"
- The Nagrech is a favoured place of the Primal Spirit

It is said that through the Throne flows the power of the gods. It is of course entirely possible that it is this belief that makes it so. The singular events of the Nagrech Heresy, propagated by Thor of Talthar, seem to have led some credence to such a suggestion but some timely diplomacy seems to have weighed strongly enough to prevent a possible catastrophic proving of such a theory.

I have a number of personal theories that I am investigating but until such time as my studies and divinations are complete I will leave you with a treatise by Layendar the Grey.

Nagrech and Reality

"Watching-Owl, Although my studies regarding the Nagrech have been woefully fragmentary, I hope I can supply at least enough information and theory to provoke some thought in your readers. The Nagrech Crystal is essentially formed of a mystical compound which is perfectly balanced in regards the elements and forces that make up all things - not just the denser forces such as the magical elements or the spiritual energy that is wielded by priests, but also the very principles upon which all things are founded - law, chaos, love, hatred and so forth.

"This inner balance makes Nagrech (if that is the name of the material itself - my studies have not confirmed this as yet) perfect in its ability to focus and manipulate all things. The power of the Nagrech Crystal, given its size, positioning and relative purity, makes it so able for its task that it has been described by a learned scholar as "the

only real thing in the exostance" - something of an exaggeration, perhaps, but certainly a perspective that is not so far from the truth. In order to discuss the value of the Nagrech crystal, it would be necessary to first discuss the nature of planar dynamics, pre-exostantial theories and several other related subject matters, most of which are of a large part theoretical. Even a précis of such is beyond the scope of this discussion, so I will instead focus upon how the Nagrech appears to interact with the realm of the realm of the divine, which should be of most interest to your readers.

It is clear that belief and spiritual power have the capability to cross the Aether, but much like water it appears to be their tendency to flow in every direction unless channelled. This is somewhat simplistic - really belief has a tendency to flow towards the divine source that would best represent it, but it is a somewhat limited tendency.

The Nagrech acts like a lens, focussing both the belief from Primus (and the lower, Epidal planes) to the upper, Divine planes, and the Divine power 'downwards' towards Primus, and through the 'lens' to the lower planes. It is in this way that the Nagrech permits the easy flow of power from the higher planes, and thus the formation of organised but locationally remote groups that worship beings and divine sources of power from other planes - those things that we call churches. Every indication is that without it, the flow of belief and power would be limited such that the direct interaction with divine beings from the higher planes would be much more difficult, and the organisation of religious beliefs in churches would be almost impossible in practical terms, as only the most gifted and devout are favoured with direct contact with their deific plane.

It is likely in this case that most religion would take the form of shamanic beliefs - drawing power from the shared divine power of those in the immediate vicinity, and from worship of the so-called 'Primal Deities', although it is not clear how readily these could be worshipped in such a case. All this lends credence to the recent claims that most of the deities currently worshipped on Primus are alien to this place, and the original spiritual practices of Primus, if it serves to make a distinction between aeons, are the oft-derided shamanic and witchcraft practices. Certainly, it would seem that the churches owe a lot to the Nagrech Crystal, and she who sits upon it. Fortunately for them, the Nagrech crystal owes a lot to the churches also, but that is a matter for another discussion entirely.

*Baron Layendar The Grey
Imperial Scholar*

The Master of Priums

He, or she, who sits upon the Nagrech is referred to as the Master, or Mistress, of Primus. They are given the power to control the flow of belief as it permeates

through Primus and to the realms beyond.

In recent history there have been two periods when the

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throne was unoccupied, the first, known simply as the Masterless Time followed the removal of Emperor Amora and without an Emperor on the Throne dangerous levels of Entropy slowly began to manifest without proper guidance. The attempted venting of such entropy however partially failed leading to the destruction of Gileenim.

During the second such period when there was no living Master of Primus to regulate the Nagrech the very blood of the Sallow, quite literally, was used to sustain the Throne. Following the assassination and the final vanquishing of the spirit of Emperor Michael I during The Mittlesmith Vexathaccor's Throne of Wood Crisis the blood of Michael's children was used to stabilise the Throne. An act of great sacrifice by Truic Badrass before she became Empress. An act necessary no doubt due to the direct assault on the Primal Reality by the Mittlesmith Vexathaccor.

God Emperors

It is interesting to note that amongst the many mooted qualities that allow for a sane Master of Primus, or at least those I uncovered during my period of investigation into the various rites of Coronation, is mortality. It occurs to me that perhaps part of the problem associated with the sanity of the Masters of Primus might in itself lie with a process of partial deification. As has been noted previously the process by which a mortal may ascend can quite simply cause insanity.

Now it is a well known fact that eventually the strength of mind of a Master of Primus is slowly, but not irreparably, broken by fulfilling the role of Master of Primus.

Since very few mortals have the power to remain sane by deification the insanity that seems to eventually grip each who sit upon the Nagrech for any length of time may simply be a result of the mistaken belief in a "God-Emperor" by their subjects. The attribution and hence eventual manifestation of divine traits within a mortal without the ability to control or use them leads to insanity.

It is not too hard to envisage a situation whereby a long standing, successful Master of Primus is viewed as a god by his subjects and that belief seeks to take reality. The Master, already tied to the Forces that are Primus and Empire, simply cannot draw upon or resist this deification and is driven insane by it.

Whatever the truth of the matter it would, on the face of it, seem unwise to allow a Master of Primus to be thought of as divine. Even if it is as simple as not angering those greater Forces who's flow of power is regulated through the Nagrech by the Master of Primus. Those other Forces who may well deem it an offence that a deity exists by virtue of "stolen" power as would arguably be the case for a deified Master of Primus.

Watching-Owl

Cities and City Spirits

Within the heart of each of the Empire's cities lies a City Spirit, the soul of the city if you will, a representation of the simplest lives, trials, triumphs and desires of those that dwell within the city. Most of what follows is conjecture garnered from snippets of information and whilst little is certain my observations and interactions with some of the City Spirits leads me to believe the following:

It would seem the spirit is the living will of those who dwell within a city made manifest. The Spirit and its "priesthood", The Kallah, guard their city, work for its best and vie for prominence in the eyes of the Primal Spirit. The City Spirit, within its city, is all but immortal and the older more powerful spirits can use almost godlike powers.

The Nature of the City Spirits

City Spirits seem unable to influence those around them without taking a host however this taking of a host, whilst granting them a corporal form, engenders a certain vulnerability. On taking a body the spirit becomes a blending of the personality of the spirit and the host body. The different levels of blending lead to two forms of City Spirit, those whose host body is able to master and control the force that is the Spirit and those whose Spirit is able to master and subdue the will of the host, referred to respectively as Host-Ascendant and Spirit-Ascendant.

However the necessity to take on a host body seems to leave the spirit vulnerable to certain things and a City Spirit can become trapped in its body. If the body dies and the spirit is trapped within, then this bodes badly for the city, such I have witnessed with the decline of Alguz after it's spirit was so trapped in its slain body.

It would seem that the ritualists of House Natal have great knowledge in manipulating a City Spirit, or at the very least the City Spirit of Halgar. It is commonly

known that Earl Natal selected at least one body for the Spirit of Halgar, the Senatorial Aide, Stooks, had the spirit forced upon him at the end of the 2nd age. Done presumably to give the nobility a greater say in the actions of the spirit, having served an agreed term the spirit was released from Stooks and stored awaiting to be placed into another vessel, however with the capture of Earl Natal by the Hordehost during the events of The Choice, it seems that the rites used to hold the spirit expired, as rites do at a Final Dawn and the spirit was free to choose its own vessel.

The Origin of the City Spirits

The origin of the city spirits is a strange one. The history of the Realm of Glass records that Emperor Amora released the spirits of the cities but there are now many indications that the City Spirits are far older than Amora and were in fact restrained by him or the Sallow Princes before. No doubt further manipulation of history by Emperor Amora through the Night of Levity.

One of the spirits has claimed that for a time he and his kin were more than they are now, not simply bound to a city but more akin to realm spirits, wandering free like the Primal Deities.

The tribes too tell of a greater past. It seems that the Sallow Princes chose the sites of their cities with careful consideration. The tribes relate how the cities of the Invaders were constructed on their Sacred Places. Places where the totems and spirits were strong and free. These places of tribal power were corrupted and the spirits that dwelt there trapped by the construction of "rings of stone" the dwelling places of corrupted men. This entrapment transforming and enslaving them, changing them over time until they became what they are now, the City-Spirits. To those who say this unlikely one need only look to the positioning of the youngest of the Empire's cities, the City of Keys. Built atop the most

sacred of the Tribal places remaining in the Empire, Armastas.

The Servants of the City Spirits

These are the Kallah and Hanot Beggars, who often derive supernatural power from their city. These gifts are consistent with the mood of the spirit, which in turn is dictated by the mood of the city's citizens. The Kallah

and Hanot could in some ways be called the Priests and Paladins of the City Spirit, their faith the Cult of the City Spirit, a faith as influential as any faith that might exist.

The history of the Kallah Caste is not without mystery. It is whispered that they were not always beggars, they were forced to become beggars that they could hide for their influence over their city's was feared.

The Primal Spirits

The Wormwood Letters Suspected to have been an Imperial Scribe until the reforms of Chancellery, Inquisition and Bastion, Wormwood is reputed to be a scribe-for-hire. Imperial records show no person by such a name having ever served in the Imperial Bureaucracy and scholars suspect 'Wormwood' to be a name used by scribes whenever the unexpected happens, or someone is to blame when no one wants to take the buck.

Nonetheless, the Wormwood Letters appear from time to time amongst the Scribes Reaches, Inky Inns or Bicker Halls of the Empire. Wormwood here talks about the Primal Spirits as he or she understands them.

"Brothers!

Much as the Whiteocracy would have us silenced through his henchman and executioner Trundle still we speak of matters of merit and weight within our Empire. I write this day of the Primal Spirits. We are all of us aware that the primary force is that named for being just such - Primus. Both the world in which we live, and a conscious force in and of itself Primus is the defining power for our Land.

As we all know, with the ending of the year all that we believe, perceive and love is unmade. The stars expand or fall and for the merest of moments all that is ceases to be. It is at that time that Primus views the world and then through his perception restores himself once again. This death of the year sees turmoil and cold through the season that follows it as the land settles and sheds what *was*, for what now *is*.

But it is not simply through his own perceptions that this is made. It is through the eyes and beliefs of the people, those many minds and souls that are not made independent of Primus by the curse of Vitae. Not even the Primal Spirit can see all and so it is not he or she alone that visits all the lives of this land. Rather it does so through a number of lesser Spirits, both geographical and otherwise.

Of these the most famous and least hidden are the City Spirits. Tied to a beacon of civilisation they reflect the people and their perception of their city. The Spirits vary in power, most notably when the flesh they inhabit is in dominance to the Spirit itself, the time of such assumption and the power of the city itself. Certainly there is a hierarchy of power amongst the city spirits and I suspect even allegiances and conflict amongst them. Further, these Spirits talk to one another and unite and plot together more through worldly character than the city itself. This duality makes them unpredictable, their alliances seemingly based on mortal likes and dislikes as much as the more material political considerations.

But above these, I am told, lie the Realm Spirits. What form they take and what power they wield I can only speculate about in the purity of the Bicker Halls.

It is perhaps others that draw my concern more. For as most of us know there are mortals that travel this land, each of them possessed of some fragment of Primus. Such powers are said to carry a small part of the Primal whole within them, some representation. Most of such study was destroyed in the evil of the Night of Levity but still today we hear of them. Of a Spirit that is of the common warrior, of a Spirit that is a thing of the Tranquil Wave, of a Spirit that concerns itself with victory through trickery, Of a Spirit that is said to be concerned with dominion, even lies and deceit. It is true, as we know, that those aspects of the populace as we perceive them in our observations and traditions are derived from our understanding of Primus. Therefore might it not be logical to assume that there is a Spirit of murder? Of malcontention? Our simple rites suggest this to be so. After all if this is how the Primal whole is identified to us, is it not likely that each is a Primal power in its own right?

Two things are of more concern to your concerned Wormwood.

Firstly, that there have been Spirits before. Can it rightly be said that the trickster or the tranquil Spirit are the first of their kind? There are likely differences assuredly, in name and focus but are these predecessors truly different? I think it unlikely. There is a history to each of them, and though many now lie dead might they not rise again? It is true that even these predominate on our eastern coast but thus is not ultimately surprising as our civilisation spread from the west. This becomes more clear in the light of my second concern.

For secondly, despite the seeming reliance on city, are these Spirits now a remnant of the older land? The Night of Levity might have removed any vestige of knowledge of the First Age and much of the work of the Sallow Princes but a little remains. In particular we should compare the Spirits exemplified by the tribes. Whist the terminology might vary and the names be different there are obvious parallels between our own geographical Spirits and those proclaimed to be of leaf, wood and hill. More damning perhaps is the evidence of their 'Walking Gods'. Comparisons with the forces previously spoken of are acutely similar..."

Wormwood

The General Inquisition



The General Inquisition is that body within the Empire responsible for monitoring and dealing with threats of a supernatural nature. Currently it is divided into nine departments and presided over by the Lord Inquisitor. Given the highly supernatural nature of Primus and the Empire the position of Lord Inquisitor is one which carries a great deal of weight and influence. Such that the Lord Inquisitor carries with it the rank of Imperial Senator.

The post of Lord Inquisitor was one I held. My reasons for taking on the task, or even serving the Empire so hated by my people have confused many but I had my reasons. Most prominent amongst these was simply because at the time The existence of Primus itself was threatened in a way that it had not been for a 1,000 years: The end of an Age.

What I write now may seem conceit but it is truth: No other could siege the post with the combination of contacts, in both the Mercenary Caste and the Imperial Nobility, and skills; my personal powers of divination, understanding of the Empire and not inconsiderable tact

and diplomacy all leant to me being the man for the job at the time.

For those who would serve the Inquisition it is important to remember why the scales feature in its ten coats of arms, there are no absolutes but rather: **All things in balance.** The Inquisition has neither the strength or power to directly control *all* those forces that would assail the Empire however by subtlety and diplomacy can the forces be acted upon to balance each other and support each other. When this is done successfully the people of the Empire are barely aware of the Inquisition's presence it is only in failure that we are noticed.

Under Amora the Inquisition was divided into nine "Traditional" departments. The term traditional is of course hard to apply when the Inquisition in its current form may not even have actually existed before the Night of Levity. However as is the mark of good leadership that which can be improved upon will be and it seems that my successor, Lord Inquisitor Anacrites, has re-ordered this august Imperial body into **Truic's Inquisition.**

Amora's Inquisition



Mentatus

Arguably the most well known, or at least feared, post in the Inquisition. Unlike the other posts the Mentatus has a dual role. Like the other departments he safeguards the Empire against specific threats, in this case those of a psychic nature, such as the now defeated Silverfolk but also the Mentatus is also responsible for that most enigmatic, feared and universally hated of Imperial organisations: The Imperial Seers.

The power and influence of the Seers is remarkable. The Charter granted to the Imperial Seers, under Tithe, Amora's Mentatus, was not inconsiderable. The precise details are quite interesting and I choose not to describe them here other than to say that they are the eyes and ears of the Master of Primus and that their primary task is the management of the flow of Entropy that is generated simply by the existence of order within Primus.

The role of the Mentatus has shrunk over recent years, if for no better reason that the successful defeat of the Silverfolk. The Silverfolk now being confined to the Astral Plane are no longer the organised threat that they were and the dedication of my Mentatus at the time, Selgard, can only be commended.

Spiratus



The Spiratus, one of the busiest of the departments, yet seemingly the hardest to find suitable candidates to head. The Spiratus is responsible for monitoring threats of a Spiritual nature towards the Empire. The job of Spiratus is made all the more difficult by the need to liaise with the Churches of the Empire.

The Churches have an exceedingly important role within the Empire. No other nation on Primus endures the doubled edged sword that is organised religion. The North is a land of Wild untamed Spirits called upon by Shamans and Druids, the East a land where the Golden Emperor is god, the Southern Baronies are bound by The Accords where to even call upon a deity is to break the laws. In Ishma, to the West, the power of the Mana Dragons and the Athfash Ban Mir, rules and even further beyond the ravaged continent is Bourthek where the gods do not even gaze.

The strength, and indeed very character, of the Empire owes a great deal to the Churches and their organised religions. The Healers who tend to the armies, the militant faiths who inspire the humble soldier and so forth. Yet they are the single greatest internal threat to the Empire. Maintaining this crucial balance whilst ultimately the responsibility of the Lord Inquisitor it is the unenviable job of the Spiratus to make sure that all is well.

Majitus



The department of the Majitus is responsible for monitoring the effect of Magic on the empire. For ascertaining the risks it can pose and for addressing the problems of rites. This eventually came to include threats from the Secundal realms, mainly through the leadership of Lord Inquisitor Anacrites, who was Majitus during my term of office.

During his tenure as Majitus Senator Anacrites was very much a hands on man. He lead Inquisitional mercenary teams, performed a vast bulk of the Inquisition's investigations into the Mittlenacht and probably remains the Empire's foremost expert on the Mittlenacht,

developing the now famous "Rite of Paths" that allow "safe" travel through the Mittlenacht. I was quite comfortably able to delegate the Throne of Wood threat and the problems posed by the Mittlesmith Vexathaccor in the hands of Majitus Anacrities.

Gaius



The department of Gaius is responsible for monitoring the Natural forces of Primus, not an easy job. The natural order is something to be respected, not threatened or coerced. At should be allowed to continue along its own path, in own time in its own way. The balances it creates should be observed. Unfortunately the action of Man, his rites and unnatural manipulations impact greatly on the nature of Primus and when stressed the forces of nature rebel. It is these rebellions that the Gaius needs to deal with. The Gaius needs to understand when the natural forces should be left to restore their own balance, when they need to sped along and when perhaps for the greater benefit they need to be dealt with in some other way.

The multifaceted will of nature is expressed through her servants, the Druids and it is ultimately to the druids that the Gaius must turn to. Often a Druid himself provision was created for rites that sunder the link the Gaius has with the rest of nature. The natural order that prevents one druid harming another can be suspended for the Gaius in order that where necessary he can act against individual druids.

It was Amora's Gaius, Kith Kaharn, Avatar of the Ratgod Slavik, who created the Ratfolk to perform a task for the Empire. By all accounts the Ratfolk performed the task but were betrayed their payment. And sought only a place to live within the Empire (*See Slavik page 30 for further details on the short history of the Ratfolk*).

Diablos



Another hard working department., That of the Diablos. The remit of the Diablos is such that it can cross over into any of the other departments. The Diablos is responsible for dealing with unreasonable Supernatural Threats. Usually those from other worldly sources and usually, but not exclusively, those of a Demonic nature.

When the Empire calls together great musters of mercenaries it is usually the Diablos Department that has a had a hand in it and over the years the Diablos Department has learned to operate with a fair degree autonomy from its departmental head and has forged a good working relationship with the mercenary caste. Under the guidance of my first Diablos, Amporphus, the department learnt to anticipate the needs of the Mercenary caste and its stores are now filled with general equipment as used by Mercenaries and with the kind of trinkets that mercenaries appreciate being rewarded with.

Benefatum



The forces of Light, ever watchful, ever militant, ever ready to act to purge the land of the forces of darkness, ever ready to spread their crusades across Primus and save the souls of the misguided...

To quote the Realm Spirit Primus: "Goodly spiritual people! That's all we need wandering about the place. I tell you, I get more trouble resulting from goodly spirits than anything else. They get together, roam about and force their own twisted moral code on anybody else who even vaguely looks at them. I tell you, it'll be goodly people who'll try and capture me, or influence the Throne. Oh yes, they're 'right' so everything they do can't be 'wrong'. Children!"

The Benefactum is responsible for overseeing the forces of Light, namely the highly organised goodly churches, especially those of a militaristic bent. It is not an easy job, the goodly Churches strongly believe in their god given right to cleanse the world around them.

There are problems with this though, not least the strong held belief in the Decree of Night and Day, that decree imposed by a past Master of Primus that declared that Primus should never be a haven of light, a bastion against the dark or a cruel darkened realm but rather to swing between the

Malefactum



Direct counterpart to the Benefactum they Malefactum must keep an ever-present eye on the sly creeping darkness, that evil that hides out, quietly waiting and biding its time to grab for power. Where the goodly faiths are straight-forward and obvious the darker powers are slow, sly, subtle and patient. Harder to spot until ready to take action they present a very different threat to Primus and the Empire.

Ironically one of their greatest threats is their provoking of the goodly faiths. Their existence within the Empire is seen by many of the goodly faiths as a sin, an abomination and often it is their provocation, by deliberately flouting the protection offered them by Imperial Law that causes problems. Rarely so crass as to deliberately and directly cause trouble they can act as an insidious force within the structure of the Empire.

An astute Malefactum is able to tell when a force of darkness truly seeks peaceful co-existence or is simply biding its time to strike and to react accordingly. Strike too harshly and it will simply bury itself deeper its holes, fail to act at the appropriate time and it will simply grow beyond reckoning.

Statafactum



One of the smaller of the Departments. The Statafactum is responsible for maintaining a watch over the Empire's interests in Mystic Law. Traditionally the Lord Inquisitor is replaced by the Statfactum. A tradition that was broken with by my promotion from Spiratus to Lord Inquisitor and further discarded by the appointment of my Majitus, Anacrites, as my successor in the post of Lord Inquisitor.

Entropofactum



The Entropofactum is responsible for monitoring the nature of Chaos and Entropy that is the inevitable side effect of advanced ritualism and the very nature of the imposition of Law on the reality of Primus.

Truic's Inquisition

With Empress Truic coming fully into her power she has thrown aside the Amoran Traditions of her father and re-organised much of the Empire, the Inquisition has likewise been re-organised and been streamlined. New departments have been created through amalgamation of the old ones. It is too early in the new Inquisition's arrangement to comment on its effectiveness but the

Lord Inquisitor's Reeve: Special Assistant to the Lord Inquisitor, no specific duties listed.

Warden of Beyond: External Supernatural threats, complex interplanar threats including those of a temporal nature. Additionally the Imperial Seers nominally report to the Warden of Beyond. Effectively amalgamating and expanding upon the duties previously performed by the Departments of the Diablos and Mentatus.

Watcher of Faiths: Briefed to monitor faiths, beliefs and Churches to identify those who's tenets or practices may be inimicable to the interest of the people of the Empire and suppress such faiths.

Keeper of Lore: Collation and analysis of inquisitional records and master of the scribes that report to the Inquisition

Monitor of Rites: Responsible for the tracking of ritual activities that may be deemed a danger to the citizens of the people

Master of Steel: A new department, responsible for all aspects of Inquisitional Security.

Inquisitional Resources

Under Inquisitor Anacrites the resources of the Inquisition have expanded greatly, ancient libraries, *Ritual Chambers*, the *Bloodsworn Guard* and the *Black Library* where collected works and tomes whose secrets are deemed too dangerous to be left in the hands of all but a select few.

Often forgotten is that the Lord Inquisitor, is a highly skilled Mithlsmith, one of the reasons for my employing him as Majitus. He is often ensconced in the Inquisition Orrery Chambers poring over the maps contained within. These maps are rumoured to display and represent the very flow of power, faith and, most importantly combine with his skills as a Mithlennacht to show any changes in the nature of primus and the Empire especially changes caused by Mithlennacht Convergence or Secundal Slippage.

The Final Dawn

The Final Dawn is a term scholars apply to the moment when the Primal Spirit gazes across Primus and sees through the eyes of his servants. What it sees will then define the world for the next year. At this point the flow of power across Primus is cleansed meaning those rites not stabilised and tied to Primus tend to unravel as they are brushed aside for the new year.

However the references to the Final Dawn that concern us are that relating to not just the end of the year but the end of an Age. In this case the end of the Second Age and the start of the Third Age in which we now find ourselves, The Final Dawn of IM999 when even the Primal Spirit itself was renewed and replaced. At that Final Dawn even the most robust of spells were unravelled and failed. With the ending of the Millennium came the very Death of Magic where all rites faded, all spells ended, all artefacts died and even the spells that bound Elfkind into their living existence ended. For the briefest of moments all magic ended before being recreated by the refreshed Mana Dragons. With all old magics brushed aside ancient artefacts cracked and died and the centuries of residual magics were cleansed that the world might be renewed.

Whilst a discussion of the nature of this event could itself occupy its own tome I will stick to a précis of the basic facts of import. In the last few days leading up to the Final Dawn of the second age, and to my actual surprise, the Senior Mennihaf, declared Inquisitional Law. For this brief period I, as Lord Inquisitor, was charged with the defence and protection of the Empire and Primus. I had been appointed the supreme authority in the Empire.

Bar two notable failings it seems that my guidance of the countless mercenaries allowed the survival of the greater whole. A trying and sleepless period for me but no less than any of the other mighty heroes who bled and died at that time following my orders almost without question.

For the record my two failings were that Primus lost a race of beings, known as The Navigators, and the Empire lost the City of Ickybiggle. A third disaster was averted, not through anything I achieved but rather, by the placation of the Outer and Elder gods by the Church of Lost Salvation. There, it seemed, a possible fourth disaster, the death of the Grey Mana Dragon, was averted by the childlike mage Bluebottle, Elemental Lord of Twilight. The Mana Dragons themselves cast a spell to heal Primus of the rift known as Amora's Doom and for this it seemed they used the essence of the Grey Mana Dragon to cast the spell. In some fashion the acts of the Elemental Lord saved the Dragon. Even to this day I am not sure quite what Bluebottle did but he is a creature who, with a modesty not often seen in the mercenary caste has saved a great many people, worlds and times by his skills.

Later events tended to indicate that at least something went "wrong" with the Final Dawn, as typified by the machinations of the Mithlsmith Vexacathaccor, but that is of small import in the great scheme of things, for Primus survived, the Empire survived and the people survived.

Watching-Owl

The Treatises of Da'Karte

The Nature of Gods - Understanding, Understanding

Understanding the nature of the divine is a task most of us will never fully accomplish, for in doing so one will come to understand the very nature of all, and it is that understanding that in and of itself creates the divine. Thus in understanding Divinity one becomes part of it.

As the above paragraph should indicate, what follows is

not true.... At least it is not the truth in its entirety. For I have not yet fully come to understand the nature of the One Truth, and thus I cannot truly explain the nature of it. Rather I have sought to set out my views and the lessons of my people that others might grasp what we believe and thus the knowledge of my people is passed on.

A Word on Perception

This document often refers to the powers and significance of perception. Because of this it is worth devoting some time to explain what is meant by the term in the context it is used.

Perception in both its focused and unfocused varieties refers directly to how the world is viewed and experienced by an individual or group. It therefore directly affects the belief structures of that individual or group.

Perception of a thing does not indicate understanding of it. However understanding of a thing requires knowledge of how it is perceived. Perception is a powerful tool

because it has a direct impact on belief and thus the will of any given individual or group.

By adjusting an individual's perception of a situation, you can manipulate their belief and acceptance of that situation. Thus Perception and belief directly relate to one another, and it is belief in a situation or thing that affects the will of an individual.

It is that will that is central to power.

Thus by altering or maintaining perception we can control both belief (thus faith) and will (thus power)

The One Truth

It is this concept that defines the Gythzeri Understanding of the divine it shapes it and goes some way to answering the questions we have about the Divine.

The Concept is a simple one.

There is but one single truth. Once the mind comprehends that truth then all things are within its grasp.

I cannot explain this truth for I do not yet understand it. I can however offer what we believe to be proof of its existence.

Let us consider for a moment the power of perception, for perception that a thing is so, is able to make it thus, if the will behind such a perception is strong enough. This can

be seen in many examples from the massed will of the peons of Primus, to the will of eastern warriors reforming their shattered bodies.

The most common form of perception altering reality is the use of higher mind functions or psionics, as the people of Primus refer to them. These powers are commonly seen amongst mercenaries of power, and enable many forms of seemingly mystic feats that come from no other source than the will of the practitioner.

This ability to influence the world around us without external aid goes some way to confirming that such power is not solely the province of dragons and deities and that once one understands the true nature of something one can manipulate it.

Achieving Understanding

Knowing that there is a truth, does little to ultimately assist one in reaching an understanding of it.

It is the quest for this understanding that ends in the process of ascension, a task not easily achieved. The process of ascension often seems to involve huge rituals. Or even the intervention of another deity. In such cases the truth is either explained by another who already understands. Or in the case of ritual ascendance the sacrifice of the thousands of lives required (In nearly all recorded cases of ascension ritual mass sacrifices are required) Transfers the power of the sacrificed

individuals will and perception, to the focus of the rite. Allowing said focus to expand their understanding and perception to the point of comprehension of the one truth.

It is indeed these two methods that in recorded history have seen the most successful ascensions. Leading a portion of my people to believe that understanding cannot be truly accomplished alone but rather it is passed on. For my part I refute that but I would agree that the process of rite or interference of another deity seems to hasten the process of understanding.

Divine Guidance

My refusal to accept the theory that these two methods are the surest path to ascension comes from the story of our most hated enemy. Her shining Ascendancy, Gyth.

The Histories of the Silver Folk race clearly indicate her Ascension was achieved alone, indeed her mental incarceration by the Illithid race, forced her to become completely alone. It was during this period of enforced mental withdrawal that Gyth came to understand the nature of the truth. Achieving this understanding of course shattered the bonds of her slavery and she was able to lead what would become the Gyth peoples to freedom.

As a side note it is possible to draw certain conclusions about the nature of gods, from their mental state at their time of ascension. Gyth was likely angry and bitter at her enforced slavery, and also determined that neither she nor her people would ever serve again. The result created an angry and bitter deity determined to rule all peoples so that she may not herself be ruled but I digress...

However it is achieved one thing is clear once understanding is finally achieved the changes both physical and metaphysical wrought upon the body and psyche of individual are extensive.

Living with the Truth

The questions arising about life after understanding is achieved are many, and they may never truly be answered. For once the concepts of the universe are manipulated at will Time, space, and all the laws of planular dynamics mean very little. The lives of gods are outside of our abilities to perceive.

However some things do seem clear.

Divinities seem unable to inhabit the material planes of existence. Why this occurs is unknown. And theories range from the concept that material existence is too bland for the minds of deities, to the collective unaccepting wills of the countless mortals rejecting the presence of such unrestrained and unfathomable power.

Recently anomalies have occurred located on Primus that seem in some way to question this fact, but I will discuss the so called Primal Deities later in this document

The other significant point seems to be the tunnelling of will. It seems that understanding the One Truth has certain side effects the most significant of which seems to be the focussing of the individual's nature. Deities seem to almost lose the power of self determination and rather become bound by their nature to act in a certain way.

It is this focus that leads gods into becoming a definable being in the eyes of mortals.

What causes this phenomenon is unclear; perhaps it is simply impossible to grasp the complete nature of the truth meaning that an individual will simply slip into one aspect of that truth. Perhaps the focus is created by the individuals mind set at the time of ascension, combined and reinforced by their basic nature and personality, as noted above in the case of Her Shining Ascendancy. Or perhaps it is simply mortal inability to understand a deity and thus we must perceive them as a focussed entity.

The other clear need of deities is faith... this fervent belief or trust in them seems somehow to sustain them.

For an explanation of this need we must again look at the concept of perception. It seems that in understanding the truth one literally become part of perception. Thus the perception of Mortals seems to have a direct and quantifiable effect on the nature and power of deities. Deities in turn fuel faith in themselves by granting power to mortals who offer them great amounts of faith. Creating a priesthood.

The Word

The creation and activities of priesthood appear to be a vital lynch pin in the existence and lifespan of a deity.

Priesthoods are a very common sight in and on Primus, and indeed in the empire surrounding the central hub of primus they are perhaps society's greatest focus, leading the population and guiding them in their perceptions of deities.

Deities seemingly direct a priesthood to spread "the word" and dutifully the priests of a deity do so spreading the teaching of their god to all who will listen. Significantly in most cases these teachings are detailed to the priesthood by the deity themselves.

We can draw conclusions that perception of a deity's existence is vital to its continued existence but not only that, it seems that how a deity is perceived is just as important as it being perceived in the first place. Indeed

deities seem willing to take extraordinary steps to ensure that perceptions of them change as little as possible. This includes curtailing the freewill of their most significant exponents. This is accomplished via the binding of power to an individual priest and forming the resulting being in the deities own image (or part of its own image)

This act creates a being commonly referred to as angel kind; the free will of such individuals becomes focused down a preferred thought pattern. Limiting the change such exponents of the faith are able to implement upon the perception of the deity.

And so a priesthood, stand not only to assist in the continued empowerment of a deity but also to reinforce the manner in which it is perceived. For without a priesthood and thus without a renewable source of perception circumstances begin to grow grim for deities.

Dying for the Truth

Divine Guidance

Can gods die? A question with two basic answers and one that is not conclusively proved either way. However if we accept that perception of a deity, grant it power to exist. Then we must accept that actually killing a deity is near impossible.

Despite the power that understanding the truth brings however it is possible to seriously harm a deity. Given that they require faith to survive, removing the source of that faith will greatly impact upon its power. Though even killing all the priests of a deity is unlikely to destroy it completely.

Consider Shaeahan goddess of mercy, even if her priests were to be removed and her name forgotten. The natural pockets of peace would certainly provide enough perception to continue her sustained existence. The power of the deity would diminish considerably but she would still live.

In theory it should be possible to kill the personality of a god, such as in the recent case of the deity Morgoth, the personality was destroyed and the power subsumed by

Valasius.

The most recent mass deaths (or rather apparent deaths) of deities occurred during the War of Names. During this event Deities from one of the major possible future timelines, gained access to the past via a temporal rift. Opened by one of the Masters of Primus.

Within this timeline the deities had been "forgotten" and their priesthoods dispersed. They had survived by consuming the natural perception. However the chance to reform a priesthood in the past led them through the temporal rift to challenge their past selves

The resulting war saw several deities "die" though whether that was simply death of the personality and transferral of power or an unconscious (or conscious choice in two cases) to simply pass on is unclear.

The War of Names also highlighted one of the true limitations of the gods; it seems that even they are bound by the universal constant of time.

Limitations and Weaknesses of the Divine...

It seems that even in comprehension of the One Truth a will is limited on the effect it is able to have on reality to some degree. The war of Names as noted above showed us that it is impossible for the same will to occupy the same portion of reality, thus causing the need for War between the gods.

It also showed us that Time while manipulatable to some degree by deities has certain laws that even they are unable to break.

While it is possible to assume that the limitations of the divine are caused by universal constant it is more likely that the combined perceptive will of the infinite mortal minds that inhabit the material planes is ultimately a force even stronger than the will of a deity.

Putting the subject of a deity's weakness to a mortal worshipper or a peon will of course immediately receive a negative response, but as scholars we must attempt to comprehend the weaknesses that can be present even in creatures as powerful as deities.

Ultimately it is clear that a deity's weakness is rarely

physical or related to the supernatural force they are able to bring to bare. At least from a mortal perspective. Deities are in the main unkillable and have an inexhaustible supply of supernatural power to draw upon. To challenge a deity in such a manner would be foolish.

Deity's inherent weaknesses come from the manner in which they are forced to exist. By this I refer to the tunnelling of their natures, and there reliance upon continued perception and faith.

Perhaps a mortal's greatest weapon against the divine is a knowledge of the thought process the deity will follow. Once you understand the actions the creature will take then one may plan a course of action by which a deities hand is forced.

It is also possible to target the perception of that deity and thus force change upon it in a way that it may not wish. Ultimately however opposing the will of a deity is an inadvisable course of action, and if required should be approached with extreme caution.

Classifying Deities

Those who spend time contemplating the nature of deities have come to believe that certain variants exist.

A side note of interest is that it is rarely priests who contemplate the nature of their deities, but rather those unconnected to deities at all.

Broadly Gods can be divided into three categories.

Gods, Demigods, and Immortals.

Gods

Creatures who have achieved true and encompassing understanding of the one truth. Their power and purpose stretches beyond the ability of the mortal mind to define.

Gods can further be divided into two sub categories

anthropomorphic personifications, and Ascended mortals. The majority of this document has spoken of gods in the terms easily equitable to Ascended mortals.

Let us consider for a moment the anthropomorphic personification. A good example of such a creature is the God Talthar. Never having been mortal the deity has evolved from the concept of hope.

The application of a single truth theory does encounter certain difficulties at this point, because the mortal mind has some difficulty accepting that a concept is able to reach an understanding of another concept. I would rather postulate that such a creature is already part of the concept of the single truth, and its evolution is a natural extension of its growth in power as it is perceived by a wider and wider section of mortals.

Demigods

These creatures are as diverse as they are many, their background are likewise varied. Many are created to fulfill specific roles by a true god. A limited number of more powerful mercenaries are now falling into this category, as their respective deities place more and more power within them.

Immortals

This group of beings provide us perhaps the most interesting set of creatures for study. Two distinct categories are found in this classification. Totem Spirits, and the Primal Deities.

Totem Spirits

Totem Spirits present an interesting dilemma for "civilised" races once again have difficulty in understanding how a creature of animalistic values is able to grasp the one truth.

While opinion on the matter is divided I believe that rather than understanding the truth Totems represent the place of natural order within that truth and are thus part of the truth itself.

Primal Deities

The phenomenon of Primal Deities is of great interest. It is my belief that such creatures are not deities in the truest sense of the word. While they are able to display exceptional power, including the traits inherent within deities to consume faith and grant power. The Primal Deities are definable within mortal perception.

It is this difference that sets them apart from other such creatures. Let us take for example the creature Asa Volki. He can be defined both in terms of realm, Scope of faith and power. This vital difference makes them unique within my studies to date.

I would postulate that these creatures are not gods as such. In that they do not possess an understanding of the Truth. This sets them apart in certain ways. It curtails their powers greatly, and yet it allows mortals to perceive them whole and thus they may coexist with mortals upon the material planes. The power of these creatures however can not be underestimated, and if it does not come from an understanding of the truth. We must consider where it comes from.

To understand this we need to look carefully at the nature of primus and understand the nature of power flowing through it. The nature of Primus is worthy of a second document dedicated to the subject, but for now we must simply accept that faith, belief, perception, call it what you will, flows up from the material planes below it and power flows downward from the higher planes above.

This faith and power can become trapped in the fabric of primus causing pools of both power and faith to become accessible. It is this power that such primal deities tap to empower themselves and their priesthood.

While discussing the calcifications of deities it is worth also contemplating the nature of various forces and how they fit into the structure.

By forces I refer to such creatures as the Mana Dragons

and the personifications of nature, of indeed simply Nature itself. The perception of these forces varies wildly from the perception of deities however there place within the concept of the One Truth bares comment.

The concept of nature as a force is perhaps the oldest form of organised perception. When a creature capable of thought is introduced into an alien environment, it immediately begins to perceive that environment, and attempt to understand it. While natural laws may vary from plane to plane. The perception of the environment will generate belief and thus power. While Nature itself does not comprehend the truth, it in a similar manner to the Primal Deities is a source of power that may be drawn upon.

Importantly however power gained over nature of one plane of existence in this way is not always compatible with the environmental power generated on other planes of existence.

An interesting example of this can be seen in the mercenary named Marik Custodius. The individual has become so dependant upon the power generated within the primal environment that when the subject is removed from it and placed in an alien environment the subject begins to degenerate, at a relatively rapid pace.

This is the major difference between nature and ascended deities. A deity understands the Truth, the Truth is universal and thus its power is applied universally. Nature is specific to its environment and thus not consistently transferable.

The Mana Dragons again present an interesting variant worthy of note. They are similar in many ways to deities, though opinion is divided over their origins. Are they creatures born, that grow into an understanding of the truth, or a portion of it? Or are they anthropomorphic personifications of portions of the truth.

The interesting variation dragons present is not based upon their understanding of the truth, but rather their focus. As noted earlier Deities seem to become focused upon particular viewpoints. Yet even so the power they grant is often diverse.

Dragons however are focused even beyond the nature of deities the powers offered to those who are able to tap them are almost uniform in their nature.

In addition to this Dragons are not dependant on faith for their power nor are they subject to the whims of perception altering that power.

It is my belief that rather than understanding the truth Dragons are manifestations of the truth. Viewed in a manner by which mortals are able to comprehend study and tap them.

In theory therefore Deities would also be able to tap the forces perceived by mortals as the mana dragons. Perhaps going some way to explaining the "mancer" phenomenon. And reasons for the wide spectrum of empowerment displayed in the limited recorded instances of direct divine engagement.

Calendar of Holy Days

Date	Name	Details
1 st Januar	Inceptus Majius	All Powers High Shadow Day
1 st Januar	The Day of Awakening	Talthari Renewal Holy Day
3 rd Januar	The Festival of Mortal Light	Tryst Shadow Day
15 th Januar	Winter Barrows Opening	Elbereth Shadow Day
17 th Januar	Winter's Heart	Druidic Shadow Day
20 th Januar	Shaedwaith	Condesecration Shadow Day
21 st Januar	Winter's Heart	Druidic Shadow Day
25 th Januar	Day of Cerilian Winter	Azrai Holy Day
31 st Januar	Up-helly-naa	Triune Holy / Shadow Day
1 st Februar	Day of Tears	Tsu Ling Shadow Day
1 st Februar	Elemental Lord's Day	Draconic Church of Earth Holy Day
4 th Februar	Day of the Madness	Talthari Serenity Shadow Day
9 th Februar	The Awakening of Totems	Shamanic Shadowday
9 th Februar	Warming Over	Draconic Church of Seasons Holy Day
10 th Februar	Sharing The Bounty	Elbereth Holy Day
20 th Februar	Day Of Awakening	Disciples of the Bright Lady Holy Day
20 th Februar	Reformation Day	Shaehan High Holy Day
1 st Martius	Faith's Day	St Michael Holy Day
5 th Martius	Day of Family	Tsu-Ling Holy Day
12 th Martius	Remembrance	Temple of the Rose Holy Day
15 th Martius	Day of Rebirth	Triune Holy Day
15 th Martius	The Shadowed Herald	Tryst Holy Day
23 rd Martius	The Awakening	Sword Knight Holy Day
26 th Martius	Day of the Fractuting	Talthari Unity Shadow Day
1 st Aiprus	Day of Tears	St Michael Shadow Day
1 st Aiprus	Asiet	Temple of the Rose True Holy Day
13 th Aiprus	Night of Deismaar	Azrai Holy Day
15 th Aiprus	Breeze Day	Dragon of Air Holy Day
17 th Aiprus	Day of the Fallen Hero	Talthari Adversity Shadow Day
23 rd Aiprus	Ascension of St Michael	St Michael True Holy Day
1 st Maii	The Day of Tides	Tsu Ling High Holy Day
1 st Maii	Festival of Natural Life	Druidic High Holy Day
1 st Maii	The Day of Hope	Talthar High Holy Day
10 th Maii	Gelnaroth	Condesecration High Holy Day
13 th Maii	Saladin's Day	St Michael Holy Day
26 th Maii	The Birth of Elven Worship	Elbereth True Holy Day
28 th Maii	The Dusk of Deception	Ebony Faithful Holy Day
28 th Maii	Spring Vigil	Temple of the Rose Shadow Day
29 th Maii	Hatching of the Earth	Dragon of Earth Holy Day
3 rd Juon	Illumination Day	Shaehan Holy Day
15 th Juon	Summer Barrows Opening	Elbereth Shadow Day
17 th Juon	Day of Gifting	Dragon of Air Shadow Day
21 st Juon	The Day of Gifts	Talthari Subtlety Holy Day
23 rd Juon	Faer-Dagaeum	Tryst Holy Day
27 th Juon	Candle Day	Unity Holy Day
7 th Jurrle	Day of Cerilian Summer	Azrai Shadow Day
15 th Jurrle	Thunder's Peak	Dragon of Air Holy Day
20 th Jurrle	Virnaroth	Condesecration True Holy Day
28 th Jurrle	The Night of Cloaking	Ebony True Holy Day
1 st Orgus	The Day of Drought	Tsu Ling Shadow Day
7 th Orgus	Remembrance Secundus	Temple of the Rose Holy Day
15 th Orgus	Draconic Harvest Day	Dragon of Earth Holy Day
17 th Orgus	Kelnaroth	Condesecration Holy Day
24 th Orgus	Celebration of the Constellations	Elbereth Holy Day
27 th Orgus	Summer Vigil	Temple of the Rose Shadow Day
1 st Septus	Ebon Eclipse	Ebony Holy Day
3 rd Septus	Justice Day	St Michael Holy Day
15 th Septus	The Dark Dawn Festival	Tryst True Holy Day
17 th Septus	Fulcrum of Shadows	Azrai Holy Day
21 st Septus	Taunest Serie	Temple of the Rose Holy Day
1 st Octuar	Contemplation of Shaehan	Shaehan High Holy Day
1 st Octuar	Spritael Dagaeum	Tryst Shadow Day

Divine Guidance

Date	Name	Details
10 th Octuar	The Sorrow of Loss	Condesceration Shadowday
10 th Octuar	Aranal's Day	Talthari Diplomacy Holy Day
13 th Octuar	Shamanistra	Shamanic High Holy Day
17 th Octuar	Islani's Tears	Talthari Diplomacy Shadow Day
30 th Octuar	Festival of Encircling Shadow	Dragon of Darkness True Holy Day
31 st Octuar	Holy Eve	Triune Maiden Holy / Triune Mother Shadow Day
31 st Octuar	The Joining of Worlds	Servants of Evil Holy Day
1 st Novaus	The Day of Ocean's Renewal	Tsu Ling Holy Day
5 th Novaus	Day of Shadows	St Michael Shadow Day
5 th Novaus	Raseens Birthday	Azrai Holy Day
7 th Novaus	Storm's Fall	Dragon of Air High holy Day
9 th Novaus	The Dreaming Day	Shamanic Shadow Day
19 th Novaus	Turning of the Stars	Elbereth Holy Day
1 st Deeber	Sealing the Gates of Accounting	Redaip Shadow Day
4 th Deeber	Illuminous Dawn	Ebony Shadow Day
21 st Deeber	Longest Night	All Powers True Shadow Day
23 rd Deeber	White Ivories Morn	Ebony Holy Day

Miscellaneous Holy Days

What follows is a list of recognised Holy Days and Shadow days attributed to powers not covered elsewhere in this tome.

1st Januar ~ Inceptus Majius [All Powers High Shadow Day]

It was on this day, so many years ago that a possibly mythical event created all power within Primus and it's surrounding territories. This day is a high shadow day for all powers, as gods, dragons and other powers bow their heads in respect for the very creation of what gave birth to them - power.

21st Januar ~ Winters Heart [Druidic Shadow Day]

This day symbolises the low point for natural life, snow covers the ground and there are no leaves on the trees. It is considered bad luck to leave open a door on this day, allowing the winter frost into the hearth of the house bringing ill luck for the year. Many rural families spend this day behind locked doors, though druids should perform rites calling to the Spring warmth.

31st Januar ~ Up-helly-naa [Triune Mother Holy Day/Maiden Shadow Day]

The feast of fire, symbolising the end of winter and the beginning of spring, when the fires that have burned all winter are fed with extra fuel to encourage the sun to warm the earth anew.

1st Day of Februar ~ Elemental Lord's Day [Dragon of Earth Holy Day]

The Day that the Dragon Lords became a power in the Empire. This day is shrouded in mystical rites and ceremony known only to a very few.

1st Day of Plague Season ~ Day of Flowering [Talthari Adversity Holy Day]

15th Martius ~ Day of Rebirth [Triune Holy Day]

When the souls of dead family members are closest to the earth. Places are set for them at table, and many women try to conceive at this time, hoping that the spirits of those they have lost will be reborn in their children.

15th Aiprus ~ Breezeday [Dragon of Air Holy Day]

It was upon this day an alliance was formed between the Imps of Slumber and the Dragon of Air.

1st Day of Mai ~ Festival of Natural Life [Druidic True Holy Day]

Often just referred to as the Festival of Life this date celebrates the re-establishment of Life within the natural world. Mostly celebrated in rural areas, there is a feast on the green, followed by games and the crowning in a floral garland of the queen and king of the year. It is rumoured that druids must perform a secret rite to ensure a good harvest for the coming year on this date. This day is blessed with fertility.

28th Maii ~ The Dusk of Deception [Ebony Holy Day]

As the day draws on, ancient suppressed powers of deception, bound to serve the Ebony Drake with long forgotten pacts, flow into the followers of the drake of deception.

29th Maii ~ Hatching Day of Earth [Dragon of Earth High Holy Day]

This day celebrates the hatching of the Brown Dragon of Magic

31st Maii ~ Preceptus Imperium [Imperial Holiday]

This day, following the end of the Chaos war, Emperor Cerus Amora left his protective wardings and declared the area of lands now known as Labyrinthia as to be his Empire. The development to completion of the Feudal Republic took a few more years to conclude.

1st Weekend of Sunner Season ~ Coming Together [Talthari Unity Holy Day]

17th Juon ~ Day of Gifting [The Dragon of Air Shadow Day]

This is the day when Dragons gift power to the Grey Dragon, and the Blue Dragon is proud to make a small offering to it's cousin in return for access to it's spells for his followers.

Divine Guidance

Longest Day of the Year ~ The Day of Purity [Talthari Justice Holy Day]

28th Jurrle ~ The Night Of Cloaking [Ebony True Holy Day]

The greatest trick of 'Coragha', the Ebony Drake, was to send his Ivory sister into a deep slumber for five months, upon the anniversary of this day. Since then each year upon this date Coragha is able to draw much power from the Ivory Drake. It is also rumoured that upon this day Darkbane, once a notorious Ebony mage, was born.

15th Orgus ~ Dr aconic Harvest Day [Dragon of Earth Holy Day]

This day the harvest is celebrated by the Draconic Church of Earth, as it's master yields it's bounty to those who till the soil.

1st Day of Harvest Season ~ Coming Together [Talthari Unity Holy Day]

1st Septus ~ Ebon Eclipse [Ebony Faithful Holy Day]

Truth and illumination are sent into retreat as the ebon moon rises over the land. Upon this day the powers of communing are twisted and confused as the Ebony Drake's influence is magnified.

30th Octuar ~ Festival of Encircling Shadow [Dragon of Night True Holy Day]

This special day marks a celebration of many of the ideals that the Draconic Church of Darkness holds dear, it also is close to the end of summer time and the turning point in the yearly battle between night and day.

31st Octuar Holy Eve [Triune (Maiden Holy Day, Mother Shadow Day)]

The Day when the land of the dead is closest to this world, and those whose ties to life are weak are most likely to lose their hold on life.

7th Novaus ~ Storm's Fall [Dragon of Air Holy Day]

Celebrates the arrival of winter storms and the season of the Air Dragons most destructive power.

Last Sunday of Novaus ~ Day of Searching [Talthari Serenity Holy Day]

4th Deeber ~ Illuminous Dawn [Ebony Shadowday]

The anniversary of the awakening of the Ivory Drake, after 'The Night Of Cloaking'. Well rested, she sends her arch foes followers into hiding. This day is also rumoured to be the anniversary of 'Darkbane's' final death.

21st Deeber ~ Longest Night [All Powers True Shadow Day]

The longest night of the year grants more time in the moons grace for those creatures, which would stalk the land, feeding from the citizens of the Empire. On this day the lay folk lie low, and mercenaries cannot move without demands for their services in fighting the undead and servants of black magic. It was also on this day that The Labyrinthian Emperor Michael I was crowned in the 2nd Age IM999. Perhaps not the most auspicious start, and may well have had something to do with the rumours that a dead man was ruling the Empire!

23rd Deeber ~ Whiteivories Morn [Ebony Faithful Shadow Day]

*Dazzling truths send the ebony drakes followers into retreat, as the ivory drake shows her followers the true path.....
.....It is whispered that this day is entirely the fault of a dragon known as 'Bluebottle'*

Credits

Many thanks to those who submitted information that helped to make up the entries within this tome. Special thanks to those below.

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Rhys Jones, 44
Simon Morgan, 32
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